

BEYOND SEXuality



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BEYOND THE COUCH

Introduction

This book is about sexuality at the end of the twentieth century and about the discourse that has made sexuality central to our understanding of who and what we are—psychoanalysis. Although psychoanalytic practice and, indeed, most sexual practices take place largely on the couch, I am more interested in what happens beyond the couch. In the pages that follow, I devote my attention to how psychoanalysis and sexuality function in social and cultural domains, rather than in strictly individual or clinical settings. I find Jacques Lacan's theory of the symbolic order particularly useful for this enterprise, in part because it makes fully evident how the private, individual realm of subjectivity ultimately cannot be separated from the public realm of social life.¹ To condense an argument I develop in greater detail below, let me just say that Lacan theorizes the subject as coming into being only by way of *the Other*, a term he uses to designate not other persons or disenfranchised groups, but cultural systems of meaning.

By theorizing this inseparability of subject and Other, Lacan also indicates where and how psychoanalysis departs from psychology. "[P]sychology is itself an error of perspective on the human being," he

1. In a recent article, Lauren Berlant and Michael Warner treat as axiomatic for queer theory the notion that "there is nothing more public than privacy," though they decline to develop in a psychoanalytic direction what I take to be their fundamentally Lacanian insight. See Lauren Berlant and Michael Warner, "Sex in Public," *Critical Inquiry* 24 (1998): 547–66.

remarks (*SI* 278). In pushing psychoanalysis beyond psychology, Lacan also pushes it beyond the couch—that is, beyond a framework comprising specific interactions between persons. And hence Lacan’s account of symbolic subjectivity contributes more to social theory than to psychological theories of the individual. Part of Lacan’s challenge—but also his fascination—for an English-speaking audience lies in this impulse toward outmoding the individual as a tenable category of analysis.

2 I will have more to say about this later, but I want to make clear from the outset that when I refer to psychoanalysis I mean a specific tradition of speculative thought that begins with Freud and is developed by Lacan, Jean Laplanche, and others. This Continental psychoanalytic tradition remains quite distinct from—and is often antithetical to—the various American traditions of psychoanalytic empiricism, which historically have harnessed Freudianism to an ideological project of boosting individualism rather than questioning it. My claims on behalf of psychoanalysis should be read with this distinction in mind, especially since one of this book’s aims is to generate a sharper perspective on psychoanalysis by rendering it less rather than more recognizable. In other words, I intend to clarify current debates—ranging from the “sex wars” to the “Freud wars”—by defamiliarizing psychoanalysis, making it new. Given that we inhabit a therapeutical culture whose effects are more often debilitating than beneficial, I want to show how psychoanalysis is less an inevitable part of the world we live in—with its television trash-talk shows and its relentless psychologizing of all relationships—than a genuine alternative to that world.²

In intellectual circles, the alternative perspective offered by my psychoanalytic tradition has largely been neglected in favor of a philosophically oriented political challenge to psychological theories of sexuality that is attributable to Michel Foucault. Foucault argues that sexuality must be understood not psychologically but historically—and, specifically, discursively—in terms of the overarching deployment of what he calls biopower, as distinct from juridical power. Foucault’s concept of biopower separates our understanding of sex from law and repres-

2. Here I find myself in sympathy with John Forrester’s caustic remark that “[n]ot only does everyone know what Freud wrote and what everything Freudian ‘really means,’ everyone also knows what all the fuss is really about. So the process of writing about Freud must always be one of uneducating one’s readers” (*Dispatches from the Freud Wars: Psychoanalysis and Its Passions* [Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1997], 12).

sion, emphasizing instead how the category of sexuality is used to create subjective effects by molding bodies and regulating erotic practices.³ In the sense that Foucault too is concerned with sex primarily beyond the couch, my project could be described as Foucaultian. Indeed, Foucault concurs with Lacan in the effort to move beyond psychology, affirming, in *Madness and Civilization*, that “[i]t is not psychology that is involved in psychoanalysis: but precisely an experience of unreason that it has been psychology’s meaning, in the modern world, to mask.”⁴ From this point of view, psychoanalysis represents not so much a subdivision of the larger discipline of psychology, but a demystification of that field’s assumptions and procedures.

Yet in spite of the valuable perspective on sexuality that it furnishes—and in spite of this observation in *Madness and Civilization*—Foucault’s critique ends up reobscuring distinctions between psychoanalysis and psychology, as well as between psychoanalysis and psychiatry. In order to conceptualize sexuality *beyond* psychology, it is crucial to elaborate rather than glossing over the fundamental incompatibilities between the Continental psychoanalytic tradition, on one hand, and psychological—even psychiatric—canons of thought, on the other. My effort throughout this book to understand sexuality outside the terms of the ego, the individual, or the self culminates in my final chapter’s discussion of the impersonality of desire. Thus rather than abandoning categories of sexuality and desire in favor of those of bodies and pleasures, as Foucault advocated, I try to show the steps necessary for thinking about sexuality and desire in different, less psychological terms.

In so doing, I am preoccupied less by Foucault’s own relation to psychoanalysis or its status in his work (issues that have received admirable treatment elsewhere)⁵ than by his widespread influence on subse-

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3. Michel Foucault, *The History of Sexuality*, vol. 1, *An Introduction*, trans. Robert Hurley (New York: Random House, 1978).

4. Michel Foucault, *Madness and Civilization: A History of Insanity in the Age of Reason*, trans. Richard Howard (New York: Random House, 1965), 198. According to his recent editors, Althusser attributed to Lacan the rigorous distinguishing of psychoanalysis from psychology. See Louis Althusser, *Writings on Psychoanalysis: Freud and Lacan*, ed. Olivier Corpet and François Matheron, trans. Jeffrey Mehlman (New York: Columbia University Press, 1996), 4.

5. See especially Jacques Derrida, “‘To Do Justice to Freud’: The History of Madness in the Age of Psychoanalysis,” trans. Pascale-Anne Brault and Michael Naas, *Critical Inquiry* 20 (1994): 227–66; Jacques-Alain Miller, “Michel Foucault and Psychoanalysis,” in *Michel Foucault, Philosopher*, ed. and trans. Timothy J. Armstrong (London: Harvester Wheatsheaf, 1992), 58–64; and, most recently, Christopher Lane, *The Burdens of Intimacy: Psychoanalysis and Victorian Masculinity* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1999), 12–26.

quent accounts of sexuality, particularly those generated from within feminism, gay studies, and, most recently, queer theory. These progressive theories of sexuality form part of that school of thought known as social constructionism; they tend to either assimilate psychoanalysis to an essentially Foucaultian epistemology or repudiate it as an avatar of the ahistorical, universalizing view of sexuality that social constructionism rightly sets out to dismantle. Thus by way of amiable hermeneutic domestication, on one hand, or misguided rejection, on the other, what is most valuable about psychoanalysis disappears completely.

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This is not so much Foucault's fault as that of the Anglo-American reception of Foucault *and* of Lacan. What happened to Freud in the United States has also been happening to his French successors. Transatlantic enthusiasm for these Continental thinkers has gone hand in hand with caricaturing and ultimately defanging them. Indeed, the concept of sexuality remains as much the sticking point now as it was ninety years ago, when Freud first traveled to America, to speak at Clark University, in 1909. In order to rethink sexuality, I expend much of my energy on disentangling psychoanalysis from its proponents and detractors alike, hoping that the distinctness of psychoanalysis may fall into greater relief. If in pursuing this metacritical project I sometimes appear too harshly critical of scholars I debate, I can say only that I'm interested in maintaining neither Lacanian orthodoxy nor what increasingly appears to be a Foucault-inspired antipsychoanalytic orthodoxy, but in confounding both.

Toward this end, I articulate a psychoanalytic theory of sexuality with a gay critique of psychoanalysis, not only to show their respective limits, but, more fundamentally, to push both to a new place. I consider it necessary to stake out a new position by way of the series of critiques that follows because the terms currently available for discussing sexuality—generally comprehended under the rubric of essentialism versus constructionism—represent false alternatives, and therefore they continue to mislead us in both theory and practice. Attempting to formulate an account of sexuality that is neither essentialist nor constructionist—and mounting a critique of Foucaultian positions in queer theory, as well as of certain sacred cows in Lacanian theory—I am aware that I risk alienating all parties in these debates. This risk seems to me unavoidable given the current state of sexuality and sexual practices at this *fin de siècle*. My efforts in this book are based on the assumption

that the dawning historical perspective afforded by AIDS requires a fundamental reconceptualization of sexuality and its place in our lives. In my view, psychoanalysis still holds an untapped potential for assisting with this reconceptualization.

Sexuality and the Unconscious

The longstanding gay critique of Freud is right to decry institutionalized psychoanalysis's blind spots vis-à-vis same-sex object-choice, yet wrong to conclude from this history of institutional oppression that Freudian thought offers nothing but trouble for lesbians and gay men. This skeptical attitude toward psychoanalysis is neatly encapsulated in a wonderful line from Mark Merlis's debut novel, *American Studies* (about closeted Harvard literary critic F. O. Matthiessen's undoing in the McCarthy era), in which the narrator declares, "Of course I have never actually read Freud and so am prepared to dismiss him as readily as any other right-thinking faggot."⁶ From this point of view, hostility toward psychoanalysis remains a sign of allegiance, a necessary credential for one's political identity as lesbian or gay. And even though this political view is currently being challenged by lesbian and gay psychoanalysts, therapists, and the more progressive elements of our mental health establishment, the terms of this challenge invariably remain those of minority rights—and hence of personhood. In other words, when North American analysts argue—against their homophobic colleagues, led by Charles Socarides—that it's OK to be gay, they do so on nonpsychoanalytic grounds, insisting that, as the editors of *Disorienting Sexuality* put it, "both sexuality and gender are historical constructions which serve to create boundaries between what is forbidden and allowable, defining both deviance and normality."⁷ While it is necessary to acknowledge

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6. Mark Merlis, *American Studies* (New York: Houghton Mifflin, 1994), 40.

7. Thomas Domenici and Ronnie C. Lesser, introduction to *Disorienting Sexuality: Psychoanalytic Reappraisals of Sexual Identities*, ed. Domenici and Lesser (New York: Routledge, 1995), 9. The following characterization of their project by the editors of this important volume seems to me accurate:

This book is an attempt by lesbian, gay, and heterosexual psychoanalysts to reshape the psychoanalytic discourse on sexuality in a new image. The shared vision of each author is one which respects diversity, does not privilege one form of sexuality over another, confronts the uses of categorization, hierarchization, and the use of the "abnormal" within psychoanalytic theory, is suspicious of the power plays which underlie essentialist assumptions, and views gay, lesbian, and heterosexual identities as historical and cultural productions. Rooted in the gay, lesbian, and feminist movements, Foucauldian

that any sustained attempt by North American clinicians to consolidate a nonpathologizing discourse about homosexuality represents a historically significant step in the right direction, regrettably these psychoanalysts seem unable to formulate this affirmative discourse in anything but standard Foucaultian terms.

As several commentators on *Disorienting Sexuality* have noted, approaching sexuality by way of Foucault tends to minimize consideration of the unconscious. British psychoanalyst Joanna Ryan observes:

Notions of the fluidity of identities, of diversity, of erotic flexibility and mobility, are all important in helping us listen to and understand the experiences and conflicts of patients without imposing rigid presuppositions or pathologizing categories. But they are not themselves elaborated psychoanalytic concepts, and it is easy to feel that [in *Disorienting Sexuality*] they are being made to take more weight than they can bear. They do not alone speak to and of the unconscious (although they could). Furthermore, they can just as easily become normative requirements or reified concepts themselves, albeit of a different kind.⁸

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Ryan raises a number of issues that I pursue in *Beyond Sexuality*, particularly the question of norms and normativity in psychoanalysis. Given Foucault's argument that modern power functions less through repressive force than through techniques of normalization, the problem of psychoanalysis's role in normalizing sexual expression remains vitally pressing. Since I consider this question at length in my final chapter, I want to focus here on the category of the unconscious.

Extrapolating from Ryan's comments, I suggest that any theory of nonnormative sexuality is extremely difficult to sustain without a psychoanalytic, depsychologized understanding of the unconscious. In other words, without an appreciation of the unconscious, queer sexualities themselves become normalizing (paradoxical though that sounds), insofar as sexuality becomes wedded to identity. Hence although *Beyond*

theory, as well as social constructivist and postmodern critiques of sexuality, the views presented in this book, however, are not monolithic. (6)

See also Adria E. Schwartz, *Sexual Subjects: Lesbians, Gender, and Psychoanalysis* (New York: Routledge, 1997).

8. Joanna Ryan, "Reflections on *Disorienting Sexuality*," *Gender and Psychoanalysis* 2 (1997): 182. This journal contains a cluster of responses and counterresponses to the essays collected in *Disorienting Sexuality*; see, in particular, Donald Moss's "Disorienting Sexuality: A Commentary," 185–90.

Sexuality criticizes identitarian claims within the arena of sexual politics, it does so differently than Foucaultian critiques of identity politics. My argument that any theory of nonnormative sexuality collapses without a psychoanalytic concept of the unconscious makes sense only once we distinguish what we mean by the unconscious from its conventional resonances of interiority, mental depth, and chthonic powers.

Lacan depsychologizes the unconscious by treating it as linguistic and thus as transindividual: "The unconscious is that part of the concrete discourse, in so far as it is transindividual, that is not at the disposal of the subject in re-establishing the continuity of his conscious discourse" (E 49). With respect to its transindividuality, Lacan's sense of the unconscious requires distinguishing from Jung's collective unconscious—the assemblage of archetypes that Jung considered transhistorical. In direct contrast to Jung, Lacan identifies the unconscious as thoroughly historical, both conceptually and for the subject: "What we teach the subject to recognize as his unconscious is his history" (E 52). Lacan specifies this further, adding that "[t]he unconscious is that chapter of my history that is marked by a blank or occupied by a falsehood: it is the censored chapter" (E 50). On the face of it, this alignment of the unconscious with a subjective history may seem utterly conventional. But Lacan's emphasis on language—specifically, his attention to the symbolic inscription of historical events significant for the subject—reorients this standard view of the unconscious as referring simply to the patient's history, childhood memories, and so on. By emphasizing that the censored chapter of my history "has already been written down elsewhere," Lacan reinterprets that "other scene"—the *andere Schauplatz* Freud speaks of when describing the unconscious—in terms not of more or less private mental space, but of public discourse, the symbolic domain of language and culture, which is necessarily transindividual yet also historical.⁹ Hence his insistence that "[t]he subject is as such historicised from one end to the other" (SII 255).

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9. Lacan anatomizes this "elsewhere," this other scene where the censored chapter of my history has already been inscribed:

- in monuments: this is my body. That is to say, the hysterical nucleus of the neurosis in which the hysterical symptom reveals the structure of a language, and is deciphered like an inscription which, once recovered, can without serious loss be destroyed;
- in archival documents: these are my childhood memories, just as impenetrable as are such documents when I do not know their provenance;
- in semantic evolution: this corresponds to the stock of words and acceptations of my particular vocabulary, as it does to my style of life and to my character;

3 The question of what psychoanalysis means by “history”—and of what Lacan means by the imperative to historicize—is too complex to pursue here.¹⁰ Suffice it to say that the psychoanalytic tradition I discuss in this book remains far from indifferent to history and historical explanations, despite what many critics charge. The common dismissal of psychoanalysis *tout court* on the basis of its ahistoricism seems to me unwarranted, even though it isn’t hard to find flagrant examples of psychoanalytic insensitivity to cultural and historical difference. In chapter 1, I discuss some methodological issues concerning the relationship between psychoanalysis and historicism, since I want to lay out from the start the principal stakes of employing psychoanalytic categories for cultural study. In that chapter, I argue against the historicist reduction of psychoanalytic concepts to the circumstances of their historical emergence; but I also want to indicate at this point that Lacan views the unconscious as a historically determined concept:

[O]ne should see in the unconscious the effects of speech on the subject—in so far as these effects are so radically primary that they are properly what determine the status of the subject as subject. This proposition was intended to restore the Freudian unconscious to its true place. Certainly, the unconscious has always been present, it existed and acted before Freud, but it is important to stress that all the acceptations given, before Freud, to this function of the unconscious have absolutely nothing to do with the Freudian unconscious.

The primal unconscious, the unconscious as archaic function, the unconscious as veiled presence of a thought to be placed at the level of being before it is revealed, the metaphysical unconscious . . . above all the unconscious as instinct—all this has nothing to do with the Freudian unconscious, nothing at all. (*Four* 126)

—in traditions, too, and even in the legends which, in a heroicized form, bear my history;

—and, lastly, in the traces that are inevitably preserved by the distortions necessitated by the linking of the adulterated chapter to the chapters surrounding it, and whose meaning will be re-established by my exegesis. (*E* 50)

10. The best discussion of this question may be found in Joan Copjec, *Read My Desire: Lacan against the Historicists* (Cambridge: MIT Press, 1994). See also Charles Shepherdson, “History and the Real: Foucault with Lacan,” in *Rhetoric in an Antifoundational World: Language, Culture, and Pedagogy*, ed. Richard R. Glejzer and Michael F. Bernard-Donals (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1998), 292–317.

Lacan's claim is that when we think about the concept of the unconscious historically, we find that Freud means something fundamentally different by this term *unconscious* than those who preceded him. Furthermore, though it is commonplace to observe that in the twentieth century Freudian categories have so thoroughly permeated our culture that it is almost impossible to think without them, I maintain that in certain crucial respects we still use the idea of the unconscious in an essentially pre-Freudian sense, coining it as a psychological category. Lacan is at pains to demonstrate that the Freudian unconscious is neither psychological nor strictly cultural, but something else entirely. In taking a conceptual term with widespread currency—the *unconscious*—and making it inextricable from sexuality, Freud fundamentally altered the meaning of both sexuality and the unconscious. It is for this reason that in a project devoted to thinking differently—I might even say thinking queerly—about sexuality, I regard it as indispensable to meditate on this concept of the unconscious.

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Trying to specify a genuinely psychoanalytic concept of the unconscious, I have become increasingly aware how this basic Freudian idea constantly threatens to dissolve into something more recognizably psychological—even in the works of psychoanalysts themselves. Both Lacan and Laplanche have argued, in different ways, that Freud represses the most radical dimension of his own discovery—specifically, that his tripartite model of the mind (ego, id, superego), which replaces the earlier topographic and dynamical conceptions of the unconscious, effectively institutes a repression within psychoanalytic theory itself.¹¹ In other words, the Continental psychoanalytic tradition tends to regard Freud's substitution of one model of mind for another in psychical, rather than purely epistemological, terms. Far from compromising psychoanalysis's legitimacy, however, Freud's repression or forgetting of his own conceptual innovation paradoxically substantiates what is, after all, an empirically unverifiable discovery.

Lacan takes this evanescent quality of the unconscious as essential rather than accidental in his understanding of it, describing the unconscious in terms of temporal pulsation (*Four* 123–48). His idea that the unconscious may be registered only as it disappears, in the moment of

11. For this view of Freudian theory, see in particular Jean Laplanche, *Life and Death in Psychoanalysis*, trans. Jeffrey Mehlman (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1976).

its closing up, suggests just how difficult this fundamental psychoanalytic concept is to grasp. Indeed, if the Continental reading of Freud is on target in this respect, it follows that any discourse *on* the unconscious—including mine—necessarily engages an uphill task, given the elusiveness of its object. As I explain in my first chapter, Lacan's infuriating verbal style functions in part to remind his audience of this elusiveness, since unlike other concepts describing mental life, that of the unconscious resists objectification and, hence, systematization.

Why Does Freud Contradict Himself?

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Another way of framing this problem involves emphasizing the contradictions in psychoanalytic theory. It isn't only the case that Freudian theory has been misapplied by homophobic and heterosexist therapists whom we might contextualize as inevitably "products of their time"; beyond the myriad injustices perpetrated throughout the institutional history of psychoanalysis there remain fundamental problems within Freudian theory itself. Following various French readings of him, it now seems less plausible to regard Freud's inconsistencies as evidence of sloppy thinking than as signs of difficulties inherent in mental life as such. Indeed, as Derrida puts it, "[t]he contradiction is no doubt in the things themselves, so to speak."¹² If, after Freud, it is hard not to see inconsistencies in any text as significant and therefore as interpretable, the question remains how contradictions within psychoanalytic theory itself should be understood. As I have suggested, Lacan and Laplanche interpret the vagaries of Freudian thought in terms of repression, seeing in Freud's conceptual turbulence an index of conflicts fundamental to psychic life. Laplanche's reading of Freud has been pursued in more overtly deconstructive terms by Leo Bersani, who, in *The Freudian Body*, takes the contradictions as fully constitutive, arguing that Freud conceptualizes precisely those mental forces that trouble any theoretical project and thereby prevent metapsychology from realizing its ambition. Brilliantly unpacking what he describes as "the operations of a psychoanalytic textuality in consciousness itself," Bersani reads Freud for those moments of textual collapse that indicate not so much signs of repres-

12. Derrida, "To Do Justice to Freud," 251.

sion as evidence concerning the impossibility of speculative closure.¹³ In other words, for Bersani the vitality of psychoanalytic theory lies more in its internal disruptions than in its systematic conceptualization.

Much as I recognize the influence of Bersani's work on my own, I am also persuaded by Arnold I. Davidson's methodological approach to Freud, which implicitly dissents from Bersani's focus on textuality. In "How to Do the History of Psychoanalysis," Davidson provides an alternative explanation of the contradictions in Freudian thought by arguing that "[t]he hesitations and ambiguities of Freud's *Three Essays on the Theory of Sexuality* are not the result of some deconstructive indeterminacy or undecidability of the text but are rather the consequences of the dynamics of fundamental change."¹⁴ Instead of emphasizing textual disruptions in Freud, Davidson constructs an archaeology of discourses concerning what we now call sexual desire. By showing how Freud's account of sexual instinct departed from the *functional* conception of instinct that governed nineteenth-century psychiatric approaches to sexuality, Davidson argues that Freud's *Three Essays* opens a radically new conceptual space. In this properly psychoanalytic conceptual realm the notion of sexual perversion makes no sense, because sexual instinct has no predetermined object or aim. In other words, the sexual instinct as theorized by Freud is originally dysfunctional, since underdetermined by nature.

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However, Freud continued to employ the idea of sexual perversion inconsistently, as if his thinking were unable to accommodate the conceptual innovation that he himself had generated. Davidson illuminates Freud's apparent self-contradictions on this question by distinguishing between mentality and concept, two different dimensions of systems of thought. Citing developments in French historiography inspired by Foucault, Davidson explains:

Automatisms of attitude have a durability, a slow temporality, which does not match the sometimes rapid change of conceptual mutation. Mental habits have a tendency toward inertia, and these habits resist change that, in retrospect, seems conceptually required. Such

13. Leo Bersani, *The Freudian Body: Psychoanalysis and Art* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1986), 6.

14. Arnold I. Davidson, "How to Do the History of Psychoanalysis: A Reading of Freud's *Three Essays on the Theory of Sexuality*," in *The Trial(s) of Psychoanalysis*, ed. Françoise Meltzer (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1988), 63.

resistance can take place not only in a scientific community but even in the individual who is most responsible for the conceptual innovation. Freud was a product of the old mentality that regarded perversions as pathological, a mentality whose first real signs of disintegration can be found at the beginning of the twentieth century. Freud's *Three Essays* ought to have stabilized the new mentality, speeding up its entrenchment by providing it with conceptual authorization. But given the divergent temporality of the emergence of new concepts and the formation of new mentalities, it is no surprise that Freud's mental habits never quite caught up with his conceptual articulations.¹⁵

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This divergent temporality helps account for the dynamics of "fundamental change," dynamics that contextualize contradictions in Freudian theory without explaining them away or reducing them to a textual principle. I would like to see how Davidson's account of the complex dynamics entailed in a fundamental shift in sexuality's conceptualization may be applied to Lacan, as well as to Freud, since Lacan has not yet been read with anything like the sophistication devoted to Freud.

As with Freud, Lacan made conceptual innovations concerning sexuality of which he himself appears to have been only intermittently aware. Or, to adapt Teresa de Lauretis's phrasing and put the matter more pointedly, we might say that Lacan's most profound ideological and affective convictions sometimes run counter to his most brilliant critical and analytical insights.¹⁶ In this book I am critical of Lacanian positions—as well as of psychologistic and explicitly antipsychoanalytic positions—because Lacan's followers have largely failed to clarify or develop his conceptual innovations on the question of sexuality. Such failure can be explained in several ways. In the first place, as has been suggested, Lacan's Anglophone reception—by aligning his emphasis on the signifier with the poststructuralist focus on textuality, on one hand, and the historicist focus on discursivity, on the other—has tended to obscure what's most interesting and valuable in his work. From my perspective, it is what differentiates his version of psychoanalysis from

15. Ibid. Davidson develops his archaeology of perversion in "Closing Up the Corpses: Diseases of Sexuality and the Emergence of the Psychiatric Style of Reasoning," in *Homosexuality and Psychoanalysis*, ed. Tim Dean and Christopher Lane (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, forthcoming).

16. Teresa de Lauretis, *The Practice of Love: Lesbian Sexuality and Perverse Desire* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1994), 18.

the philosophical and semiotic theories emerging during the same period in France that lends Lacan his greatest command on our attention.

But the blame for domesticating Lacan does not reside with his English-speaking audience alone, as some Francophiles appear to believe. The Lacanian establishment in France also has stymied the development of his most radical ideas about sexuality, in part by trying to systematize what is not simply an unsystematic body of thought, but, more profoundly, an antisystematic one. Anglophone and Francophone normalizations of Lacan remain distinct, yet they overlap and subtly reinforce each other by imposing complementary forms of coherence on a fundamentally inchoate mode of thinking. It pays to bear in mind that for almost quarter of a century Lacan improvised seminars before a live audience; and so despite his baroque polemics and his ostensibly dogmatic manner, Lacan was never just presenting a theory or outlining a position. Even the most cursory inspection of his seminars reveals a highly mobile, dialogic mode of thinking in process—an intellectual style that we violently disrespect by making it into a theoretical edifice or system. To suggest that we pay attention to the conceptual mobility of Lacan's work—that we read him rather than translating him, irrespective of what language we're working in—doesn't mean that we cannot be lucid about psychoanalysis. On the contrary, we attain greater clarity in this matter when we attempt to follow Davidson's example and disentangle Lacanian concepts from Lacan's mentality.

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Lacan's Competing Logics

In this book I draw out two different logics from Lacan's work, one associated with his concept of the phallus, the other associated with his concept of the object; and I try to exploit the tension between them rather than harmonizing them. In my view, feminist and deconstructive critiques of the Lacanian phallus remain limited by their failure to recognize that the alternative, counterheterosexist understanding of sexuality is already implicit in Lacan's own theory, in the logic of *objet petit a*. Valuable though feminist perspectives on Lacan have been, the critique of the phallus—together with the systematizing impulse that tends to accompany any mediation of French psychoanalysis—has prevented us from appreciating more fundamental and productive contradictions internal to Lacan's own thinking. It is not so much that the phallus is

really a penis—or, in Judith Butler's reading, a dildo—as it is a giant red herring.¹⁷

Yet lest I appear unsympathetic to feminist work on Lacan, let me make clear that the impulse to stabilize psychoanalytic concepts—which is, after all, a prerequisite for launching any critique—can be explained in terms of Lacan's own style, since his notorious verbal opacity virtually compels his audience to impose forms of coherence on what tend to appear as disturbingly incoherent or sibylline utterances. By disorienting us, Lacan's words encourage us to identify some authority that would provide the coordinates to orient his reader or listener. Another way of putting this would be to say that Lacan's verbal style produces an effect of the real, a kind of trauma within his own discourse, which prompts a set of characteristic responses, both positive and negative. The positive response to this confusion entails hunting for definitions, for stable meaning, and hence beginning the process of systematizing Lacan by introducing elements of coherence into his work. This approach locates the source of authority in Lacan himself and effectively treats him as a genius uncontaminated by the ideological or material constraints that hamper the rest of us. Hence this approach leads to the construction of a psychoanalytic orthodoxy and to the Lacanist dogmatism that deters so many otherwise curious people from engaging Lacan's texts.

The negative response to the disorientation accompanying any encounter with Lacan simply inverts what I've just characterized as the positive response. Faced with Lacan's difficulty, many readers respond by locating an authority outside his work by which to negate that work. As I elaborate in chapter 1 when discussing contextualist accounts of psychoanalysis, in this negative mode of response Lacan tends to be explained away as intellectually derivative or ideologically reprehensible (and often as both). I would diagnose these positive and negative responses as essentially defensive reactions to the epistemological difficulty and rebarbative rhetoric of Lacan's work; neither mode of response, whether idealizing or demonizing, does justice to the complexity of that work.

The time has come to cease presenting Lacan as a thinker one must

17. See Judith Butler, "The Lesbian Phallus and the Morphological Imaginary," in *Bodies That Matter: On the Discursive Limits of "Sex"* (New York: Routledge, 1993), 57–91. I discuss Butler's reading of Lacan in chapter 5.

either embrace or repudiate in his totality. In making this recommendation, I'm not suggesting a critically eclectic approach to psychoanalysis, one that would pick and choose among ideas and phrases, selecting those that conform to one's agenda and discarding the rest. Instead, I'm suggesting a reading strategy that patiently untangles the heterogeneous logics informing Lacan's work, and that—as far as possible—suspends prejudices and preconceived ideas about psychoanalysis while doing so. Perhaps this amounts to recommending that we treat Lacan psychoanalytically, reading the analyst in the way that he listens to his patients, prepared to encounter paradoxes and nonlinear forms of argumentation, without flattening his work under ready-made skepticism or unquestioning belief.

Having said that, I think we should recognize that psychoanalysis elicits such polarized responses of negation and assent partly because its epistemological status remains closer to that of religion than to science. The idea that psychoanalysis is a religion—the form of mystical authority to which a secular age prefers to devote its faith—is far from new. Even before Foucault characterized psychoanalysis as an updated version of the Catholic confessional, Philip Rieff elaborated the same connection, albeit in a different idiom; and many others have repeated the charge.¹⁸ The fact that the unconscious is empirically unverifiable accounts for the peculiar epistemological status of psychoanalysis, since its most basic concept demands acceptance on grounds other than those we're accustomed to employing in a secular world. "I believe in the unconscious," we say, as if psychoanalysis entailed a doctrinal creed that one must either accept or reject wholesale. When asked by skeptics for evidence of the unconscious, we insist that it is visible or legible in its effects, and we refer to the everyday phenomena of dreams and parapraxes, slips of the tongue and bungled actions. But one cannot base a science on anything so resolutely subjective and shadowy as dreams,

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18. See Foucault: "Perhaps some progress was made by Freud; but with such circumspection, such medical prudence, a scientific guarantee of innocuousness, and so many precautions in order to contain everything, with no fear of 'overflow,' in that safest and most discrete of spaces, between the couch and discourse: *yet another round of whispering on a bed*" (*History of Sexuality*, 1:5; emphasis added). See also Philip Rieff, *The Triumph of the Therapeutic: Uses of Faith after Freud* (New York: Harper and Row, 1966). Psychoanalyst François Roustang has devoted his career to demystifying French analytic institutions as structured according to ecclesiastical principles. See Roustang, *Dire Mastery: Discipleship from Freud to Lacan*, trans. Ned Lukacher (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1982); *Psychoanalysis Never Lets Go*, trans. Ned Lukacher (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1983); and *The Lacanian Delusion*, trans. Greg Sims (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1990).

just as one cannot produce objectively sound theory from mistakes. Every effort to make psychoanalysis a science, to shore up its reputation in empiricist terms, negates the very thing it attempts to validate and ends up eliding the insight—that of the unconscious—on which psychoanalysis is founded. Hence the ineluctably precarious position of psychoanalysis, one that encourages the degeneration of conceptualization into declarations of faith, and leads ultimately to dogmatism.

16

Recognizing the lure of these tendencies, I try in this book to avoid pieties of both the intellectual and ideological sort by putting Lacan into dialogue with the contemporary theorists of sexuality whom he surely would have engaged had he survived for another generation. In many respects, *Beyond Sexuality* could be regarded as a sustained critical response to Judith Butler's work, which has attained such widespread influence in the humanities, social sciences, and even in clinical writing on psychoanalysis in the United States. Valuable though Butler's anti-foundationalist approach to gender and sexuality has been, my critique is based on the conviction that Butler's appropriation of psychoanalysis for feminism and queer theory continues to obscure psychoanalysis's greatest potential for a progressive critique of sexuality. So many academics and clinicians today rely on Butler's work for their understanding of psychoanalysis that it is necessary to lay out as fully as possible exactly where Butler goes wrong. Though this approach might seem uncharitable or tantamount to breaking political rank, engaged auto-critique in fact remains indispensable to the vitality of feminism and queer theory.¹⁹ It is not so much a question of identifying Butler's errors (though this remains an important corrective to certain hagiographic strains in queer theory) as of showing how her style of thinking forecloses a more thoroughgoing antinormative critique of sexuality within psychoanalysis itself. I take up this issue most explicitly in chapters 2 and 5.

Although *Beyond Sexuality* develops the logic of a profoundly antinormative critique by way of a particular reading of Lacan, it would

19. For substantial critiques of Butler's work, see Amanda Anderson, "Debatable Performances: Restaging Contentious Feminisms," *Social Text* 54, vol. 16, no. 1 (1998): 1–24; Joan Copjec, "Sex and the Euthanasia of Reason," in *Read My Desire*, 201–36; Cynthia Dyess and Tim Dean, "Gender: The Impossibility of Meaning," *Psychoanalytic Dialogues*, forthcoming; Frances L. Restuccia, "The Subject of Homosexuality: Butler's Elision," *Clinical Studies* 5, no. 1 (1999): 19–37; Molly Anne Rothenberg and Joseph Valente, "Performative Chic: The Fantasy of a Performative Politics," *College Literature* 24 (1997): 295–304.

be naive or disingenuous to pretend that there remain no residues of heterosexism in Lacanian theory. Not only can we view attempts to systematize Lacan as distinctly normalizing, but we can also begin to see how these attempts dovetail all too neatly with certain normalizing mental habits discernible in Lacan and his followers. By *normalization* I'm referring to both the impulse to domesticate conceptual turbulence and the impulse to organize sexuality into categories of social identity, all the better to regulate erotic expression. While not identical, these twin impulses of normalization overlap and reinforce each other, to the degree that even progressive efforts to enlist psychoanalysis in the critique of sexual identity politics flatten out the most productive contradictions in psychoanalytic theory. Though far from homophobic, Lacanian speculation nevertheless bears the imprint of certain normative ideologies, such that it should be regarded as incoherent in the best possible sense. To consider briefly one example: Lacan's axiom that "there is no sexual relation" counters the heterosexist assumption of complementarity between genders; yet Lacan's explanations of this axiom are couched in terms of each gender's failure to relate to the other, rather than in terms of sexual relationality's failure as such, independent of gender. What Davidson says of Freud—that his mental habits never quite caught up with his conceptual articulations—is true also of Lacan. Nevertheless, what I find so valuable about Lacan's writing is that in its constitutive resistance to closure his speculative work bears witness to a fundamental antinomy between the unconscious and all techniques of normalization.

17

Beyond Sex

I want to contribute to a fundamental change in our thinking about sexuality by exploiting this antinomy and theorizing sexuality outside the realm of individuals—indeed, outside the realm of persons. We take it for granted that sexuality involves other persons; *Beyond Sexuality* attempts to undermine that assumption. I try to push the critique of sexual identity politics in another direction, toward an understanding of the radical impersonality of desire. Thus I develop an account of desire as coming into being as the consequence less of subjective identity—my own or the other's—than of an impersonal object. Once we escape an understanding of desire based on persons, our sexual politics

may expand beyond the imaginary diversification and proliferation of sexual norms to which multiculturalism and the critique of identity politics has brought us. As I argue more fully in chapter 6, the problem with multiplying sexual norms is that this political strategy—no matter how well intentioned—simply enlarges the scope of normalization by treating desire as a question of the imaginary.

By contrast, Lacan's account of the symbolic order, which remains at best implicit in Freud, provides the conceptual ground from which to begin thoroughly depersonalizing or deindividualizing our understanding of sexuality.²⁰ Since the symbolic order denotes a transindividual aspect of subjectivity, this concept allows us to think about sexuality outside the realm of persons, as well as outside the confines of biology or nature. Hence the significance of Lacan's claim that his version of psychoanalysis does "not shrink from seeking the origins of symbolic behaviour outside the human sphere" (*E* 62). It is not simply that the symbolic updates our vocabulary for discussing human sexuality as a cultural rather than a natural phenomenon, but, more interestingly, that Lacan's theory of the symbolic shows how human sexuality involves persons only contingently. *Beyond Sexuality* develops the counterintuitive thesis that we misconstrue sexuality's functioning when we begin our analysis of it from the point of view of men and women, rather than from the perspective of language and its effects.

Some of the confusion about Lacan's reconceptualization of the unconscious in terms of symbolization stems from the failure to recognize that his theory of language takes account of a resistance or negation *within* language, which Lacan terms the real. As with the maxim that life is what happens when you're making other plans, the real is what interrupts every symbolic trajectory, spoiling our imaginary view of things. Since each chapter in this book approaches Lacan's concept of the real from a slightly different angle, I shall not attempt a definition here. Suffice to say that, as the third dimension in Lacan's triad of imaginary-symbolic-real, it remains the most underappreciated in Anglophone studies of French psychoanalysis. Indeed, in contemporary writing on Lacan one still comes across references to the imaginary

20. Since misconceptions abound concerning the conceptual and ideological status of the symbolic order, we should note that there are many symbolic orders, many interwoven networks of signifiers through which we move. Referring to these networks as a singular entity represents not so much insidious universalism as a form of shorthand.

and the symbolic unaccompanied by any reference whatsoever to the real.

The work of Slavoj Žižek and the Slovenian school of psychoanalysis has done much to redress this deficit by bringing the category of the real—along with the concepts of *jouissance*, drive, and object associated with it—to the fore.²¹ Given the intimate connections between the dimension of the real and the place of sexuality in psychic life, one would have thought that the attention recently accorded this conceptual category would have generated a genuinely new perspective on sexuality, one able to account for new sexual practices and new conditions of sexual life, such as AIDS. Unfortunately—perhaps owing to Eastern European sexual politics—the question of sexuality is hardly a strong suit of the Slovenian school of psychoanalysis, in whose writing one often encounters the most banal heterosexism.²² On the other hand, the vagaries of Lacan's Anglophone reception, together with the American mental health establishment's tradition of sexual conservatism, have forestalled queer theory's recognition of what Lacanian psychoanalysis has to offer a radically antinormative critique of sexuality.

19

Beyond Sexuality attempts to develop the category of the real in light of queer theory, in order to generate a new perspective on the manifestations of sexuality—particularly its unconscious manifestations—in our time. I began work on this book by trying to articulate two of my principal concerns, Lacanian psychoanalysis and AIDS, in order to see how each could help me think about the other. I've ended this book firm in the conviction that it is unethical to talk about contemporary sexuality without talking about AIDS, and that it is intellectually stunting to theorize sexuality without taking into account the unconscious. Chapters 3 and 4 of this book are devoted explicitly to thinking through psychoanalytically some of the issues surrounding the epidemic; yet the specter of AIDS hovers over every chapter and may explain their sense of urgency about theorizing sexuality in a different way than reigning academic models permit.

One of the hardest psychoanalytic ideas—hard to come to terms

21. See Slavoj Žižek, *The Sublime Object of Ideology* (New York: Verso, 1989). For a helpful and very judicious account of Žižek's work, see Robert Miklitsch, "‘Going through the Fantasy’: Screening Slavoj Žižek," *South Atlantic Quarterly* 97 (1998): 475–507.

22. The principal exception to this general weakness is Parveen Adams, *The Emptiness of the Image: Psychoanalysis and Sexual Differences* (London: Routledge, 1996).

with both conceptually and emotionally—concerns sexuality’s imbrication with a dimension of negativity that Freud called the death drive. AIDS gives a ghastly new life to this idea, literalizing longstanding connections (many of them purely mythic) between sex and death in a way that raises the stakes of our theoretical discussions about sexuality. While it remains necessary to distinguish the stakes of intellectual debates from the life-and-death stakes of contemporary sexual practices, it is also necessary to remember that how we talk about sex profoundly affects how we experience it. We live in a world of sexually transmitted diseases, a viral world where sexual intercourse can be lethal; but we also live in a symbolic world, where words can be as medicinal as they can be deadly. Hence it is in the interests of helping to create a healthier symbolic universe that I write about sexuality, having learned from psychoanalysis that talking about sex in the right way can in fact save lives.

20

Contemporary theories of language’s power and efficacy, whether psychoanalytically derived or otherwise, have far more to say about language’s power to harm than its power to heal or protect us.²³ This emphasis on the privative aspects of symbolic existence comports well with Lacan’s description of the signifier’s mortifying effects on human life. Yet the whole point of psychoanalysis as a talking cure is that the signifier can be good for your health, as well as detrimental to it. While no amount of discourse can redress certain basic losses, one doesn’t have to resort to utopianism in order to recognize that a different discourse on sexuality holds open the possibility of less destructive sexual relations. Though Freudianism was caught up in the emergence of our modern understanding of sexuality, nevertheless a certain version of psychoanalysis retains the potential to push us beyond that epoch in the history of sexuality.

AIDS represents an especially crucial chapter in the history of sexuality, partly because it sharpens the question that Foucault identified in the opening volume of his *The History of Sexuality*, namely, whether sex is worth dying for. According to Foucault, the modern deployment of sexuality situates sex as so central to our self-understanding that we effectively become willing “to exchange life in its entirety for sex itself,

23. See, for example, Elaine Scarry, *The Body in Pain: The Making and Unmaking of the World* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1985), and Judith Butler, *Excitable Speech: A Politics of the Performative* (New York: Routledge, 1997).

for the truth and the sovereignty of sex.”²⁴ Of course, Foucault was speaking in epistemic, not individual terms. Nevertheless, my point is that by dramatizing this symbolic pact—the exchange of life for sex—AIDS may push us beyond it, to a new chapter in the history of sexuality. It would be easy and perhaps comforting to misconstrue this claim as implying either that AIDS will unleash a backlash of puritanical moralism, returning us to the preliberation norms of abstinence, monogamy, and the closet; or that the horrors of the epidemic can be recast redemptively, such that those who have died can be viewed as martyrs for the weary enlightenment of those who survive. I’m not trying to make either of these points. Instead, I’m suggesting that a psychoanalytic understanding of contemporary sexuality and of AIDS may enable us to move beyond the intransigent, systemic assumption that sex confers the principal guarantee of subjective truth.

21

One of the implications of this possibility would be that gayness cease being defined primarily in terms of sex—not because anybody would necessarily have less sex or fewer sexual partners or different kinds of sex, but because sex would signify fundamentally differently. In such a world, one would be defined by one’s sexuality no more than by any other contingent feature, because erotic desire would have been fully disarticulated from personhood. If the deployment of sexuality were to shift in this direction, “sexuality” could be reinserted between quotation marks, as Foucault recommended, and psychoanalysis might become obsolete. Then we would be truly beyond the couch. But in my view, such an outcome would represent the fulfillment, not the default, of Freud’s radical promise.

24. Foucault, *History of Sexuality*, 1:156.

HOW TO READ LACAN

Chapter 1

How should we approach Lacan's work? I address this question here by assessing the various ways in which he has been read. Although it would seem incontestable that the way we read Lacan determines what ideas we get from him, many of his recent interpreters appear surprisingly unreflective about methodological approaches to psychoanalysis. In this respect, a professional training in something as ostensibly nugatory as *reading* represents the resource that a literary critic has to offer psychoanalytic theory. I am particularly concerned, in this chapter, with how various contextualist accounts of Lacan paradoxically obscure what is most distinctive about his work. Situating Lacan in different histories, these commentators intend to illuminate his work, yet in so doing they tend to overlook the complex history of concepts within Lacan's own thinking. In order to revitalize psychoanalytic conceptualization, I want to show how Lacan's reception has quashed the potential of his most far-reaching ideas. By charting the history of his concept of the object, I want to begin suggesting the multivalence and usefulness of this concept for cultural study.

Against Understanding

In the preface to his "Rome Discourse" of 1953—in a formulation that remains as cogent today as it was almost half a century ago—Lacan

himself suggested how we might approach psychoanalytic theory: "I consider it to be an urgent task to disengage from concepts that are being deadened by routine use the meaning that they regain both from a re-examination of their history and from a reflexion on their subjective foundations" (E 33). One has only to consult contemporary humanistic discourse or, further down the cultural food chain, peruse the self-help section at the bookstore—or, further yet, turn on the television to one of the many talk shows glutting the airwaves—to confirm that Freudian concepts have become almost completely "deadened by routine use." And by referring to "subjective foundations," I think Lacan is getting at the basic epistemological idea that while concepts have a history through which they come into being, their conceptual value exceeds the conditions and processes of their historical emergence. If it were not so, all ideas would be subject to the relativizing introduced by historicism, including the concept of historicization itself. Thus although in this chapter I focus on particularly egregious contextualist approaches to Lacan, I want also to suggest the limits of historicizing psychoanalytic concepts in general.¹

23

It is significant for my purposes that Lacan specifies the project of reexamining concepts' histories and reflecting on their subjective foundations as "the teacher's prime function," not that of the clinician. In distinguishing between the role of the teacher and that of the analyst, Lacan reminds us that in his seminars he fulfills a somewhat different function than in the consulting room, one closer to what we do in the classroom. Yet he also draws a useful analogy between analytic work and professional reading:

[T]he method of textual commentary proves itself fruitful. Commenting on a text is like doing an analysis. How many times have I said to those under my supervision, when they say to me—*I had the impression he meant this or that*—that one of the things we must guard

1. Although my critique is far from limited to these examples, I focus on Mikkel Borch-Jacobsen, *Lacan: The Absolute Master*, trans. Douglas Brick (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1991); and David Macey, *Lacan in Contexts* (New York: Verso, 1988). For a critical review of Borch-Jacobsen that engages many of the issues I address here, see Shuli Barzilai, "Reading Lacan, or Harlaquanage: An Essay Review," *American Imago* 52 (1995): 81–106. This chapter was first drafted in 1991, before the appearance of Joan Copjec's *Read My Desire: Lacan against the Historicists* (Cambridge: MIT Press, 1994), which provides the most sustained psychoanalytic critique of historicism. Copjec's brilliant critique notwithstanding, the fundamental problems of Lacan's Anglophone reception remain so intractable that I considered it necessary to pursue these issues once more here.

most against is to understand too much, to understand more than what is in the discourse of the subject. To interpret and to imagine one understands are not at all the same things. It is precisely the opposite. I would go as far as to say that it is on the basis of a kind of refusal of understanding that we push open the door to analytic understanding. (*SI* 73)

24

Distinguishing between reading or textual commentary, on one hand, and understanding, on the other, Lacan aligns a kind of careful reading with what goes on in analysis. This kind of reading, for which so many of his critical commentators have no patience, is psychoanalytic in the sense that it resists understanding too quickly, since understanding, as a particular function of consciousness, concerns the precipitate satisfactions of the ego. The faculty of understanding and the agency of the ego are both structured according to the illusion of coherence; both operate like a perceptual gestalt, totalizing into a spurious unity what remains fragmented and heterogeneous. In other words, the problem with understanding as *connaissance* is that it is always founded on a *méconnaissance*, insofar as its formation of coherence constitutively misses something. Lacan articulates this principle most bluntly when he remarks that “[t]o think, it is often better not to understand” (*E* 252).

By assigning understanding to the domain of the imaginary and characterizing it as a function of the ego, Lacan suggests why psychoanalytic practice and, indeed, his own writing are designed to frustrate us, since his conception of analysis is based on a critique of the ego as the agent of misrecognition. Lacan’s attitude also explains why any systematization of psychoanalytic thought, no matter how rigorous, necessarily reduces that thought to ego-reinforcing dogma, since systematization entails making theory falsely coherent. Indeed, at the beginning of his first seminar Lacan announces, “This kind of teaching is a refusal of any system. It uncovers a thought in motion—nonetheless vulnerable to systematisation, since it necessarily possesses a dogmatic aspect” (*SI* 1). This announcement comes just two months after Lacan delivered his “Rome Discourse,” from which I quoted earlier in this chapter. Taken together, these lines suggest that at a crucial, semi-inaugural moment in his teaching Lacan attempted to forestall the systematization of psychoanalytic concepts—indeed, that he actively resisted previous systematizations of Freud. Hence we can see that Lacan’s notorious critique

of the ego is cognate with his less widely appreciated objection to systematization.

In consequence of his awareness that mobile speculation remains forever “vulnerable to systematisation,” Lacan devised strategies for thwarting the imaginary lures of the intellectual ego, practicing techniques in his own discourse for inhibiting ready understanding. The assumption underlying such a rebarbative verbal stance is that we can think differently only once we learn to listen and read differently. And though Lacan’s dense style makes more sense from this perspective, the content of his discourse is no more readily grasped in its totality. Thus while I try in this book to resist the temptation to systematize Lacan, I also want to be as clear as possible about what he offers, without underestimating the difficulties of both his conceptualization and the form in which it is presented.

25

In the seminar passage I’m discussing, Lacan continues by comparing his own teaching to Freud’s: “Freud’s thought is the most perennially open to revision. It is a mistake to reduce it to a collection of hackneyed phrases” (*SI* 1). A collection of hackneyed phrases or mantras describes perfectly the state into which Lacanian thought is constantly in danger of deteriorating—even though, more than Freud’s, Lacan’s thought is “perennially open to revision.” Indeed, in his acknowledgments to the first seminar edited after Lacan’s death, Jacques-Alain Miller proposed that the work of producing Lacan’s seminars is one in which—because Lacan’s conceptual development remains unclosed—the readers of his texts participate: “I thank in advance any reader who would like to collaborate in the revision of a text that is the object of continuing work” (*SVII* 326).² The seminar may have been provisionally interpreted between the time of its presentation and its publication, but this interpretation is merely preliminary.

It is this unfinished, unsettled aspect of Lacan’s work that I find so exhilarating and intellectually productive. For me, Lacan’s writing reads like poetry, not so much in its verbal complexity as in its potentiality, its incitement to further thinking. Despite the initial effect of a “closed book” that one tends to experience when first encountering Lacan, his work is profoundly open to what we make of it through our careful

2. I take Miller’s statement to be offered in good faith, even though I remain skeptical about his role in posthumously systematizing Lacan.

reading. This is particularly the case with his seminars, which capture thinking quite differently than do published books, even books of essays (or *écrits*), since the latter undergo a greater degree of revision, interpretation, and systematization before publication. (Here we can see one major difference between Lacan and his academic contemporaries, the French structuralists and poststructuralists with whom he's often grouped.) It is because Lacan's principal intellectual work consisted in his bimonthly seminars, improvised before an audience, rather than because of uncritical reverence, that I refer to Lacan's "teaching."

26 Given that all reading occurs within some interpretive horizon that imposes a framework on the text in the interests of legibility, I want to evaluate the common hermeneutics through which Lacan gets read. In this chapter I focus on the historicist hermeneutic, and in subsequent chapters I assess the other principal framework—that of feminism—through which Lacanian psychoanalysis has been mediated in the English-speaking world. The influence of new historicism in contemporary literary studies has prompted me to think about the virtues and limits of contextualist approaches to both literary and psychoanalytic texts, even though the examples I discuss aren't, strictly speaking, new historicist.³ I suggest that the historicist mode of reading Lacan—exemplified here by David Macey and Mikkel Borch-Jacobsen—gives us an account of Lacan that is not only inimical to the history of his work, but also profoundly ahistorical with respect to psychoanalytic concepts. Contending that we are served better by a periodized than a historicized Lacan, I outline an alternative, periodized paradigm, which I hope will yield more useful readings of Lacan. Unlike the historicists' Lacan, my periodized model has the flexibility of allowing for its own disintegration under the pressure of individual readings of specific texts.

Contextualizing Lacan

Historicist approaches to psychoanalysis may be distinguished according to whether they situate their object of study in relation primarily to intellectual influences (Borch-Jacobsen) or to a broader cultural milieu and its attendant prejudices (Macey). I want first to examine the latter,

3. I discuss this historicist epistemology at greater length in "Wanting Paul de Man: A Critique of the 'Logic' of New Historicism in American Studies," *Texas Studies in Literature and Language* 35 (1993): 251–77.

more culturalist approach because my argument thus far concerning systematization accords with Macey's critique, in *Lacan in Contexts*, of what he calls "final statism." I agree with Macey that the early Anglo-American reception of Lacan has tended to produce a final state or coherent theoretical edifice that leaves the reader in a disabling position of either embracing or rejecting wholesale that edifice. It is this position that turns Lacanian psychoanalysis into a kind of cult. However, I disagree with the solution that Macey proposes, because I see his remedy as leading to merely a different final state from the one he initially diagnoses. In other words, his solution repeats the problem.

Macey's remedy for final statism—"to place the master in a variety of contexts" (25)—represents a historicist solution to the problems involved in treating any artifact or text as transcending the cultural context that produced it. Arguing against the notion of transcendent creative genius by emphasizing a text's social embeddedness or cultural immanence has been a tremendously useful critical approach, since it provides a way of apprehending the multiple cultural voices circulating within a single text. This approach admirably demystifies genius by identifying the various social factors that constrain any thought or utterance, thereby rooting intellectual work in its proper milieus. However, applying this historicist contextualism to psychoanalysis limits the possibility that psychoanalytic concepts may have any purchase beyond the moment and circumstances of their historical emergence. Freud himself recognized this limitation, observing dryly that "[w]e have all heard of the interesting attempt to explain psychoanalysis as a product of the Vienna milieu" (*SE* 14:39). Nevertheless, historicism counters by objecting to what it views as psychoanalysis's failure to consider cultural and historical specificity in the formulation of psychic laws and models, such as the Oedipus complex—an objection that also forms part of feminist and queer critiques of psychoanalysis.⁴ According to histori-

4. While the question of psychoanalytic universalism is too far-reaching to assess properly here, we might perhaps recall what Lacan means by the "universality" of the Oedipus complex. Responding to a lecture by Lévi-Strauss entitled "Kinship versus the Family," Lacan distinguishes universality from both necessity and the generic, asserting that "[w]ith respect to the introduction of the symbolic system, I think that the answer to the question raised by Lévi-Strauss yesterday, is that the Oedipus complex is both universal and contingent, because it is uniquely and purely symbolic" (*SI* 33). Hence Lacan conceives the universality of the Oedipus complex not anthropologically, in terms of the incest taboo, but symbolically, in terms of a signifying structure that predetermines an alienated symbolic identity for every subject. Another way of putting this would be to say that symbolic alienation is cultural, but universally so, since every culture depends on language. For further

cism, concepts have a history that renders them contingent; therefore concepts cannot be understood adequately without elaborating the histories through which they are produced and the contexts in which they come to wield explanatory power.

28 This notion of cultural immanence—as opposed to transcendence—derives in large part from Foucault's influential critique of the repressive hypothesis, by way of his argument that "[r]elations of power are not in a position of exteriority with respect to other types of relationships (economic processes, knowledge relationships, sexual relations), but are immanent in the latter."⁵ By conceiving of power as productive rather than repressive—"Power is everywhere; not because it embraces everything, but because it comes from everywhere"⁶—and thus by making power coextensive with desire rather than opposed to it, Foucaultian discourse analysis foregrounds the material and discursive constructions of sexuality, subjectivity, gender, and suchlike as the primary focus of critical attention. Within this hermeneutic, psychoanalysis and literature tend to be treated as little more than homologous instances of the discourses (and practices) that construct, say, the bourgeois subject. Despite the various problems with this hermeneutic, some of which Lacan himself anticipated,⁷ a certain historicist logic has become pervasive in the humanities, influencing the methods even of those who don't think of themselves as historicists.

Macey's account of Lacan is guided by exactly this logic. For example, he characterizes Lacan's work on feminine sexuality as derivative of and coterminous with various aesthetic tenets and icons of French surrealism. Macey's reading is governed by the historicist principle that converts every text into a historically determined cultural document, placing it on an equal footing with other contemporaneous documents: "Lacan is not influenced by surrealism, as though it were some external

psychoanalytic discussion of this issue, see Moustafa Safouan, "Is the Oedipus Complex Universal?" in *The Woman in Question: M/F*, ed. Parveen Adams and Elizabeth Cowie (Cambridge: MIT Press, 1990), 274–82, and, more recently, Jacqueline Rose, "On the 'Universality' of Madness: Bessie Head's *A Question of Power*," *Critical Inquiry* 20 (1994): 401–18.

5. Michel Foucault, *The History of Sexuality*, vol. 1, *An Introduction*, trans. Robert Hurley (New York: Random House, 1978), 94.

6. *Ibid.*, 93.

7. The Foucaultian argument that the law produces desire, that sexuality and power are coextensive rather than opposed, fails to account for the production of neuroses, according to Lacan ("Names" 89).

factor impinging upon his subjectivity; his writing is part of the same web" (74). This form of reductionism eliminates the possibility of any discursive specificity whatsoever. Furthermore, Macey's contextualism remains vulnerable to the poststructuralist critique that charges historicism with failing to treat texts as textual, insofar as documents tend to be read thematically (that is, imaginarily) rather than textually (symbolically). For example, in his account of feminine sexuality Macey fails to consider the elementary differences between surrealist pictures and surrealist texts, thereby overlooking the fact that the surrealism he characterizes as an unequivocally sexist representational practice could produce only an *imaginary* theory of sexuality. Macey conflates the complex formulations of *Encore*—in which sexuality is theorized in terms of the symbolic and real—with Lacan's historical association almost forty years earlier with surrealist painters, such as Salvador Dalí, and the surrealist journal *Minotaure*. This conflation requires Macey to effectively reimagine both symbolic and real orders—to treat imaginary, symbolic, and real as indistinguishable—in order to sustain his argument that surrealist misogyny determines the theory of feminine sexuality in *Encore*: "the frequent but veiled references to convulsive beauty, and the iconography of both *Encore* and *Ornicar?* all combine to suggest that, for Lacan and his disciples, the riddle of femininity is basically a question of pussy" (195). Macey describes Lacan's theory of sexuality as if it involved only one register, the imaginary, when Lacan is quite emphatic about the necessity, when theorizing sexuality, of taking into account language and the dimension of trauma or impossibility that he calls the real.

29

Furthermore, in order to argue that Lacanian psychoanalysis has no contribution to make to feminism, Macey is compelled to basically ignore the long history of feminist appropriations of Lacan—from work by Juliet Mitchell and Jacqueline Rose to Jane Gallop, Joan Copjec, Parveen Adams, Kaja Silverman, and others. Although he is to some degree correct in his assessment that early feminist work on Lacan produced a "final state" of psychoanalytic theory that requires a major overhaul, it does not follow that rethinking Lacanian psychoanalysis will unmask it as thoroughly misogynist. Indeed, the burden of my argument in subsequent chapters is that although for various reasons feminist critiques have developed what I take to be less useful aspects of Lacan,

French psychoanalysis still holds many radical ideas that can be developed for feminism and queer theory.⁸

In the end, Macey's problem isn't just that he misinterprets Lacan and is unfair to certain feminists, but that in his zeal to contextualize he reproduces exactly the problem he initially diagnosed—the solidification of Lacanian theory into a system or orthodoxy, a set of judgments beyond dialectic. The question remains whether this is a necessary result of his approach or whether contextualism can maintain a dialectical openness with respect to psychoanalytic concepts.

Mastering Lacan

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Since historicism isn't discredited in toto by Macey's shoddy contextualism, let us consider Mikkel Borch-Jacobsen's critique, in *Lacan: The Absolute Master*, of what he calls "the Lacanian system." As I have suggested, treating Lacan's teaching as a "system" projects it into the context of mastery, for there is no systematization without a master. The rub here is that Borch-Jacobsen wishes to invert, not merely subvert, the position of mastery by arguing that Lacan "never really had a thought of his own" (2).⁹ We start to see that Borch-Jacobsen stands as Europe's version of Frederick Crews. Wishing to completely invert the position of mastery, Borch-Jacobsen forgets that an inversion in the imaginary is liable to effect an imaginary *identification*, since the imaginary is structured dyadically. Like Macey's, Borch-Jacobsen's account proceeds almost exclusively at the imaginary level—hence, for instance, the doubling phenomenon whereby Macey reproduces the problem he begins by diagnosing.

Borch-Jacobsen tries to demonstrate the historicist proposition that Lacan was "a son of his times," "rooted in his era by every fiber of his being" (1). "A son of his times," Borch-Jacobsen tells us, was—like "the absolute master"—a phrase of Hegel's favored by Lacan (and, we might note, favored by Borch-Jacobsen). Borch-Jacobsen situates Lacan in a very specific philosophical context, that of Alexandre Kojève's reading

8. See Mari Jo Buhle, *Feminism and Its Discontents: A Century of Struggle with Psychoanalysis* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1998), for an admirably judicious historical account of what these two great theories of liberation still have to offer each other.

9. Subsequent to *Lacan: The Absolute Master*, Borch-Jacobsen's denunciations have become increasingly strident, anti-intellectual, and populist. See his *Remembering Anna O: A Century of Mystification*, trans. Kirby Olson (New York: Routledge, 1996).

of Hegel; implicitly he constructs a line of filiation that runs from Hegel to Kojève, through Lacan, and on to Borch-Jacobsen himself. The appellation “a son of his times” is “eminently applicable” to Lacan, according to Borch-Jacobsen; yet it is also applicable to the author of *Lacan: The Absolute Master*. Like François Roustang’s *The Lacanian Delusion*, on which it often relies, *Lacan: The Absolute Master* is penned by a European who, “raised in an intellectual atmosphere dominated by Lacan,” identifies negatively with the position he takes Lacan to represent.¹⁰ Calling Lacan “a son of his times” is one sign of that identification.

Borch-Jacobsen foregrounds the Hegelian idiom because Kojève’s Hegelianism is his principal intellectual context for situating Lacan—a context that, like Macey’s emphasis on surrealism, reduces Lacan’s thinking to the sum of his early influences. Thus Borch-Jacobsen’s account cannot accommodate the Lacan for whom “Hegelian dialectic is false.”¹¹ Lacan passes negative judgment on the Hegelian dialectic later in his career because he sees its impulse toward synthesis as confirming the ego’s synthesizing tendency, a tendency Lacan considers fundamentally misguided and, indeed, destructively exclusionary. Beyond the ego or fully integrated self, Lacan is ultimately more interested in the undialectizable remainder that keeps desire in motion. He will call this remainder object *a*.

Another way of putting this involves pointing to Lacan’s insistence

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10. See François Roustang, *The Lacanian Delusion*, trans. Greg Sims (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1990). I take the quotation characterizing Borch-Jacobsen from the cover of the paperback edition of *Lacan: The Absolute Master*. Roustang’s critique also wishes to invert the mastery it imputes to Lacan, though differently than Borch-Jacobsen’s: while the latter seeks via a philosophical historicism to deny Lacan credit for any innovation at all, Roustang projects onto the Lacanian canon a motivating principle of scientific systematization in order to dismantle that alleged systematicity. Thus where Macey identifies a final state only to historicize and substitute for it an “origin state” of his own, Roustang imputes a final state that will, of course, collapse under extended critical scrutiny. Roustang’s account is so intensely inscribed in a transferential relation to “the master” that he remains blind to how his emphasis on details—particularly details of Lacan’s dress—situates “Lacan” as maleficent Other: “Lacan is a strategist who does not make a move without precise intentions” (16). For Roustang, Lacan’s sartorial style, his discursive style, and his institutional style (“[h]e was always able to come up with a strategy *tailor-made* for each individual” [4; my emphasis]) are all cut from the same seamless cloth—a veil covering the noxious *jouissance* of the Other. In this respect Roustang’s take on Lacan is eminently subject to the analysis developed by Joan Copjec in “The Sartorial Superego,” in *Read My Desire*, 65–116.

11. “Whatever the prestige of Hegelian dialectic, whatever the effects, seen by Marx, through which it entered into the world, thus completing that whose meaning Hegel *was*, namely: the subversion of a political order founded on the *Ecclesia*, the Church, and on that score, whatever its success, whatever the value of what it sustains in the political incidences of its actualization, Hegelian dialectic is false and contradicted as much by the testimony of the natural sciences as by the historical progress of the fundamental science, mathematics” (“Names” 84).

that subjectivity must be theorized in several dimensions at once. This multidimensionality poses a problem for Borch-Jacobsen, who has to either ignore Lacan's quaternary models or convert them back into ternary or binary structures, since Hegelian dialectic is structured by a maximum of three terms. Early on Lacan argued against a "two-body psychology" (a term of John Rickman's popularized by Michael Balint) by insisting on the intervention of a third term—first the image and then the symbol: "If, as we must, we take speech as the central feature of our perspective, then it is within a three- rather than two-term relation that we have to formulate the analytic experience in its totality" (*SI* 11). Yet Lacan quickly acknowledges the necessity of a *fourth* term for his conceptual models, since "a quadripartite structure, given the unconscious, is always to be required in the construction of a subjective ordinance" ("Kant" 62). By this Lacan means that psychoanalytic interactions should be seen as not simply one person talking to another (a two-term relation), but a relation in which more entities—more complex structures of mediation—are involved. The unconscious is always a third party to any psychoanalytic exchange. Interpersonal relations are mediated by both discourse and the real (what discourse cannot accommodate).

However, Borch-Jacobsen's account of Lacan rarely proceeds beyond two-term formulations—as, for instance, in his claim that "[o]bviously, Lacan's whole complex reformulation of the Oedipus complex ultimately rests on the rigid 'dualist ontology' of Kojève" (225). Yet Lacan theorizes the Oedipus complex in terms of symbolic mediation and thus outside of any dualistic economy. In general, Borch-Jacobsen pursues binary logics, arguing in terms of affirmation and negation without grasping Freud's account of negation, whose importance lies in the discovery that negation isn't a function of binary oppositions. For Freud, negation also involves symbolic mediation and therefore depends on the intervention of a third term.¹²

12. See Jean Hyppolite, "A Spoken Commentary on Freud's *Verneinung*," appendix to *SI* 289–97. Hyppolite distinguishes between the symbol of negation used by the ego and the "concrete attitude of negation," which originates in unconscious destructiveness. This distinction enables him to identify an asymmetry between affirmation, as belonging to Eros, and negation, as belonging to Thanatos. From this it follows that negation constitutes the possibility-condition of symbolization as such, and that consequently negation, not affirmation, institutes the faculty of judgment. A primordial negation precedes any affirmation: "Why doesn't Freud say: the functioning of judgement is rendered possible by affirmation? Because negation has a role to play not as a tendency to destruc-

The main consequence of Borch-Jacobsen's binarism, which also governs his mimetic model of identification in *The Freudian Subject*, is that he remains unable to comprehend psychoanalytic concepts in anything but imaginary terms.¹³ In his book's final chapter (on desire and sexuality), in which one would most expect to find him discussing symbolic and real orders, Borch-Jacobsen, like Macey, flattens concepts down to the imaginary level: "desire organizes itself into imaginary scenarios, where it imagines (itself in) an object" (204). Borch-Jacobsen's relentless Hegelianism prevents him from apprehending the elementary fact that Lacan situates desire at the level of the unconscious. This remarkable oversight also leads to his mistranslation of the ethic of psychoanalysis as "Do not give in to your desire," which reduces ethics to simple moralism and turns Lacan into Nancy Reagan.¹⁴ Borch-Jacobsen defines even the object *a* in imaginary terms: "The *objet a* thus has the remarkable property of furnishing an image of the subject, *insofar as he is lacking in that image*" (232; original emphasis); and "[i]n phantasy, in other words, the subject imagines himself as the object that could fulfill the desire of the Other" (230). Although Lacan's earliest conception of the object sometimes described it in imaginary terms, the significance

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tion, no more than within a form of judgement, but in so far as it is the fundamental attitude of symbolicity rendered explicit" (296).

13. Mikkel Borch-Jacobsen, *The Freudian Subject* [1982], trans. Catherine Porter (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1988).

14. Lacan's phrase, "cédé sur son désir" (Jacques Lacan, *Le séminaire livre VII: L'éthique de la psychanalyse 1959–1960*, ed. Jacques-Alain Miller [Paris: Seuil, 1986], 368), is admittedly somewhat ambiguous. However, to render it as giving *in to* one's desire, rather than giving *up on* one's desire, promotes exactly the opposite meaning for the ethical imperative elaborated by Lacan, who repeatedly enunciates the matter in terms of a positive statement rather than in terms of a negative prohibition ("Thou shalt not"): "Je propose que la seule chose dont on puisse être coupable, au moins dans la perspective analytique, c'est d'avoir cédé sur son désir" (368); "Le seule chose dont on puisse être coupable, c'est d'avoir cédé sur son désir" (370). (This formulation is rendered by Dennis Porter, translator of Seminar 7, as "the only thing one can be guilty of is giving ground relative to one's desire" [SVII 321], which is more cumbersome, but remains faithful to the sense of Lacan's text.) Yet Borch-Jacobsen's account—by quoting out of context, by putting in quotation marks a paraphrased negative injunction rather than any actual line from Lacan's text, and by the placing of his own mischaracterization of the Lacanian concept of desire—manages to create the impression that Lacan's psychoanalytic ethic consists in the conventional negative prohibition: "Do not give in to your desire!" (Borch-Jacobsen, *Lacan: The Absolute Master*, 226). It is important to stress that this is a conceptual rather than a linguistic or translation error: the translator's note that prefaces *Lacan: The Absolute Master* assures us that "Thanks to Mikkel Borch-Jacobsen's extensive participation, the reader will be spared the translator's habitual complaints about inevitable unfaithfulness to the 'original,' since the present volume is more a cooperative rewriting than a translation. In fact . . . it could even be said that the 'translation' precedes the 'original'" (xiii). This conceptual mistranslation, attributable as much to Borch-Jacobsen as to his translator, stems from the former's failure to comprehend desire as "that which supports an *unconscious* theme" (SVII 319, emphasis added).

of object *a* lies in its nonspecularity and its function within a structure involving at least three dimensions. Object *a*—the object of unconscious fantasy—designates that which escapes the imaginary and the domain of the ego.

34 Like Macey's account of surrealism's influence on Lacan, Borch-Jacobsen's argument remains locked in imaginary terms, because it is only in the imaginary that the Other can be an other—that is, an image of another person.¹⁵ Following his elaboration in Hegelian terms of Lacan's early theory of desire as desire of the other, Borch-Jacobsen fails to register the significance of Lacan's move beyond Hegel. Lacan moves beyond a Hegelian conception of desire by redefining it as desire of the Other—a shift that immediately removes desire from the imaginary register and into the symbolic. By claiming that for Lacan, "desire is a desire to be desired as a subject—that is, as a non-object" (208), Borch-Jacobsen conflates two incompatible accounts of desire. Lacan's early, neo-Hegelian account of desire saw it as a result of the intersubjective dialectic of speech, in which speech aimed at eliciting subjective recognition. But treating the Other as nonsubjective, as a domain of alterity irreducible to other persons, entails a conception of desire that isn't intersubjective. Instead, Lacan's later account of desire locates its origins in the objectal remainder—*objet petit a*—of the Other's action on my own body.

By discussing desire and the object as questions of intersubjectivity, Borch-Jacobsen reimaginarizes both the Other and the object, according them the status of non- or negated subjects. Yet Lacan implied as early as January 1955 that it is only in the imaginary that the Other is an other: "Hegel is at the limit of anthropology. Freud got out of it. His discovery is that man isn't entirely in man. Freud isn't a humanist" (*SI* 72). In contrast to Freud, Hegel remains a "humanist," because he sees the subject's ontology as constituted in its relation to an other subjectively conceived—that is, another person. As long as the other remains captive to the status of the subject, one is stuck in the imaginary domain of psychologized relations. However, by theorizing alterity impersonally—in terms of the symbolic Other, rather than the imaginary other—Lacan moves beyond psychology and hence beyond intersubjectivity.¹⁶

15. I elaborate this distinction in "Two Kinds of Other and Their Consequences," *Critical Inquiry* 23 (1997): 910–20.

16. This shift explains my methodological disagreement with the work of relational psychoana-

Yet *Lacan: The Absolute Master* treats Other and object in accordance with the dictates of Hegel's master-slave dialectic, in which the subject is defined in relation to an other subject. By viewing the other as the binary opposite of (or complement to) the subject, Borch-Jacobsen makes the subject-Other relation basically symmetrical. This symmetry prompts him to explain the concept of the gaze in Sartrean, rather than Lacanian, terms, since in Sartre's account of specular relations subject and other *are* symmetrical, and the visual field in which they confront each other (Sartre's famous park) conforms to the Euclidean conventions of perspectival space.¹⁷ By contrast, Lacan's account of the gaze—which owes more to Merleau-Ponty's last, unfinished work than to Sartre—locates the gaze as object *a*, thereby situating it closer to the domain of the real than to that of the imaginary.¹⁸

Despite the longstanding availability in English translation of the seminar in which Lacan elaborates his theory of the gaze as object *a*, Anglophone accounts of Lacan repeatedly misconstrue this concept.¹⁹ While neither Macey, Borch-Jacobsen, nor historicism can be held directly responsible for this problem, historicism's influence does account for the failure to comprehend the significance of object *a*, since this concept implies a certain notion of transcendence. The historicist rejection of transcendence, which is disallowed on other grounds by the deconstruction of metaphysics, promotes a critical emphasis on discursive constructions or linguistic constitutivity that tends to be regarded as fundamentally compatible with Lacan's insistence on the determining effects for the human subject of relations of signification. This tendency to extract the concept of the signifier as the sole basis of Lacan's rethinking of Freud—as if Lacan could be grasped by merely combining Freud, Saussure, and Lévi-Strauss—derives in part from the canonization of Lacan's "Rome Discourse" and has led to the bracketing of French psychoanalysis with a version of poststructuralism for which it is axiomatic

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lysts whose primary concern lies in specifying more equitable intersubjective arrangements, particularly between the sexes, and who often rely on a Hegelian model of intersubjective recognition. See, for example, Jessica Benjamin, *Like Subjects, Love Objects: Essays on Recognition and Sexual Difference* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1995).

17. Jean-Paul Sartre, *Being and Nothingness: An Essay in Phenomenological Ontology*, trans. Hazel E. Barnes (Secaucus, N.J.: Citadel, 1977), 230 and *passim*.

18. Jacques Lacan, "Of the Gaze as *Objet Petit a*" (*Four* 67–119). See also Maurice Merleau-Ponty, "The Intertwining—The Chiasm," in *The Visible and the Invisible*, ed. Claude Lefort, trans. Alphonso Lingis (Evanston: Northwestern University Press, 1968), 130–55.

19. On this misconstrual, Copjec, *Read My Desire*, chap. 2, is particularly helpful.

that “there is nothing outside the text.”²⁰ Thus even though deconstruction and historicism remain vigorously opposed, both approaches—at least in their North American variants—have proven capable of assimilating a psychoanalysis that emphasizes the linguistically structured unconscious. As a result, the theoretical potential of psychoanalysis has been diluted. It may be restored by taking seriously Lacan’s concept of the object. In order to do so, we need to see how this concept emerges in Lacan’s own work.

Periodizing Lacan

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The scheme I propose for periodizing Lacan involves bracketing his work after 1932 into four distinct stages: a “40s Lacan” of the imaginary, a “50s Lacan” of the symbolic, a “60s Lacan” of the real, and a “70s Lacan” of the *sinthome*. Each decade designation belongs in quotation marks insofar as this splitting of Lacan’s work into discrete periods is necessarily artificial. Yet this kind of periodization serves heuristic purposes and helps to guard against final-statist kinds of systematization. Along with these four periods, each of which may be characterized by focus on a particular order, goes a conceptual element in relation to which Lacan maps the subject: the image or imago for the “40s Lacan” of the imaginary, the signifier for the “50s Lacan” of the symbolic, the object for the “60s Lacan” of the real, and the reconceived symptom for the “70s Lacan.” In the interests of highlighting the significance of Lacan’s reconceptualization of the object, I refrain from providing much account of the “70s Lacan” in this chapter.

20. Jacques Derrida, *Of Grammatology*, trans. Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1976), 158. The “Rome Discourse” was canonized by Anthony Wilden’s translation and presentation in 1968 of “The Function and Field of Speech and Language in Psychoanalysis” as Lacan, *The Language of the Self: The Function of Language in Psychoanalysis* (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1968). In his notes to a 1971 interview, Derrida used his famous formulation—“Il n’y a pas de hors-texte”—to gloss the Lacanian formulation that repudiates the possibility of a metalanguage: “There is no Other of the Other” (Jacques Derrida, *Positions*, trans. Alan Bass [Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1981], 111). This alignment suggests that if there were an Other of the Other, there would be a position outside the text from which the text could be judged without that judgment’s being textually contaminated. This would be a transcendent position, which both Derrida and Lacan supposedly discredit. However, although there is no Other (*A*) of the Other, there is an object (*a*) of the Other that remains strictly unassimilable to any text. It is for this reason that Lacan includes an extradiscursive cause, *a*, in his discourse structures. The question then is not whether there is an outside to the text but how the relation between inside and outside is to be thought. “Transcendence” is one way of naming that relation, but only so long as transcendent relations are conceived topologically.

We should distinguish this method of periodizing Lacan from the tendency to locate epistemological breaks or ruptures in the history of his thought, since such breaks often impose a false homogeneity of “before” and “after” on concepts that mutate without necessarily developing teleologically. For example, Slavoj Žižek’s commitment to treating the *Ethics* seminar of 1959–60 as just such a radical break—while it has undoubtedly revived the psychoanalysis of ideology and popular culture—inserts the complex discontinuities of Lacanian thought into a conversion narrative characteristic of ego formations, producing a “before” that is implicitly repudiated and an “after” that is embraced as the desired theoretical identity.²¹ Instead of a final state, the Bachelardian notion of epistemological rupture often produces two states, each of which is totalized by being contrasted with the other. An “after” Lacan does have the benefit of revealing a thinker who is more than the sum of his early influences. But the notion of a profound discontinuity between “early” and “late” Lacan leads to a repudiation of the “early” in the way that Macey and Borch-Jacobsen effectively repudiate the “late.”

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“40s Lacan”

Some early remarks about the mirror stage illuminate this issue of periodization:

The mirror stage isn’t a magic word. It’s already a bit dated. Since I put it out in 1936, it’s about twenty years old. It’s beginning to be in need of a bit of renovation—which isn’t always for the best, for in order to make progress, one should know how to go back

21. In “The Undergrowth of Enjoyment: How Popular Culture Can Serve as an Introduction to Lacan,” *New Formations* 9 (1989): 7–29, Žižek refers to “the break marked by the seminar on *Ethics of Psychoanalysis* (1959–60), a break which radically shifted the accent of [Lacan’s] teaching: from the dialectics of desire to the inertia of enjoyment (*jouissance*), from the symptom as coded message to the *sinthome* as letter permeated with enjoyment, from the ‘unconscious structured like a language’ to the Thing in its heart, the irreducible kernel of *jouissance* that resists all symbolization” (7). Where Žižek treats Seminar 7 as the point of radical break, Jacques-Alain Miller has spoken of Seminar 11, *The Four Fundamental Concepts of Psychoanalysis*, as the break (in “Context and Concepts,” in *Reading Seminar XI: Lacan’s Four Fundamental Concepts of Psychoanalysis*, ed. Richard Feldstein, Bruce Fink, and Maire Jaanus [Albany: SUNY Press, 1995], 5). And in “Reading the Real in the Seminar on the Psychoses,” in *Criticism and Lacan: Essays and Dialogue on Language, Structure, and the Unconscious*, ed. Patrick Colm Hogan and Lalita Pandit (Athens: University of Georgia Press, 1990), 64–83, Michael Walsh treats Seminar 3 as “a text which readily lends itself to nomination as a locus of the emergence of a more purely Lacanian contribution to psychoanalysis” (68).

over things. It isn't so much repeating it that is a bore, as not using it properly. (*SI* 102)

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The "40s Lacan" (a period that conventionally begins in 1936) emphasizes the mediation of the imaginary register, using optical models to describe the specular formation of the ego. The famous mirror stage is one description of how narcissism works, but it is certainly not Lacan's only one, as his model of the inverted bouquet shows. This model derives from a classical experiment in which a stand is placed in front of a large spherical mirror. When one places an empty vase on top of the stand and suspends a bouquet of flowers beneath it, their reflection in the spherical mirror produces an image of the flowers in the vase. By showing how a mirrored surface can register on the same plane and in the same perspective visual phenomena from different planes, Lacan's experiment of the inverted bouquet shows how the imaginary involves techniques of trickery.²² Imaginary identification forms the ego by means of a constitutive alienation in the specular other, for which the mirror is one classical, poetic figure. It is important to distinguish this specular other that founds the ego from the Other or object that founds the subject and its desire. Furthermore, we should not confuse the fascinating, seductive lure of the mirror—or the mythic jubilation encountered in the image—with desire (which is unconscious, not imaginary) or *jouissance* (which is real).

The mirror is a useful model for describing narcissism just so long as one bears in mind that its significance derives in large part from what cannot be seen in it. For centuries the technology of mirroring remained imperfect in one crucial sense, for the mirror was as likely to be the beloved's eyes or the aqueous surface in which one sought his own image as it was to be glass produced for purely reflective purposes: "In becoming fascinated by a mirror, and preferably by a mirror as it has always been since the beginning of humanity until a relatively recent period, more obscure than clear, mirror of burnished metal, the subject may succeed in revealing to himself many of the elements of his imaginary fixations" (*SI* 57). The mirror produces an ego by revealing what

22. A diagram of the inverted bouquet experiment may be found in *SI* 78. A more complex version of the diagram appears on 124, and a simplified diagram on 165. Lacan repeats the diagram in *SI* 109, referring to it as the "optical schema for the theory of narcissism." The classic discussion of this diagram appears in Jacqueline Rose, "The Imaginary," in *Sexuality in the Field of Vision* (London: Verso, 1986), 166–97.

cannot be “objectively” perceived—that which, though visual, cannot be registered independently by a material surface. This is why the domain of its effects is called imaginary. The experiment of the inverted bouquet produces an image of an object that has no objective existence outside the mirror, but nevertheless compels the viewer’s conviction. The ego is just such an object, produced through identifications that, as a consequence of their illusoriness, are bound to be frustrating. It is for this reason that Lacan resituates a central component of ego psychology by observing that the ego “is frustration in its essence” (E 42).

Although the imaginary dimension of the subject is the ego, Lacan takes great pains to avoid collapsing the subject into the ego; after all, this is precisely what he accuses ego psychology of doing. “[T]he unconscious is the unknown subject of the ego,” he maintains (SII 43). This claim should prompt us to question the relation between subject and ego—a question that also concerns the relation between imaginary and symbolic. This relation, which Lacan on one occasion describes as “ex-centric,” is what his various models try to conceptualize (SII 44). Much of this excentricity has been lost in the application of Lacan’s theory of imaginary identification to analyses of film and ideology. For example, Althusser’s famous definition of ideology as “the representation of the imaginary relationship of individuals to their real conditions of existence” restricts ideological effects to the domain of the imaginary.²³ Yet it is already clear in the “40s Lacan” of the imaginary—specifically, in his 1948 paper on “Aggressivity in Psychoanalysis”—that there is a crucial distinction between subject and ego:

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[W]e call ego that nucleus given to consciousness, but opaque to reflexion, marked by all the ambiguities which, from self-satisfaction to “bad faith” (*mauvaise foi*), structure the experience of the passions in the human subject; this “I” who, in order to admit its facticity to existential criticism, opposes its irreducible inertia of pretences and

23. Louis Althusser, “Ideology and Ideological State Apparatuses,” in *Lenin and Philosophy and Other Essays*, trans. Ben Brewster (New York: Monthly Review, 1971), 162. See also Christian Metz, *Psychoanalysis and Cinema: The Imaginary Signifier* (London: Macmillan, 1982). The Althusserian formulation of ideology has been developed most rigorously by Michel Pêcheux, *Language, Semantics and Ideology: Stating the Obvious*, trans. Harbans Nagpal (London: Macmillan, 1982), and most influentially by Benedict Anderson, *Imagined Communities: Reflections on the Origin and Spread of Nationalism* (New York: Verso, 1983). The best psychoanalytic critique of ideology in nonimaginary terms may be found in Slavoj Žižek, *The Sublime Object of Ideology* (New York: Verso, 1989).

méconnaissances to the concrete problematic of the realization of the subject. (E 15)

Couched in the vocabulary of existential phenomenology, this distinction between ego and subject is so marked as to constitute an opposition (“this ‘I’ . . . *opposes* its irreducible inertia . . . [to] the subject”). Yet once Lacan moves beyond phenomenology, his account of the subject-ego relation becomes more complex and interesting. These shifts take us to the “50s Lacan.”

“50s Lacan”

40

Throughout the 1950s Lacan moves from theorizing the imaginary to emphasizing the mediation of the symbolic register to focusing on the real Thing (*das Ding*). There is such conceptual productivity during this period that we might say that 40s, 50s, and 60s Lacans are actually all compressed into one historical decade—hence my effort to distinguish periods, theoretical emphases, and conceptual distinctions. The “50s Lacan” of the signifier, embraced by literary critics as part of a transatlantic wave of structuralism and poststructuralism, has been so approximately rendered that a number of elementary distinctions are in order.

The “50s Lacan” encompasses the famous “Rome Discourse” of 1953 and “The Agency of the Letter in the Unconscious, or Reason since Freud” (1957), the latter of which was the first *écrit* translated into English, in 1966. In these texts Lacan presented a theory of the linguistic unconscious by developing the rhetorical tropes of metaphor and metonymy, which he borrowed from Roman Jakobson’s classic paper on aphasia (and which I discuss at greater length in chapter 5). In so doing, Lacan followed Freud’s use of a classical literary narrative to theorize the principal unconscious formation—the Oedipus complex. As early as 1953, Lacan treats the Oedipus complex as a model, not as an unequivocal truth:

When we get on the trail of the unconscious, what we encounter are structured, organised, complex situations. Freud gave us the first model of it, its standard, in the Oedipus complex. Those of you who have followed my seminar for some time have had the opportunity to see for themselves to what extent the Oedipus complex poses problems and to what extent it contains ambiguities, thanks to the

commentary I made on those cases least subject to reservations on account of their having been so richly sketched in by Freud himself, namely three of the five great psychoanalyses. In short, the entire development of analysis has resulted from showing to advantage, one after another, each of the tensions implied within this triangular system. This fact alone requires us to see in it something quite different from this solid mass summed up in the classic formula—sexual attraction for the mother, rivalry with the father. (*SI* 65–66)

That Lacan proceeds to reinterpret the triangulated relations of Oedipus in terms of his own tripartite scheme of imaginary, symbolic, and real should prevent us from too readily assigning the Oedipus complex solely to the domain of the symbolic. Although we have noted Lacan's observation that what makes the Oedipus complex both universal and contin-
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gent is its "purely symbolic" character, the meaning of this symbolic character shifts throughout the fertile period of the 1950s. Perhaps the best way to elucidate these changes is to follow Lacan's shifting descriptions of clinical technique. During his 1950s "return to Freud," Lacan devoted extensive attention to questions of technique, in part owing to the relative neglect and consequent ossification of technical theory after World War II.

Lacan begins his "Rome Discourse" with the following assertion, revealing both the underlying assumption of "50s Lacan" and the reason he's been mischaracterized as a theorist merely of the linguistic subject: "Whether it sees itself as an instrument of healing, of training, or of exploration in depth, psychoanalysis has only a single medium: the patient's speech" (*E* 40). Lacan emphasized the importance of speech in response to the abandonment of linguistic questions in psychoanalytic theory and practice—hence his "return" during this period to the founding works of psychoanalysis, in which Freud finds the unconscious interrupting ordinary discourse in ways that suggest an *other* discourse, speech on another scene (*ein andere Schauplatz*).

If speech is the sole medium of psychoanalysis, then it follows that transference must be a symbolic, rather than a purely affective, phenomenon. One year later, however, Lacan describes transference in strictly imaginary terms: "When does transference really start? When the image which the subject requires becomes confused for the subject with the reality in which he is placed. The whole progress of the analysis is to

show him the distinction between these two planes, to unstick the imaginary and the real" (*SI* 241). To suggest that the method of "unsticking" imaginary and real must be a symbolic method fails to mitigate the predominance of the imaginary relation in this description of transference. The "image which the subject requires" is the imago in which he narcissistically recognizes and identifies himself; the "reality in which [the subject] is placed" is that of the analytic situation; and the moment at which the subject's imaginary relation fastens onto the analyst as the objective correlative of his ego is the moment transference begins. In this description, the analyst occupies—at least initially—the position neither of Other nor of object *a*, but of imaginary other.

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However, this scenario is complicated further when Lacan equates "the reality [*réalité*] in which he is placed" with "the real [*réel*]" from which the imaginary relation must be dissociated. Too much confusion stems from equating "reality" and the Lacanian real for me to pass this description without comment. "Reality" is not commensurate with the unsymbolizable real that forms one order in the triad imaginary-symbolic-real, since for Lacan what we call reality is closer to what he means by the imaginary. Nevertheless, all three registers are involved in transference and hence in the technique of analysis: "I am rather inclined to leave intact the empirical totality of the notion of transference, all the while remarking that it is plurivalent and that it acts in several registers at a time, in the symbolic, the imaginary and the real" (*SI* 112–13). While one's narcissistic identifications may be altered in analysis, this is not the primary goal of psychoanalysis—just as consolidating those identifications is also not the point of Lacanian technique, though it's often implicitly the aim of more ego psychology–based analyses.

This question of imaginary and symbolic relations in transference crystallizes in Lacan's 1951 reading of Freud's Dora case, "Intervention on Transference," in which his emphasis on the dialectical relation of speech goes hand in hand with his characterization of transference in imaginary terms. As a consequence of this early conception of analysis in terms of Hegelian dialectics, commentators such as Borch-Jacobsen have concluded that Lacanian theory may be described in primarily imaginary terms, as if Lacan offered nothing more than a revamped theory of narcissism. Thus although Lacan begins his account of Dora with a reference to the "immediate given" of analysis—"the self-evident

fact that it deals solely with words" ("Intervention" 63)—the dialectical stages through which his interpretation moves culminate in his description of Dora's "imaginary matrix": "the original *imago* shows us that her only opening to the object was through the intermediary of the masculine partner, with whom, because of the slight difference in years, she was able to identify, in that primordial identification through which the subject recognises itself as *I*" ("Intervention" 68).

The confusion stemming from Lacan's early conception of transference in imaginary terms may be attributed to his emphasis on the *intersubjectivity* of speech, since the idea of intersubjectivity remains an imaginary rather than a symbolic one. That is, intersubjectivity pictures relationality as subject-to-subject, rather than subject-to-Other. In his "Intervention on Transference," Lacan emphasizes intersubjectivity in order to distinguish his version of psychoanalysis from "all psychology considered as the objectification of certain properties of the individual" ("Intervention" 62). But a decade later he begins his seminar on transference with a critique of intersubjectivity (*SVIII* 20–26). The problem with the idea of the intersubjective dialectic is, as Lacan noted of Hegel, that intersubjectivity remains at the limit of anthropology, in which the other always retains the status of subject. Thus intersubjective relations are, in principle if not in practice, symmetrical and reversible. But when Lacan reconceives the subject-other relation as a subject-Other relation, he insists that there cannot be an Other of the Other, since the Other's conceptual value—as it accumulated throughout the 1950s—is that it is strictly divested of subjective status. The subject-Other relation, which describes a fully *symbolic* subject, is definitively asymmetrical.

Unfortunately, there is no tidy progression from the other to the Other in Lacan's work. In this respect, Seminar 2, on the ego, seems more Lacanian than Seminar 3, on psychoses.²⁴ For example, in a very suggestive seminar session entitled "The Circuit" (by which he means the symbolic circuit of language), Lacan proposes a distinction between

24. In "Deux axiomatiques des psychoses," *Ornicar?* 44 (1988): 52–64, Dimitris Vergetis makes a fine argument for distinguishing between the account of psychosis given in Seminar 3, *Les psychoses* (1955–56), and that given in "On a Question Preliminary to any Possible Treatment of Psychosis" (1959), which *écrit* was supposed to summarize the findings of the seminar. Based on an analysis of the conceptual shift in schema L from seminar to *écrit*, Vergetis argues that in the seminar "the concept of the Other still remains a prisoner of the status of the subject" (53). It is for this reason that Lacan defines psychosis in terms of the *exclusion of the Other* in the seminar, while in the *écrit* he defines psychosis in terms of the *foreclosure of the Name-of-the-Father*. I discuss further these shifts in the conceptualization of psychosis in chapter 3.

other and Other: "the unconscious is the discourse of the other. This discourse of the other is not the discourse of the abstract other, of the other in the dyad, of my correspondent, nor even of my slave, it is the discourse of the circuit in which I am integrated. I am one of its links" (*SII* 89). The discourse of the *other* retains the structure of intersubjective communication, in which "the sender receives his own message back from the receiver in an inverted form" (*E* 85). But the discourse of the *Other*, the locus of the unconscious, comprehends speech within the field of discourse. In this view, the subject's communication partner is not the other but the signifying chain into which he or she is articulated.

44 This distinction between different modes of alterity holds crucial implications for Lacan's theory of desire, because his early conception of it as "desire of the other" maintains desire within a Kojève-Hegelian intersubjective dialectic, in which it is impossible not to reduce desire—and fantasy—to imaginary scenarios.²⁵ For example, in an early passage remarkable for its self-consciousness, Lacan refers to "the fundamental Hegelian theme—man's desire is the desire of the other," a theme he discusses in strictly imaginary terms via reference to "Jacques Lacan's classical mirror phase" (*SI* 146). In Hegel desire is the desire for recognition, a desire for the other to ratify my existence by means of affirmation; thus insofar as the imaginary is ordered by recognitions and especially by misrecognitions (*méconnaissances*), this Hegelian perspective reduces desire to the imaginary level.

Speech is implicated in this dialectical structure because speech implicitly includes a demand, for both recognition and love. Lacan's categories of "full" and "empty" speech depend on a distinction between speech that performs recognition and speech that does not: "Full speech is speech which aims at, which forms, the truth such as it becomes established in the recognition of one person by another" (*SI* 107). Because speech, conceived according to Hegelian dialectics, includes a demand for recognition, verbal utterance plays its part in the ordering of imaginary relations. And thus in the model of the inverted bouquet speech functions to skew the mirror. Lacan elegantly summarizes this

25. This can be seen in Lacan's early definition of the system of the ego as including "fundamental fantasies which orient and direct the subject" (*SI* 17), a definition that will be supplanted by the later formula for fantasy ($\$ \diamond a$), which conjoins symbolic $\$$ and a ("remainder" of the real), rather than conceiving fantasy in imaginary terms.

way of picturing imaginary-symbolic relations: "In my little model [of the inverted bouquet], in order to conceive of the incidence of the symbolic relation, all you have to do is assume that it is the introduction of linguistic relations which produces the swings of the mirror, which will offer the subject, in the other, in the absolute other, the various aspects of his desire" (*SI* 157). Here Lacan's account of desire as unfolding within an imaginary-symbolic scheme must be distinguished from his subsequent account of desire as an unconscious effect of the cause he names object *a*. At this moment in Lacan's thinking, his notion of the object as something that can never appear in the mirror—and which therefore remains heterogeneous to the imaginary register—has not yet emerged.

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Toward a Model for Desire

This notion of the object—the object *a* that causes desire—emerges fully in the "60s Lacan," even though an earlier seminar, *Le désir et son interprétation* (1958–59), is explicitly devoted to the question of desire. This transitional period, 1958–59, is to my mind the most problematic in Lacan's work. Not incidentally, it is also the period during which Lacan directly theorizes the phallus, a concept I want to resituate as provisional rather than foundational. I consider the phallus a provisional concept because so many of its functions are taken over by other concepts, in particular that of object *a*, which has no a priori relation to gender and, indeed, may be represented by objects gendered masculine, feminine, or neuter. To a certain extent, the logic of his concept of the object supersedes that of the phallus, even though Lacan continued to retain the term *phallus* throughout his career. For whatever reason, Lacan appeared not to realize that his own subsequent thinking makes the concept of the phallus largely obsolete; and his followers have done their best to obscure this obsolescence by continuing to insist that the phallus retain its status as an indispensable term within the Lacanian conceptual system.²⁶

In order to make this argument, which amounts to dethroning a

26. I have since found confirmation of this thesis in the work of certain non-Millerian Lacanian analysts in Paris. See, for example, Michel Tort, "The New Testament of Lacan" (unpublished manuscript), which argues that Lacan's theory of the phallus is a phallic theory, a theory generated from within the phallic stage and therefore subject to supersession.

Lacanian shibboleth from a rather different vantage point from the customary attacks launched on it, I consider it necessary to elaborate a methodological qualification regarding the status of conceptual models in Lacan's work. As is well known, throughout his career Lacan borrows models, ideas, and terminology from other disciplines to theorize subjectivity in increasingly complex ways. These disparate models and their accompanying terminology come and go with such dizzying frequency in Lacan's work that we would be mistaken in too readily hypostasizing any one of them. For instance, when furnishing his seminar audience with an optical model for grasping the imaginary order's functioning, Lacan makes clear that this model of the inverted bouquet represents "a substitute for the mirror-stage" (*SI* 74). The model of the inverted bouquet offers a different way—perhaps at the moment it is introduced a better way—of explaining how the imaginary works and how the ego is formed.

When presenting this model, Lacan quotes a passage from *The Interpretation of Dreams*, in which Freud rationalizes his own use of analogical models, such as the compound microscope or the camera, to explain how the psychic apparatus works. Lacan cites the following to justify the introduction of his own new optical model:

Analogies of this kind are only intended to assist us in our attempt to make the complications of mental functioning intelligible by dissecting the function and assigning its different constituents to different component parts of the apparatus. So far as I know, the experiment has not hitherto been made of using this method of dissection in order to investigate the way in which the mental instrument is put together, and I can see no harm in it. We are justified, in my view, in giving free rein to our speculations so long as we retain the coolness of our judgement and *do not mistake the scaffolding for the building* . . . [A]t our first approach to something unknown all that we need is the assistance of provisional ideas. (*SE* 5:536; quoted *SI* 75; my emphasis)

Freud's point is that thinking proceeds analogically, using what is known to get to the unknown, and that in this process we do well to remember that the analogies or models thus employed remain provisional, subject to supersession when other models come to hand. Following this elementary methodological qualification, I want to argue that when we insist on invoking the concept of the phallus to talk about desire, we're

effectively mistaking the scaffolding for the building, forgetting the model's epistemological status as provisional.

In order to begin demonstrating this thesis, I turn to Lacan's essay on "The Signification of the Phallus" (1958), in which he elaborates his theory of the phallus for the purpose of generating a fully symbolic account of desire. Departing from his more Hegelian formulations concerning desire, Lacan describes desire in "The Signification of the Phallus" as "desire of the Other." Similarly, by 1958 the unconscious has become the discourse of the Other, and the Other is conceived in thoroughly linguistic terms as "the level of the chain of materially unstable elements that constitutes language" (E 285). In other words, his theory of desire has been detached from the category of the imaginary other as a causal explanation and resituated as an effect of language.

Consequent upon this depersonalized conception of the Other, Lacan's understanding of speech as always entailing a demand for love takes on a more symbolic character. This account makes desire unconscious, structured metonymically, yet it still does not postulate a nonlinguistic object *a* as the causal principle of desire. Hence the following well-known definition of desire:

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For the unconditional element of demand, desire substitutes the "absolute" condition: this condition unties the knot of that element in the proof of love that is resistant to the satisfaction of a need. Thus desire is neither the appetite for satisfaction, nor the demand for love, but the difference that results from the subtraction of the first from the second, the phenomenon of their splitting (*Spaltung*). (E 287)

According to this definition, desire *resists* satisfaction and remains qualitatively distinct from biological need and from the Freudian notion of wish, since both needs and wishes can be satisfied, whereas it is in the nature of desire to be insatiable.²⁷ By this account, desire remains unconscious because it is articulated in the signifying chain without being fully articulable by the subject. In this respect Lacanian desire seems

27. For a meticulous analysis of these and related distinctions, see Charles Shepherdson, "The Epoch of the Body: Need and Demand in Kojève and Lacan," in *Perspectives on Embodiment: The Intersections of Nature and Culture*, ed. Gail Weiss and Honi Fern Haber (New York: Routledge, 1999), 183–211. See also Shepherdson, "The Gift of Love and the Debt of Desire," *Differences* 10, no. 1 (1998): 30–74.

conceptually proximate to what Freud meant by an unconscious wish, whose expression can be only ever indirect and disguised.

Having defined desire abstractly, Lacan gets more concrete, suggesting that the central problem in human sexual relations—one of the reasons sexual relations fail—is that “for both partners in the relation . . . it is not enough to be subjects of need, or objects of love, but that they must stand for the cause of desire” (E 287). The name Lacan gives this “cause of desire” in 1958 is *the phallus*: “The phallus is the privileged signifier of that mark in which the role of the logos is joined with the advent of desire” (E 287). In other words, the phallic signifier connects the function of signification to what causes desire—what it is outside the signifying chain that enables desire. That is to say, although desire is in language, it is not purely linguistic.

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Why is the phallus given this causative role with respect to desire? Lacan explains:

It can be said that this signifier is chosen because it is the most tangible element in the real of sexual copulation, and also the most symbolic in the literal (typographical) sense of the term, since it is equivalent there to the (logical) copula. It might also be said that, by virtue of its turgidity, it is the *image* of the vital flow as it is transmitted in generation. (E 287; emphasis added)²⁸

As *image*, the phallus is not exactly a signifier or a real cause of desire. Lacan's recourse, in this passage, to an image of the phallus suggests just how hard it is to completely divest the phallic signifier of its imaginary trappings—and therefore how hard it is to generate a fully symbolic, nonimaginary account of desire using this concept. But irrespective of the problems in this passage, its complex rationale for adopting the phallus as “the privileged signifier of that mark in which the role of the logos is joined with the advent of desire” need not be embraced without question in order to justify a Lacanian theory of desire and sexuality. The great advantage of Lacan's theory of desire, as I develop it through-

28. This passage continues: “All these propositions merely conceal the fact that [the phallus] can play its role only when veiled, that is to say, as itself a sign of the latency with which any signifiable is struck, when it is raised (*aufgehoben*) to the function of the signifier” (E 288). Here the phallus functions as a metaphor by virtue of its potential for erection, in that Lacan compares the sublation, or raising up, to which entities become subject in language with the elevation of the penis during sexual excitement. The function of the phallic signifier thus depends for its intelligibility on an *image* of the penis.

out this book, lies in its resistance to normalization, since he consistently pokes fun at the heterosexist *idée reçue* that genital relations between the sexes represent an ideal for psychological maturity: "It has to be said here that the French analysts, with their hypocritical notion of genital oblativity, opened the way to the moralizing tendency, which, to the accompaniment of its Salvationist choirs, is now to be found everywhere" (E 287). In thus mocking the accepted norm of sexual life—including the norm as promulgated by psychoanalysis—Lacan undermines one of the principal assumptions buttressing the pathologization of same-sex erotic desire. That this antinormative remark should come in his article theorizing the phallus as signifier of signifiers indicates the degree to which conceptual and ideological tensions remain unresolved in this period of his work.

The extent of these tensions becomes even clearer in a contemporaneous *écrit*, "The Direction of the Treatment and the Principles of Its Power" (1958), in which Lacan reiterates his post-Hegelian definition of desire: "produced as it is by an animal at the mercy of language, man's desire is the desire of the Other" (E 264). Lacan pictures ever more starkly the nonreciprocity of the subject-Other relation when he describes desire as "the mark of the iron of the signifier on the shoulder of the speaking subject" (E 265). This vivid description continues:

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[Desire] is not so much a pure passion of the signified as a pure action of the signifier that stops at the moment when the living being becomes sign, rendering it insignificant.

This moment of cut is haunted by the form of a bloody scrap—the pound of flesh that life pays in order to turn it into the signifier of the signifiers, which it is impossible to restore, as such, to the imaginary body; it is the lost phallus of the embalmed Osiris. (E 265)

Lacan often has recourse to the Shakespearean, potentially anti-Semitic figure of "the pound of flesh" to describe the toll exacted by symbolic alienation; however, he does not always specify the form of this "bloody scrap" in terms of the phallus. While he remains consistent in characterizing desire as consequent upon a forced separation or "cut," he figures the corporeal morsel that is lost thereby in a variety of ways. It is because any number of body parts can stand in for this "bloody scrap" that Lacan's catalogue of objects *a* contains so many examples and implies such varied possibilities for desire.

Since it is primarily the phallus's *imaginary* attributes that permit it to represent the signifier of signifiers, we must deduce that it is purely conventional and therefore, in the final analysis, arbitrary that the phallus should hold any indisputable priority in relation to the symbolic order's exigencies. Though Lacan never relinquished the phallus as a concept, his theory of object *a* makes clear that desire has multiple causes, many of which have no relation whatsoever to gender or sexual difference. Rather than trying to purify the phallus of its imaginary residue or, alternatively, showing the impossibility of any such purification, I want to suggest that the phallus as Lacan's model for the causal principle of desire may be bracketed once the full significance of object *a* comes into view. Such an appreciation enables us to move beyond interminable and increasingly sterile debates over the phallogocentric biases of Lacan's account of the phallus toward a more interesting "60s Lacan" of the object.²⁹

"60s Lacan"

At the end of the 1950s, in his seminar *The Ethics of Psychoanalysis*, and throughout the 1960s, Lacan's emphasis shifts from the symbolic order to the nonsymbolic real. During this period Lacan qualifies the determinations of the signifier by another level of causality—that of the object as cause of desire. In other words, "60s Lacan" focuses on the limits rather than the omnipotence of the symbolic order. These limits can be deduced from the resistance to symbolization of elements that Lacan tends to describe in logical, rather than phenomenological, terms. His principal name for this limit is *the real*. In order to fully assess the sub-

29. The kind of debates I have in mind, most of which demonstrate familiarity only with the pre-60s Lacan, are represented in *Differences* 4, no. 1 (1992), special issue on "The Phallus." I find particularly helpful Parveen Adams's essay in that collection, "Waiving the Phallus" (76–83; reprint in Adams, *The Emptiness of the Image*, 49–56), since Adams recognizes that "[t]he concept of the phallus puts in play all three orders of the Imaginary, the Symbolic, and the Real and this is its complexity as a concept, a complexity rarely acknowledged" (82). More importantly, Adams acknowledges that the phallus is not the central component of Lacan's theory of desire, since phallic identification "produces the subject of the signifier and not the subject of desire" (ibid.)—which is why the phallus can, to some degree, be waived. In my reading of Lacan, any tenable distinction between the subject of the signifier and the subject of desire is rather difficult to maintain, since the former gives rise to the latter. We might say that the subject of the signifier and the subject of desire represent two sides of the same coin. Nevertheless, Adams is elaborating a version of the distinction I'm making between the phallus as cause of desire (in Lacanian doctrine, circa 1958) and the object as cause of desire. For her emphasis on the "phallic identification" that produces the subject of the signifier, I would substitute an analysis of *normative* identification.

ject's relation to language and representation, it makes sense that we take into account a logical limit internal to symbolization. And although in this respect it is defined wholly negatively, the real nonetheless has a positive role to play in subject formation, since it represents not only a barrier to subjective or symbolic realization, but also the impossibility against which symbolization is constantly being elaborated. In other words, the real is generative, not simply constraining.³⁰

The difficulty with this concept—and surely the reason it has been so comparatively neglected in Lacan's Anglophone reception—is that it remains so abstract. Unfortunately, this nonsymbolic real cannot be pointed to, as a positivist inclination might prompt us to wish, since the real has no substance. Throughout this book, I rehearse different ways of describing the real, offering a range of examples to suggest the positive effects of its purely negative presence. At this point, let me just say that what Lacan calls the real can be inferred from trauma, whose effects are characterized by a recurring impossibility or blockage, a deep impact that calls out for—yet resists—symbolization. Understood in terms of trauma, the real designates not so much a zone of emptiness as of resistance. And thus it would be inaccurate to say that the real *precedes* language in any intuitive sense, since its temporality conforms to the deferred, nonlinear chronology of trauma, which is characterized by what Freud called *Nachträglichkeit*, or belatedness. Because the temporality of the real is *nachträglich*, this concept implies a different, more complex notion of causality than the linear, Newtonian understanding of causation with which we're generally familiar. Needless to say, different concepts of temporality and causality may help us formulate a different idea of history and historicity. Psychoanalytic concepts are not so much indifferent to the claims of historicity as they are grounded in an alternative understanding of it. And this distinction bears on the historicist commitment to a purely immanentist critique of history and causality.

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30. One way of illustrating the generative effects of this negativity would have reference to John Forrester's intriguing thesis concerning the indispensable role in childhood development of mendacity. In his most recent book, *Truth Games: Lies, Money, and Psychoanalysis* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1997), Forrester argues (following Freud) that the child's first lie to its parents is crucial for opening up the child's own subjectivity and desire, since by making itself opaque to its parents the child creates a symbolic world distinct from that of its caretakers. This insight may be rephrased in Lacanian terms by pointing to the dimension of duplicity inherent to language. Since whatever language says can be denied, a fundamental negativity inhabits linguistic subjects—a negativity Lacan calls the real.

As a consequence of the real's irreducibility to either symbolic structures or brute materiality—its immanence in neither language nor phenomena—the real can be conceived in terms of transcendence. Hence its foreignness to the logic of historicism.³¹ Aligning the real with a certain notion of transcendence permits us to suggest that the real is like God in that it does not exist (it has no positive existential status), yet it obtains palpable effects nonetheless—effects rendered through the symbolic. Since both the real and the symbolic, defined as mutually exclusive, produce subjective effects, neither order should be considered a determinist concept. Their effects cannot be known in advance, but can be extrapolated only from the specifically differentiated relations among real, symbolic, and imaginary. The psychoanalytic subject is a product of these relations. Hence the subject in “60s Lacan” is mapped not *topographically* (as a position), nor temporally (as a moment of fading), nor even semiologically (as a linguistic differential). Rather, the psychoanalytic subject of the 1960s, defined by its relation to object *a*, is mapped *topologically*, its structure conceived in terms of non-Euclidean space.

Here we enter particularly difficult conceptual terrain. Mapped topologically, the psychoanalytic subject is so far from approximating any notion of the discrete individual person as to be virtually unrecognizable. And thus even without grasping the details of Lacan's shifting theoretical emphases, we immediately can see just how far he has gone beyond theorizing the subject psychologically. I think it is worth pursuing Lacan's increasingly abstract accounts of subjectivity, because his later formulations, alien though they may appear, offer a range of implications for rethinking interpersonal relations and, in particular, the relations between subject and society. It is perhaps only a topologically mapped subject whose relation to the object can be thought of as transcendent without at the same time lapsing into metaphysics, since—abstract and counterintuitive as it is—topology is not theology.³² Indeed, it is this transcendent relation that Slavoj Žižek captures in his title *The Sublime Object of Ideology*, for the subject's *relation* to the object

31. As Copjec succinctly puts it, “some notion of transcendence is plainly needed if one is to avoid the reduction of social space to the relations that fill it” (*Read My Desire*, 7).

32. Useful accounts of Lacan's use of topology may be found in Jeanne Granon-Lafont, *La topologie ordinaire de Jacques Lacan* (Paris: Point Hors Ligne, 1985), and Johann Listing, *Introduction à la topologie*, trans. Claude Léger and Michael Turnheim (Paris: Navarin, 1989).

is what makes it sublime. Hence I persist with the notion of transcendence not in order to elude historical contingency, or the material grounding of social relations, or a sense of the subject's constructedness. Rather, I want to insist on those "subjective foundations" of object *a* that remain irreducible to these dimensions, and I want to describe them in terms of transcendence in order to designate a locus of conceptual value.

As a branch of modern mathematics, topology may help us rethink the subject's relation to its desire, because topological descriptions of space formulate relationality in radically new ways. For example, finding a rational way to describe how the "outside" functions as the subject's innermost core permits us to redescribe the subject of the unconscious, since, according to Freud, the unconscious knows no contradiction. A theory that provides logical means for overcoming spatial and propositional contradictions offers extremely useful tools for describing the psychoanalytic subject. By reformulating—not simply deconstructing—the relation between inside and outside, a topological account holds the potential for engendering new theories of social relations.³³ Hence, for instance, the possibility of rethinking the public-private distinction so central to social theory, jurisprudence, and ethics, to name a few.

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From a psychoanalytic perspective, it is not so much a question of "blurring the boundaries" between inner and outer as it is of revealing how the outside—an alien alterity—inhabits the subject's most intimate inwardness. Lacan coined a neologism for this reconception of the inside-outside relationship, and his reference to *extimité*, or "extimacy," has been developed into a full-blown theory by his son-in-law, Jacques-Alain Miller (whose seminars on Lacan have taken the place of Lacan's seminars on Freud, in the Parisian psychoanalytic milieu, since Lacan's demise).³⁴ Whereas contemporary critiques of the public-private distinc-

33. For an interesting consideration of the sexual politics of reconceiving the relation between inside and outside, see Diana Fuss, "Inside/Out," in *Inside/Out: Lesbian Theories, Gay Theories*, ed. Diana Fuss (New York: Routledge, 1991), 1–10. Fuss's meticulous deconstruction of the inside/out opposition, on which so many other oppositions are based, almost moves beyond deconstruction with her recognition that, conventionally speaking, Lacan's topological structures have neither inside nor outside. The choice of a figure akin to a Borromean knot as the illustration for the cover of this anthology of gay and lesbian theory points to a conjunction between the topological Lacan and queer theory that remains to be realized.

34. In a pattern reminiscent of Lacan's, Miller devoted his seminar for the 1985–86 academic year to the topic of extimacy and then published a redaction of that work in article form. See

tion tend to focus on how the boundary between public and private is constructed in the service of social regulation, especially the social regulation of sexuality, a psychoanalytic critique of privacy might show not that privacy is a pernicious legal fiction so much as its connection to the public realm of language and convention is structured and produced differently. The kind of protection that privacy entails has less to do with personal intimacy than with one's relations to social institutions (grouped by Lacan under the rubric of "the big Other"), since, from a psychoanalytic point of view, interpersonal intimacy is predicated on impersonal, public relations, rather than the reverse. In other words, the subject's relation to the Other provides the basis for his or her relations—social, legal, sexual, ethical—with other people. Rethinking the relation between subject and society in this way has wide-ranging implications, especially for recent debates about public sex within queer theory, some strands of which I take up in chapter 4.

I've been suggesting that subjective relations require rethinking in more complex ways because our customary psychological, philosophical, and sociological models tend to reduce relationality to two or, at most, three dimensions. From Lacan's perspective, even the subject-object relation always involves more than two elements. And therefore his increasing interest in topology stems in part from his quaternary models of subjectivity, since as soon as the dialectic's tripartite structure reaches its conceptual limit, quadripartite structures become increasingly difficult to formalize without a different idea of relationality.³⁵ Indeed, topological mappings of space may be especially appropriate for theorizing psychic space. As Victor Burgin has pointed out in a remarkably suggestive essay, space has a history, the most recent chapter of which marks the demise of the anthropocentric certainties of Euclidean geometric space. Arguing that twentieth-century technology has effectively converted space into time, Burgin reproaches theorists of repre-

Jacques-Alain Miller, "Extimité," in *Lacanian Theory of Discourse: Subject, Structure, Society*, ed. Mark Bracher, Marshall W. Alcorn Jr., Ronald J. Corthell, and Françoise Massardier-Kenney (New York: New York University Press, 1994), 74–87.

35. This connection between topology and quaternarity supports my hypothesis that topology is not tainted by theology, that its conception of relations is far from metaphysical, because Lacan's topological models distance his 1960s work from what might otherwise be considered troubling forms of trinitarianism. Not only is the topologically conceived real-symbolic-imaginary triad (RSI) of "70s Lacan" supplemented by the fourth order of the *sinthome*, but the Borromean knot structure of RSI is more accurately conceived as a chain made up of any number of elements. That is, the Borromean knot is tied with a *minimum* of three loops.

sentation for clinging to outmoded assumptions of Euclidean geometry, which maps space perspectivally and therefore centrically, rather than excentrically, as Lacan will map the subject. Although Burgin's argument moves toward a topological consideration of Kristeva's abject rather than Lacan's object, one of his central questions, premised on the historicity of space, remains highly pertinent for us here: "[w]hy should we suppose that the condensations and displacements of desire show any more regard for Euclidean geometry than they do for Aristotelian logic?"³⁶ In order to take seriously psychoanalysis's resituating desire at the level of the unconscious, I think it's worth pursuing Lacan's forays into topology, no matter how eccentric or abstract they may appear on first encounter.

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Mapping the Object Topologically

The most obvious benefit of theorizing objects of desire from such a decentered perspective lies in how this approach gets us beyond an imaginary conceptualization of desire. Such a move enables us to think about desire outside the appropriative and incorporative vectors of the ego. Indeed, situating desire in terms of the unconscious separates desire from narcissism and its ills. Yet any move beyond imaginary conceptions of desire remains cognitively challenging, since topological mappings cannot be pictured intuitively, only mathematically. A further problem with topological formalizations of subjectivity is that they're cognate with the impulse to systematize psychoanalytic theory.³⁷ Given this problem, it seems to me a virtue rather than a deficit that Lacan's use of topology remains as haphazard as it does, since his only rudimentary grasp of advanced mathematics makes it that much harder for us to systematize his thinking.

36. Victor Burgin, "Geometry and Abjection," in *Abjection, Melancholia, and Love: The Work of Julia Kristeva*, ed. John Fletcher and Andrew Benjamin (New York: Routledge, 1990), 111.

37. In an updated edition of her *Psychoanalytic Politics*, Sherry Turkle argues that Lacan turned to mathematical models and formal logic only under the influence, toward the end of his life, of his philosopher son-in-law: "While Lacan produced concepts that were deliberately ambiguous and open to multiple interpretations, Miller sought to rationalize them in the direction of greater logical coherence and uniformity. This 'corrected,' more 'coherent' version of Lacan facilitated attacks on now more easily identifiable theoretical enemies" (Turkle, *Psychoanalytic Politics: Jacques Lacan and Freud's French Revolution* [New York: Guilford, 1992], 253). Her book's second edition provides a useful account of the origins of doctrinal intolerance among Millerians—an intolerance in which mathemes certainly play a role.

We may begin to see how Lacan derives his concept of the object from topology rather than from psychoanalytic object-relations theory by considering an important footnote added, in 1966, to his 1959 article on psychosis. As I elaborate at length in chapter 3, this article, "On a Question Preliminary to any Possible Treatment of Psychosis," contains Lacan's first development of properly quadripartite schemas, which map the psychoanalytic subject "over the four corners of the schema: namely, S, his ineffable, stupid existence, *o*, his objects, *o'*, his ego, that is, that which is reflected of his form in his objects, and O, the locus from which the question of his existence may be presented to him" (E 194). (It helps to bear in mind, when considering this quadripartition of the subject, that Lacan's translator, Alan Sheridan, has put into English what conventionally is left in French: the phrase "*o*, his objects" refers to those *objets petit a*, where *a* stands for *autre*.) What Lacan means by referring to the subject's "ineffable, stupid existence" is the subject's being in the real. He describes it as ineffable because, at this point in his thinking, Lacan lacks the conceptual and terminological means for articulating this dimension of subjectivity.

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However, the crucial footnote appended seven years later retroactively confers on this schema a topological dimension that helps account for his derivation of object *a*:

The mapping in this schema R of the object (*objet a*) is interesting for the light it sheds on the field of reality (the field that bars it).

I have since laid great stress on the need to develop it—by stating that this field functions only by obturating itself [*s'obturer*] from the screen of phantasy—but this still requires a good deal of attention.

There might be some point in recognizing that, enigmatic as it may then have seemed, but perfectly legible for anyone who knows the outcome, as is the case if one claims to use it as a support, what schema R shows is a projective plan.

In particular the points . . . are those that frame the only valid cut in this schema . . . [and] are sufficient indication that this cut isolates a Moebius strip in the field.

To say this is to say all, since this field will now be merely the representative of the phantasy of which this cut provides the entire structure.

I mean that only the cut reveals the structure of the entire surface

from being able to detach from it those two heterogeneous elements (represented in my algorithm ($\$ \diamond a$) of the phantasy . . .).

It is as the representative of the representation in phantasy, therefore, that is to say as the originally repressed subject that $\$$, the barred S of desire, here supports the field of reality, and this field is sustained only by the extraction of the object a , which, however, gives it its frame.

. . . Whoever has followed my topological expositions (which are justified by nothing but the structure of the phantasy to be articulated) must know very well that in the Moebius strip there is nothing measurable to be retained in its structure, and that it is reduced, like the real with which we are concerned here, to the cut itself.

This note is indicative for the present stage of my topological elaboration (July 1966). (*E* 223–24 n. 18)

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This footnote gives us Lacan at his most elliptical and abstract. But it is worth pursuing him here because he's getting at the problem of how to specify a relationship between heterogeneous elements.

Lacan begins this note by distinguishing "the field of reality" from "the screen of phantasy" in a manner quite different from the conventional distinction between fantasy and reality. Not only is the object a —the object of fantasy, as well as of desire—nowhere to be found in "the field of reality," but it is also not to be found in the imaginary register. In contrast to our usual view of the matter, Lacan suggests that fantasy and desire don't concern imagined, hallucinatory objects as distinct from actually existing objects. Rather, objects of fantasy (objects a) are forever lost—even from the visual projections of the imagination—thanks to their cutting away from the subject that they thereby bring into being.

Here Lacan is trying to specify the relation between the subject of desire ($\$$) and the object-cause of its desire (a), since this relation describes the structure of fantasy, which he writes using the formula ($\$ \diamond a$). Once subject and object are conceived as radically heterogeneous, formulating the mode of relationship between them poses a distinct problem. Lacan's schema R suggests a solution to this problem—though it took Lacan himself quite some time to figure it out—because cutting along this schema's axes produces the elementary topological form of a Möbius strip. This is why Lacan says that schema

R shows “a projective plan,” since, in mathematical terms, the projective property of a geometrical figure remains unchanged when the figure undergoes projection. And by producing a surface whose geometrical properties remain inconceivable in Euclidean terms, a Möbius strip demonstrates the heuristic potential of a form whose inside and outside are continuous, indivisible, though not identical. This form provides an unusual way of relating heterogeneous elements, and Lacan maintains that “there is nothing measurable to be retained in its structure,” since it partakes only of the negativity of the “cut.”

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It is through this notion of the cut that Lacan most directly theorizes object *a*—object *a* is produced by cutting away something from the subject. Whereas earlier Lacan described this cut in fairly conventional terms, insisting that “[t]his moment of cut is haunted by the form of a bloody scrap,” which he then identified with the phallus, now he describes it differently, in topological terms, as an *internal* cut, the “extraction” of some element from a domain that thereby constitutes that domain and, indeed, “gives it its frame.” Hence the sentence asserting that “[i]t is as the representative of the representation in phantasy, therefore, that is to say as the originally repressed subject[,] that $\$$, the barred *S* of desire, here supports the field of reality, and this field is sustained only by the extraction of the object *a*, which, however, gives it its frame.” The kind of cut that produces object and subject both is not a border separation, a more or less culturally regulated division between domains or acceptable objects of desire. Instead, this is an internal cut, one that constitutively ensures the separation of subject and object by making the subject’s reality and its desire depend on the object’s never coming into view, never entering the field of reality or of imaginary relations. Hence the frustrating sense, in this passage, that the objects of desire we picture to ourselves are merely substitutes, doubly mediated promises of fulfillment that sustain—while never satisfying—desire. Lacan is getting at this notion that the subject remains separated from its objects by a complexly doubled mediation when he refers to “the representative of the representation in phantasy.” Another way of putting this would be to identify the three different modes of alterity—corresponding to the three registers of imaginary, symbolic, and real—that constitute the subject.³⁸

38. In “Two Kinds of Other and Their Consequences,” I distinguished between imaginary and symbolic modes of alterity. In this book I am concerned more with the third mode of alterity that

The agent of the cut that produces both subject and object is, of course, language. According to Lacan, symbolic networks dissect the human body, producing leftovers that cause desire. He explains that the psychoanalytic subject “thinks as a consequence of the fact that a structure, that of language—the word implies it—a structure carves up his body, a structure that has nothing to do with anatomy. Witness the hysteric” (*Television* 6). The ill fit between language and the body introduces wrinkles and gaps that generate desire. We might say that the unconscious and desire exist only as a consequence of this disharmony between the structures of language and those of the body. Since there are certainly better and worse fits between bodies and symbolic networks, the category of hysteria was invented to describe a particularly bad fit, a subjective wrinkle so pronounced as to disfigure the body itself. And if we accept that the symbolic order causes illness, it follows that language also can alleviate it—hence the idea of a talking cure. Yet we would be mistaken in assuming that the body could be made to conform perfectly to the structure of language. No amount of talking—or of cutting, augmenting, scarring, tattooing, starving, or exercising the body—can alleviate completely the disjunction of the unconscious.

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Language and the body are permanently out of synch, though not always in the same way. Bodies change over the course of a lifetime and over longer time spans too, as aesthetic fashions, sexual ideals, nutrition, diet, and styles of living mutate. Over longer periods we also would have to consider evolutionary changes in the human form. Symbolic networks are constantly mutating too, though we would be falling into linguistic determinism if we suggested that corporeal changes corresponded to, or followed directly, symbolic shifts. My point here is that given these changes—and therefore the changing configurations by which the body could be said to be out of synch with language—psychoanalytic diagnostic categories require a flexibility that can take full account of such shifting configurations. Retaining nineteenth-century nosological terms such as *hysteria*, no matter how one redefines their meaning, inhibits rather than enhances diagnostic flexibility.

If Lacan's theory that language carves up the body implies a gloomy

constitutes the subject, the real mode. To the distinction between imaginary other and symbolic Other, we add that mode of alterity designated by the formula *objet petit a*.

prognosis by pointing to a rift that nothing can heal, its happier implication is that anatomy is not destiny. Since the hysteric bears witness to an effect of symbolic networks on the body that "has nothing to do with anatomy," it follows that the desire borne by language need not be heterosexual at all. Throughout this book I argue that, in Lacanian theory, desire remains independent of heterosexuality. Hence the significance of Lacan's account of object *a* for contemporary sexual politics. His concept of the object recognizes the diversity of forms that erotic desire may take, as he points out in a seminar of 1963: "The *a*, the object, falls. That fall is primal. The diversity of forms taken by that object of the fall ought to be related to the manner in which the desire of the Other is apprehended by the subject" ("Names" 85). Acknowledging the plurality of forms in which human desire originates, Lacan never developed this insight in the direction of a radical sexual politics. In the rest of this book I hope to do so. Yet I want to make clear that Lacan's pluralization of desire does not imply that genders and sexualities may be reconfigured in line with ideological demands, since the pluralization of desire stems from a symbolic fissuring of anatomy that gives rise to both the unconscious and the death drive. In the next chapter, I introduce these sobering constraints into the ostensibly psychoanalytic theory of gender performativity, showing how Lacan's pluralization of desire differs from recent accounts of gender and sexuality with which it has been associated.

BODIES THAT MUTTER

Chapter 5

Modernism is an age not of rhetoric, but of rhetoricality, the age, that is, of a generalized rhetoric that penetrates to the deepest levels of human experience.

—John Bender and David E. Wellbery,
“Rhetoricality: On the Modernist Return of Rhetoric”

Poststructuralist thought is in its operation a rhetorical machine: it systematically asserts and demonstrates the mediated, constructed, partial, socially constituted nature of all realities, whether they be phenomenal, linguistic, or psychological.

—Stanley Fish, “Rhetoric”

Rhetorical Machines

Contemporary rhetoric teachers commonly assign students the task of analyzing a magazine advertisement because—as even the most old-fashioned “modern” rhetoric manuals recognize—“Ad-writers are some of the most skillful rhetoricians in our society.”¹ The pedagogical advantage of such an assignment lies in its capacity to help students connect the otherwise dry study of rhetoric to the study of social and sexual

relations, for if ads use rhetoric to help sell products, they also—students are keen to insist—use sex. And ads (such as Volvo's) that do not substitute pounds of flesh for their products nevertheless appeal to "sex" in the form of *sexuality*—that is, the network of institutions (such as the family) that sanctify sexual relations as social relations. In the terms of this chapter's first epigraph, we might say that the rhetorical analysis of advertisements converts rhetoric into rhetoricality, defined further by Bender and Wellbery as "the new conditions of discourse in the modern world and, thus, the fundamental category of every inquiry that seeks to describe the nature of discursive action and exchange."² Indeed, by converting rhetoric into rhetoricality, such analysis also converts sex into sexuality, disclosing sex as socially situated. Rhetorical analysis of advertisements thus can unfold the full range of demographic differentials—of gender, race, class, sexuality, ethnicity, age—that, we maintain, are rhetorically, discursively, and culturally constructed (advertising and mass media playing a crucial role in this process of construction).

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If it is easy to persuade students that ads sell forms of sexual and social relations rather than simply selling products, one cannot help wondering why the demystification of this process through rhetorical—or, in Roland Barthes's influential terms, *semiological*—analysis seems to leave advertising's suasive power spectacularly undiminished. Why does one form of persuasion—the rhetorical effect that disrupts conviction in the ad's promise—not cancel the opposing persuasive form—the rhetorical effect that convinces me this product will change my life? My suggestion is not that demystification or critique is pointless, but that rhetoricalist analyses, for all their suave power, are not persuasive enough. The poststructuralist "rhetorical machine" is faulty. Actually, its fault lies in our own readiness to be persuaded that sex is fully mediated, our eagerness to think of sex as constructed in—or materialized through—the imaginary and symbolic systems that permeate mass culture. For if student analyses of advertisements sometimes seem overenthusiastic in their assimilation of rhetoric to sex, their tendency to talk about body parts rather than, say, synecdoche, then critical analyses of rhetoric and sexuality exhibit the inverse problem of too quickly

2. John Bender and David E. Wellbery, "Rhetoricality: On the Modernist Return of Rhetoric," in *The Ends of Rhetoric: History, Theory, Practice*, ed. Bender and Wellbery (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1990), 25–26.

assimilating sex to rhetoric. These critical analyses too readily assume, as Lee Edelman puts it, “that sexuality is constituted through operations as much rhetorical as psychological—or, to put it otherwise, that psychological and sociological interpretations of sexuality are necessarily determined by the rhetorical structures and the figural logics through which ‘sexuality’ and the discourse around it are culturally produced.”³

The common assumption that sexuality is rhetorically or discursively constituted explicitly grounds some of the most sophisticated lesbian and gay theories of sexuality, as exemplified by Edelman’s *Homographesis* and Judith Butler’s *Bodies That Matter*. It is owing to this work’s importance and influence that I devote so much space to criticizing it in this chapter. Whether we label the assumption poststructuralist, constructionist, or, for present purposes, rhetoricalist, this idea that sexuality is a product of rhetoric, discourse, culture, history, and social relations is widely held as the only viable alternative to the conservative notion that sex is grounded in nature. If, in Barthes’s terms, myth “transforms history into nature,” the contemporary rhetoricalist demystification of “natural” sexuality transforms sex back into history, culture, discourse, rhetoric.⁴ So widely accepted is one or another version of this rhetoricalist position that we might even say rhetoricalism has naturalized itself in contemporary theory.

“‘Are bodies purely discursive?’” Butler inquires in *Bodies That Matter*, framing the question in quotation marks to signal her appropriation of one of the most cogent objections to her earlier account of gender as performative.⁵ This question leads Butler to theorize bodily materiality in terms of materialization; that is, as an enforcement of bodily norms whose normative status depends upon a reiteration or citation wherein lies the possibility of disruption or “resignification.” “Matter is always materialized,” Butler argues, converting noun into verb, essence into performance, the pre-given into the yet-to-be-given or the to-be-given-again (9). Showing how materiality is always necessarily materialized introduces the linked notions of temporality and repetition, which Butler counterposes to what she repeatedly characterizes as the “stasis”

3. Lee Edelman, *Homographesis: Essays in Gay Literary and Cultural Theory* (New York: Routledge, 1994), xiv. Subsequent page references are in main text.

4. Roland Barthes, *Mythologies*, trans. Annette Lavers (New York: Hill and Wang, 1972), 129.

5. Judith Butler, *Bodies That Matter: On the Discursive Limits of “Sex”* (New York: Routledge, 1993), 67. Subsequent page references are in main text.

of “heterosexist structuralism” (90). Repetition in Butler’s poststructuralist model is not necessarily repetition of the same; instead, repetition or citation is always potentially repetition with a difference—hence the possibility for resignifying and subverting identities.

Are bodies purely discursive? Or, to rotate the question slightly into Edelman’s terms, is sexuality purely rhetorical? The problem with framing the inquiry this way is that such questions are themselves rhetorical, instances of the trope of erotema, which subtly biases what answers are more and less plausible in response to the question. These kinds of questions are posed strategically in opposition to an essentialism or foundationalism that would ground bodies and sex in nature or biology, would position bodies and sex as pregiven or prediscursive. The foundationalist position thus opposes the rhetoricalist one, just as essentialism opposes constructivism.⁶ As Stanley Fish’s brief history of rhetoric (from which this chapter’s second epigraph is drawn) implies, most contemporary theories assume that critical thinking on corporeality and sexuality is fully exhausted by the coordinates these competing positions set. Fish maintains that “[t]he quarrel between rhetorical and foundational thought is itself foundational; its content is a disagreement about the basic constituents of human activity and about the nature of human nature itself.”⁷ Thus the figure whom Butler refers to as “the moderate critic” is situated somewhere within this conceptual field, on some middle ground between essentialism and antifoundationalism, conceding that—as Butler characterizes the moderate position she’s arguing against—“*some part of ‘sex’ is constructed, but some other is certainly not*” (11; original emphasis). I leave this moderate critic to Butler and intend to take on the stronger position exemplified by Butler’s own account. This chapter aims to outline a theory of rhetoric, sexuality,

6. Since foundationalism opposes rhetoricalism, Butler’s explicitly antifoundationalist polemics warrant my assimilating her work to the rhetoricalist position with which Edelman’s work is more obviously identifiable. See, for example, Butler, “Contingent Foundations: Feminism and the Question of ‘Postmodernism,’” in *Feminists Theorize the Political*, ed. Judith Butler and Joan W. Scott (New York: Routledge, 1992), 3–21; and Butler, “Critical Exchanges: The Symbolic and Questions of Gender,” in *Questioning Foundations: Truth / Subjectivity / Culture*, ed. Hugh J. Silverman (New York: Routledge, 1993), 134–49.

7. Stanley Fish, “Rhetoric,” in *Critical Terms for Literary Study*, ed. Frank Lentricchia and Thomas McLaughlin (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1990), 208. For further evidence that the essentialism/constructivism debate is taken to comprehend all possible accounts of sexuality, see Edward Stein, ed., *Forms of Desire: Sexual Orientation and the Social Constructionist Controversy* (New York: Routledge, 1992).

and embodiment that is both immoderately antifoundationalist *and* anti-rhetoricalist.

While Butler's fine-tuning of the poststructuralist rhetorical machine enables her to identify in deconstruction a methodological alternative to the constructivism-essentialism debate, I locate that alternative in psychoanalysis.⁸ Yet doesn't the notion that sex is discursively constituted derive, in part, from psychoanalysis—specifically, from what Edelman, acknowledging his book's methodological debts, conventionally refers to as “the linguistically oriented psychoanalysis of Jacques Lacan” (xiv)? Lacan's reconstruction of the unconscious as an effect of language (“the unconscious is the discourse of the Other”), his interpretation of the primary process in terms of metaphor and metonymy, and his description of desire as structured metonymically all support this attribution. Yet this attribution leads to a basic misconception. We may begin clarifying the crucial point that distinguishes Lacanian psychoanalysis from other positions by referring to Lacan's insistence that although desire is “in” language, *desire is not itself linguistic*. This distinction is not merely terminological or a question of emphasis, but is the basis for a specifically psychoanalytic conception of desire, sexuality, and rhetoric whose implications directly oppose those derivable from all the impressive and sophisticated constructions of sexuality churned out by the rhetorical machine.

In their failure to consider what in rhetoric or discourse exceeds language—the in-language-more-than-language, to rephrase Lacan's formulation of desire (*Four* 263)—rhetoricalist theories of sexuality effectively evacuate the category of desire from their accounts. Without desire there can be neither rhetoric nor sexuality; without desire, advertising would not exist. To say that explicitly queer-identified theories, such as Butler's and Edelman's, evacuate desire from their accounts could be understood as saying nothing more than that such accounts eschew *heterosexual* desire, concerning themselves instead with queer

8. Butler writes:

Paradoxically, the inquiry into the kinds of erasures and exclusions by which the construction of the subject operates is no longer constructivism, but neither is it essentialism. For there is an “outside” to what is constructed by discourse, but this is not an absolute “outside,” an ontological thereness that exceeds or counters the boundaries of discourse; as a constitutive “outside,” it is that which can only be thought—when it can—in relation to that discourse, at and as its most tenuous borders. The debate between constructivism and essentialism thus misses the point of deconstruction altogether. (*Bodies*, 8)

desire. Correlative to such a glib interpretation would be the conviction that a psychoanalytic conception of desire is partially or wholly heterosexist, so definitively has psychoanalysis “been shaped by homophobic and heterosexist assumptions and histories,” as Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick puts it.⁹ While the larger argument of *Beyond Sexuality* attempts to dispel this popular misconception, the present chapter contends more pointedly that the rhetoricalist model dispenses with the psychoanalytic framework that enables nonheterosexist *desire*—as opposed to non-heterosexual practices—to be thought at all.

The irony of Butler’s and Edelman’s elisions of desire lies not only in their attempts to think sexuality without desire, but particularly in their use of psychoanalysis to do so. Both Butler and Edelman are “gay Lacanians”—or so I’ve been informed on various occasions through the network of “rumors and gossip” allegedly favored by queers.¹⁰ The problem with this common misapprehension is that too many people working in queer studies—and in other fields—remain content to take their understanding of psychoanalysis from accounts such as Butler’s and Edelman’s. Yet in my view these accounts neglect what is most useful in psychoanalysis for queer intellectual work. To clear up certain misunderstandings about Lacan, it is necessary to recapitulate his development of a psychoanalytic rhetoric.

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Psychorhetoric

Both psychoanalysis and classical rhetoric are concerned with speech’s effects on the body, the capacity of speech to produce affect and desire. Lacan exploited this affinity by developing the implications of Freud’s account of “dream-work” in rhetorical terms. In his “Rome Discourse”

9. Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick, *Tendencies* (Durham: Duke University Press, 1993), 73.

10. Margaret Morrison, “Laughing with Queers in My Eyes: Proposing ‘Queer Rhetoric(s)’ and Introducing a Queer Issue,” *Pre/Text* 13, nos. 3–4 (1992): 22. It was as a response to the special double issue of *Pre/Text* on queer rhetoric that this chapter began. Perhaps it is also worth noting here that the index to *Bodies That Matter* contains more entries under *Lacan* than under any other name. Butler’s ambivalence vis-à-vis Lacanian concepts and terminology is signaled by her insistent efforts to qualify her psychoanalytic commitments—for example, by placing the term *unconscious* in scare quotes (22). However, this ambivalence is only compounded when such qualifications are framed in a Lacanian idiom: “The return to psychoanalysis, then, is guided by the question of how certain regulatory norms form a ‘sexed’ subject in terms that establish the indistinguishability of psychic and bodily formation” (22). This “return to psychoanalysis,” unlike Lacan’s “return to Freud,” explicitly claims fundamental “resignifications” of the theory to which it returns, assuming that, for example, it’s safer to speak of “The Lesbian Phallus” than “The Lacanian Phallus.”

(1953), Lacan summarized his initial construction of dream “rhetoric” thus:

Ellipsis and pleonasm, hyperbaton or syllepsis, regression, repetition, apposition—these are the syntactical displacements; metaphor, catachresis, autonomasis, allegory, metonymy, and synecdoche—these are the semantic condensations in which Freud teaches us to read the intentions—ostentatious or demonstrative, dissimulating or persuasive, retaliatory or seductive—out of which the subject modulates his oneiric discourse. (*E* 58)

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In light of his subsequent revisions of this rhetoric of dreams, it is notable that in 1953 Lacan aligned both metaphor and metonymy with condensation. After Jakobson’s famous paper on metaphor and metonymy, in 1956, these alignments changed significantly.¹¹ However, Lacan’s revisions of his earlier theory of dream rhetoric are complicated by the fact that, strongly influenced by Jakobson though he was, not only did Jakobson’s account diverge significantly from the classical divisions of rhetoric, but Lacan’s use of Jakobson subtly and inexplicitly revises Jakobson’s own revisionary model too.¹²

Four years after Jakobson’s paper on metaphor and metonymy, Lacan characterized the rhetoric of the unconscious in this way:

In this formula [of the linguistic unconscious] . . . the crucial term is the signifier, brought back to life from the ancient art of rhetoric by modern linguistics, in a doctrine whose various stages

11. Roman Jakobson, “Two Types of Language and Two Types of Aphasic Disturbance,” in *Language in Literature*, ed. Krystyna Pomorska and Stephen Rudy (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1987), 95–114.

12. In negotiating the complexities of these borrowings, divisions, and debts, I have been aided greatly by Russell Grigg’s linguistic analysis of metaphor and metonymy, which makes a series of useful distinctions. See Russell Grigg, “Metaphor and Metonymy,” *Newsletter of the Freudian Field* 3 (1989): 58–79 (a revised version of Grigg’s essay appeared under the same title in *Pre/Text: A Journal of Rhetorical Theory* 15 [1994]: 27–45). Differentiating between metonymy and three different structures of metaphor (substitution, extension, and apposition), Grigg shows that metonymy and substitution metaphors are produced through substitution, but extension and apposition metaphors are not. “Metonymy is structurally similar to the substitution metaphor, since both have a latent and a manifest term” (71), whereas apposition metaphors (such as “silence is golden”) or extension metaphors (such as “the mouth of a river”) do not require a latent term in order to function. Making this distinction shows that “while Jakobson’s analysis can be applied to metonymy . . . it is unable to account for any form of metaphor” (65). Grigg proceeds to demonstrate that Lacan adopts Jakobson’s account of metonymy (in which a *specific* semantic relation between latent and manifest signifiers holds), but that when Lacan speaks of metaphor he is referring to “substitution metaphors where these relations are absent” (66). My discussion restates Grigg’s distinctions in slightly different terms.

cannot be traced here, but of which the names of Ferdinand de Saussure and Roman Jakobson will stand for the dawn and its present-day culmination, not forgetting that the pilot science of structuralism in the West has its roots in Russia, where formalism first flourished. 'Geneva 1910' and 'Petrograd 1920' suffice to explain why Freud lacked this particular tool. But this defect of history makes all the more instructive the fact that the mechanisms described by Freud as those of 'the primary process', in which the unconscious assumes its rule, *correspond exactly* to the functions that this [structuralist] school believes determines the most radical aspects of the effects of language, namely metaphor and metonymy—in other words, the signifier's effects of substitution and combination on the respectively synchronic and diachronic dimensions in which they appear in discourse. (E 297–98; emphasis added)

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This remarkably succinct passage establishes a set of alignments that requires clarification and qualification. Lacan's optimistic conviction concerning exact correspondences between rhetorical tropes and unconscious mechanisms is misplaced, for in the domain of rhetoric precise demarcations and unequivocal equations are impossible to maintain, as "Arts of Rhetoric" consistently lament.¹³ Perhaps this is another way of

13. Conceiving Lacanian theory in periodized terms enables us to view as a form of shorthand the apparent reduction to metaphor and metonymy of the various rhetorical schemes and tropes Lacan described in 1953, rather than as a "lethal generalized restriction" of rhetoric, as Borch-Jacobsen puts it in his critique of psychorhetoric: "Psychoanalytic 'rhetoric,' as it has been understood and practiced for nearly thirty years, is in reality *restricted* rhetoric, rhetoric restricted to the figures of speaking well (or, in this case, the impossibility of speaking well), and also, therefore, to a language amputated from its effective, pragmatic, or persuasive dimension" (Mikkel Borch-Jacobsen, "Analytic Speech: From Restricted to General Rhetoric," in *The Ends of Rhetoric*, ed. Bender and Wellbery, 129–30; original emphasis). Arguing that the Lacanian understanding of rhetoric is restricted by its confining attention to metaphor and metonymy (rather than attending to language's astonishing powers of persuasion), Borch-Jacobsen discusses general (nonrestricted) rhetoric in terms of the persuasive use of language in propaganda and advertising since Freud. In his attempt to reintroduce the dimension of affect to psychorhetoric, Borch-Jacobsen focuses primarily on the functioning of propaganda in group psychology, arguing that "the singular 'logic' of the unconscious is, undoubtedly, the mimo-patho-logic of hypnotic suggestion" (132). However, our reintroducing to Borch-Jacobsen's model the missing question of advertising's persuasive power reveals his model's limits, for it is far more plausible that Madison Avenue exploits desire rather than hypnotic suggestion. Borch-Jacobsen's conception of the unconscious in terms of "the mimo-patho-logic of hypnotic suggestion" reduces the unconscious to an imaginary formation, while simultaneously reducing psychoanalysis to hypnosis. As I explain later in this chapter, Lacanian psychoanalysis theorizes persuasion through the crucial concept of object *a*, which is linked to both affect and desire. Therefore Borch-Jacobsen's avoidance of this concept, which thence restricts his own characterization of unconscious rhetoric (as restricted), displaces the restriction to Lacan's theory of rhetoric that in fact belongs to Borch-Jacobsen's own theory.

saying that there is no way to talk about rhetoric that is not itself rhetorical, no metalanguage extricable from rhetorical discourse. In Lacan's terms, there is no Other of the Other.¹⁴ Given that the appeal to exact correspondences—itsself a form of hyperbole—may be read as a sign of this impossibility, we must examine how Lacan theorizes analytic rhetoric in a way that enables psychoanalysis to be assimilated to the rhetoricalist position.

By aligning the mechanisms of the primary process—condensation and displacement—with the rhetorical tropes of metaphor and metonymy, Lacan characterizes the unconscious as rhetorically structured. This alignment depends upon Jakobson's account of metaphor and metonymy as principles of substitution and combination operative on the synchronic and diachronic axes of language respectively. These axes are also described as paradigmatic and syntagmatic, so that the metaphoric substitutions according to which unconscious condensation operates can be understood in literary terms as figuration, while the metonymic combinations according to which unconscious displacement operates can be understood in literary terms as syntax. These necessarily approximate alignments may be summarized thus:

condensation—metaphor—synchronic axis—substitution—paradigm—figure

displacement—metonymy—diachronic axis—combination—syntagm—syntax.

14. The consonance between this Lacanian formulation and the rhetoricalist commitment to the impossibility of metalanguage requires qualification. The rhetoricalist position is stated cogently by Derrida: "Concept is a metaphor, foundation is a metaphor, theory is a metaphor; and there is no meta-metaphor for them" (Jacques Derrida, "White Mythology: Metaphor in the Text of Philosophy," trans. F. C. T. Moore, *New Literary History* 6 [1974]: 23). The antifoundationalist foundation of meta-metaphoricity's impossibility (no Other of the Other) does not entitle metaphor to encompass the entire field of discourse. *Metaphor fails, and its failures are not only metaphoric*. This distinction is highlighted in Butler's "argument" over the Lacanian concept of the real when she asserts that "[t]o claim that the real resists symbolization is still to symbolize the real as a kind of resistance" (*Bodies That Matter*, 207). This assertion bespeaks a sophistic refusal to distinguish between symbolization, discourse, and conceptualization. The notion that a concept is reducible to its discursive conceptualization is a form of the linguistic idealism that Butler ostensibly rejects (*Bodies That Matter*, 8). To say that signification fails, that it is impossible to say everything, is not thereby to eradicate that failure or impossibility. Yet Butler persists with this faulty logic: "The former claim (the real resists symbolization) can only be true if the latter claim ('the real resists symbolization' is a symbolization) is true, but if the second claim is true, the first is necessarily false. To presume the real in the mode of resistance is still to predicate it in some way and to grant the real its reality apart from any avowed linguistic capacity to do precisely that" (*Bodies That Matter*, 207). Butler confuses true and false here. The validity of the "former claim (the real resists symbolization)" is independent

Perhaps these divisions and alignments are unjustifiably schematic; nevertheless this model's great benefit for both psychoanalytic and literary interpretation lies in how—by aligning figuration with condensation, on the one hand, and syntax with displacement, on the other—this version of psychoanalytic formalism reveals an unconscious place in discourse no matter how self-consciously rhetoric is deployed. In other words, one can use this model to interpret written and spoken utterance psychoanalytically without recourse to either the vulgar Freudianism of “thematic” readings or the marginally more sophisticated approach of “symptomatic” readings.¹⁵ For example, while neither symbol hunting nor psychobiography seems at all adequate for the interpretation of discursive practices such as poetry, nevertheless reading poems through the perspective of psychoanalytic formalism encourages one to connect distinctive syntactic patterns and structures of figuration with unconscious processes in a nonpathologizing way.

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Furthermore, conceiving unconscious processes linguistically immediately deindividualizes the unconscious: once the unconscious is understood in terms of the discourse of the Other, then the unconscious necessarily exceeds the individual and becomes more readily thinkable as social and cultural (if not “collective” in the Jungian sense). Of course, it's just a hasty step from this conception to the notion that the subject is *constructed* by social discourses and practices. I've tried to suggest why we should think long and hard before taking that easy step. Although irreducible to social constructionism, psychoanalytic formalism is not

of the validity of “the latter claim (‘the real resists symbolization’ is a symbolization),” and since Butler fails to consider the possibility that the first, rather than the second, claim is true, her argument neglects the distinction that would recognize that not every statement (and not every conceptualization) represents a symbolization of the real.

15. The “symptomatic” approach of hunting for parapraxes (as opposed to the “thematic” approach of hunting for symbols) is epistemologically problematic when dealing with highly revised and carefully edited written texts, rather than with unscripted spoken utterance. Nevertheless, critics such as Jane Gallop have had a good measure of success with the symptomatic approach, an ingenious method that seems appropriate when a published text—such as Butler's reading of Žižek—is peppered with terminological slips and conceptual slippages that could be seen as crying out for interpretation. And more recently, in “What Ails Feminist Criticism?” *Critical Inquiry* 24 (1998): 878–902, Susan Gubar interprets a repeated grammatical error in Butler's prose: subject-verb disagreement. Gubar not only identifies an impressive series of instances in which Butler uses the singular verb form when referring to plural grammatical subjects, but she also treats these errors as *meaningful*, as indicating more than mere sloppiness or faulty grammar on Butler's part. Thus Gubar argues that “the most vigilantly antitotalizing theorist of poststructuralism relies on stubborn patterns of totalization (two [grammatical subjects] treated as one)” (898). In discerning meaning—and, indeed, some degree of motivation—behind these grammatical lapses, Gubar's approach is implicitly psychoanalytic, notwithstanding her essay's nonpsychoanalytic argument.

by that token narrowly formalist, for by revealing the degree to which formal properties of discourse are determined by extratextual, historically specific constraints, this psychoanalytic model lays the groundwork for a more nuanced account of what connects a text to the world beyond itself. In maintaining that textual forms are extratextually determined, this account does not suggest that history or culture completely determines texts, or that such determinations operate in a one-to-one fashion. Although psychic determination tends toward overdetermination, these multiple networks of determination and displacement effectively render overdetermination always incomplete, and thus no single sociohistorical, cultural, or subjective determinant can occupy the position of primary cause. The concept of overdetermination does not entail a psychically determinist model, for that would return psychoanalysis to foundationalism. Indeed, by connecting a text's formal or rhetorical features to ostensibly nonformal, historical determinations, psychoanalytic formalism is exonerated from the stereotypical charge leveled at psychoanalytic methods—that they are ahistorical and universalizing.

Yet the psychoanalytic model I'm describing remains troublingly schematic. This can be confirmed by noting that the alignment of metaphor with the substitution axis, on the one hand, and the alignment of metonymy with the combination axis, on the other, ignores "the fact that not all metaphors are substitutions (there are also appositive and extension metaphors) while all metonyms are substitutions," as Grigg indicates.¹⁶ Thus, despite the classical understanding of metaphor as substitutive—the etymology of *meta-phor*, a transfer of burden, suggests this—metaphor intuitively seems to belong on the combination axis (the substitution metaphor "combines" a tenor and vehicle), while metonymy, as *necessarily* substitutive, seems to belong on the substitution axis, rather than vice versa, as Lacan, following Jakobson, aligns them. Furthermore, understanding metonymy in terms of displacement would seem more readily to align metonymy, rather than metaphor, with the substitution axis, since metaphor's alignment with condensation presupposes prior substitutions or displacements that combine various chains of association to form condensation, as Freud suggests in *The Interpretation of Dreams* (SE 5:339 ff.).

Although the passage from "Subversion of the Subject" quoted above

16. Grigg, "Metaphor and Metonymy," 64–65.

appears oblivious to the costs of schematism, Lacan anticipated this problem in his seminar *The Psychoses* (1955–56) by showing how the metonymic principle of substitutability is metaphor's condition of possibility. Acknowledging that “[w]hen one reads the rhetoricians, one realizes that they never get to an entirely satisfactory definition of metaphor, or of metonymy,” Lacan notes the outcome of this difficulty: “This results in, for example, the formula that metonymy is an impoverished metaphor. One might say that the thing is to be taken in exactly the opposite sense—metonymy exists from the beginning and makes metaphor possible” (*SIII* 227).¹⁷ This excursus on rhetoric in the seminar on psychoses is not tangential but central, a point of some significance given that psychosis represents the most serious—that is, ostensibly the least rhetorical—form of psychical disturbance. In other words, if the most extreme instance of mental illness is to be understood in rhetorical terms, then there seems precious little that would escape this psychoanalytic rhetoricalization of psychic life. Indeed, with respect to rhetorical operations Lacan insists: “This is the heart of Freud’s thought. His work begins with the dream, its mechanisms of condensation and displacement, of figuration—these are all of the order of metonymic articulation, and it’s on this foundation that metaphor is able to intervene” (*SIII* 228).

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Given Lacan’s painstaking discussion, in the seminar, of the distinctions between metaphor and metonymy and the implications each has for the other, what are we to make of his subsequent failure in “Subversion of the Subject” to perfectly formalize psychorhetoric? Besides signifying the impossibility of metalanguage, this failure of formalization may be viewed psychoanalytically as a sign of the real: if the real is defined as that which resists symbolization, then symbolization’s failures are legible as “signs” of the real. This leads me to suggest that beyond psychoanalytic formalism lies desire—a desire that is structured metonymically but is not itself wholly linguistic. In his *Four Fundamental Concepts*, Lacan explains in highly figurative language how desire is a product of lapses in symbolization:

17. Grigg makes the same point, arguing that one crucial difference between metaphor and metonymy lies in the fact that “there is an established semantic link between latent and manifest terms in metonymy,” whereas “metaphors do not just operate by means of a semantic relation between a manifest and a latent signifier, but make use of any means the language has at its disposal” (71–72). Thus although this restriction makes metonymy look like “an impoverished metaphor,” Grigg’s distinctions enable him to show that nevertheless “the substitution metaphor depends upon the metonymic support the latent term derives from the manifest terms” (73).

In this interval intersecting the signifiers, which forms part of the very structure of the signifier, is the locus of what, in other registers of my exposition, I have called metonymy. It is there that what we call desire crawls, slips, escapes, like the ferret. The desire of the Other is apprehended by the subject in that which does not work, in the lacks of the discourse of the Other, and all the child's *whys* reveal not so much an avidity for the reason of things, as a testing of the adult, a *Why are you telling me this?* ever-resuscitated from its base, which is the enigma of the adult's desire. (*Four* 214)¹⁸

Suggesting that desire originates from negative instances and is therefore not a product of positive linguistic or rhetorical constructions, Lacan's colorful imagery for the mobility of desire provides a useful antidote to the misconception, reiterated in *Bodies That Matter*, that the Lacanian conception of desire is, in its structuralist fixity, intransigently heterosexualist. If Butler's project in *Bodies That Matter* is, as she says, "to challenge the structural stasis of the heterosexualizing norm within the psychoanalytic account" (22), then one has only to conjure Lacan's ferret to see how misplaced the charge of "structural stasis" is.¹⁹

In the spirit of psychorhetoric, both Butler's and Edelman's accounts make much of Lacan's reversing the conventional relation between metaphor and metonymy—his reversing, that is, the place of metonymy for that of metaphor as "foundational" rather than secondary and impoverished. Butler and Edelman exploit this reversal in the process of their rethinking the conventional relation between heterosexuality (as foundational and original) and homosexuality (as secondary and imitative). Since Butler's and Edelman's arguments share a number of misconceptions that nevertheless develop in different directions, it

18. It would be instructive to compare Lacan's notion of the constitutive "enigma of the adult's desire"—an enigma produced by a failure of signification, a gap in the discourse of the Other—with Laplanche's notion of the "enigmatic signifier" and its role in "implanting" sexuality and thence desire. See Jean Laplanche, "The Theory of Seduction and the Problem of the Other," trans. Luke Thurston, *International Journal of Psychoanalysis* 78 (1997): 653–66.

19. In the context of this value-laden opposition between fixity and mobility, I should emphasize that my argument here is consonant with Joan Copjec's crucial point that "[s]ex does not budge, and it is not heterosexualist to say so" (*Read My Desire*, 211), because the heterosexualist conception of sex depends upon an imaginary complementarity, whereas the psychoanalytic conception of sex as real implies the impossibility of complementarity, the failure of sexual *relation*. It is because sex is real, unsymbolizable, that "sex does not budge." Both Butler and Edelman miss this psychoanalytic point by making sex performative and graphemic—that is, by situating sex at symbolic and imaginary levels of construction, rather than at the level of the real.

makes sense to consider their arguments in turn. In what follows, I want to suggest that by assimilating the category of sexuality to imaginary and symbolic formations, Butler's and Edelman's accounts paradoxically produce queer bodies bearing egos but devoid of subjective desire. That is, their accounts describe subjects of the signifier, not subjects of desire.²⁰ While the subject of desire is produced through language's impact on bodily materiality—that is, the way language “penetrates to the deepest levels of human experience,” in Bender and Wellbery's terms—the subject of desire differs significantly from the subject of imaginary and symbolic identifications. The subject of desire emerges not when an identification (with the father, the mother, or a signifier) is made, but when it fails to be made. In Lacanian terms, we could say that the rhetoricalist account of subjectivity confuses alienation (into the signifier, *A*) and separation (from an object, *a*). Failing to distinguish others from Others, Butler's and Edelman's accounts offer us undersubjectivized bodies, bodies so completely rhetoricalized that paradoxically they are devoid of desire.²¹ Such suave bodies are queer indeed, though not in any way liberated or liberating.

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Suave Bodies

I'd like to begin by characterizing Edelman's titular neologism, *homographesis*, since the terms of his substantial, complex, and sophisticated argument require unpacking. Taking seriously Foucault's canonical account of the late-nineteenth-century invention of homosexuality as a discrete ontological identity, Edelman develops the implications of Foucault's description of this new sexual “species” whose sexuality was “written immodestly on his face and body because it was a secret that always gave itself away.”²² Linking Foucault's characterization of homosexuality as something *written* on the body to the ancient tradition of treating homosexuality as “the crime not fit to be *named*,” Edelman persuasively delineates “the historical relationship that has produced gay

20. For more on this distinction, see Parveen Adams, *The Emptiness of the Image: Psychoanalysis and Sexual Differences* (London: Routledge, 1996), 55.

21. For more on the implications for queer theory and politics of this distinction between others and Others, see Tim Dean, “Two Kinds of Other and Their Consequences,” *Critical Inquiry* 23 (1997): 910–20.

22. Foucault, *The History of Sexuality*, 1:43.

sexuality within a discourse that associates it with figures of nomination or inscription" (4). Associated with writing (graphesis), homosexuality thus figures in Edelman's rhetoricalist account as a "dangerous supplement," undermining all heterosexuality's claims for originality, priority, and naturalness in the way that, for Derrida, writing as supplement undermines similar claims made on behalf of speech.

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However, Edelman's rhetoricalization of sexuality is more complex still, since *homographesis* bears the double valence of, on the one hand, indicating the regulatory regime that demands homosexuality be legible (hence necessarily inscribed, textualized) as a discrete identity separate from heterosexuality in the first place; while, on the other hand, *homographesis* suggests the deconstructive possibility inherent in any textualized form for revealing the artificial, secondary, and derivative status of the "natural." Edelman summarizes thus: "Like writing, then, homographesis would name a double operation: one serving the ideological purposes of a conservative social order intent on codifying identities in its labor of disciplinary inscription, and the other resistant to that categorization, intent on *de*-scribing the identities that order has so oppressively inscribed (10). In this way homographesis reveals how heterosexuality is founded not in nature but in the repression of homosexuality, the latter of which then claims a certain priority—not as natural, but as the primary differential in sexuality's constitution. By virtue of its scriptive, rhetorical nature, homosexuality's deconstruction of heterosexuality enables Edelman to claim that gay sexuality "functions in the modern West as the very agency of sexual meaningfulness, the construct without which sexual meaning, and therefore, in a larger sense, meaning itself, becomes virtually unthinkable" (xv). Treating "meaning itself" as an extension of "sexual meaning," Edelman's position in fact directly opposes Lacan's, since Lacan spoke of sexuality in terms of the failure of meaning. To be more precise, we should say that Lacan considered meaning as a substitute for sexuality: "Everything implied by the analytic engagement with human behaviour indicates not that meaning reflects the sexual but that it makes up for it."²³

This crucial difference notwithstanding, Edelman frames the reversal of priority between hetero- and homosexuality in terms of Lacan's

23. Jacques Lacan, *Le séminaire*, livre 21, "Les non-dupes errent," 1973–1974, unpublished manuscript, 9. Cited in Jacqueline Rose, *Sexuality in the Field of Vision* (London: Verso, 1986), 71.

reversal of priority between metaphor and metonymy. That is, Edelman rewrites the Foucaultian narrative of homosexuality's invention "as a transformation in the rhetorical or tropological framework through which the concept of 'sexuality' itself is produced":

a transformation from a reading of the subject's relation to sexuality as contingent or metonymic to a reading in which sexuality is reinterpreted as essential or metaphoric. When homosexuality is no longer understood as a discrete set of acts but as an "indiscreet anatomy," we are in the presence of a powerful tropological imperative that needs to produce a visible emblem or metaphor for the "singular nature" that now defines or identifies a specifically homosexual type of person. That legible marking or emblem, however, must be recognized as a figure for the now metaphorical conceptualization of sexuality itself—a figure for the privileged relationship to identity with which the sexual henceforth will be charged. In keeping, therefore, with the ethnographic imperative of nineteenth-century social science, "the homosexual" could emerge into cultural view through the attribution of essential meaning—which is to say, the attribution of metaphorical significance—to various contingencies of anatomy that were, to the trained observer, as indiscreet in revealing the "truth" of a person's "sexual identity" as dreams or somatic symptoms would be in revealing the "truth" of the unconscious to the emergent field of psychoanalysis. (8)

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Like Foucault, Edelman implies—without ever directly stating—that "the emergent field of psychoanalysis" formed part of "the ethnographic imperative of nineteenth-century social science" that enabled—indeed required—the shadowy figure of "the homosexual" to "emerge into cultural view." Edelman reads the historically coincident emergence of homosexuality and psychoanalysis metaphorically rather than metonymically, in that he figures their coincident emergence as essential and therefore causally related, rather than as contingent.

What is at stake in Edelman's rhetoric that encourages us to read homosexuality metonymically but psychoanalysis metaphorically? By suggesting how the cultural project of making homosexuality visible operates through a tropological imperative to produce vital signs, Edelman argues that "sexuality" as sexual orientation is produced when desire as metonymic is misrecognized as metaphoric—in other words,

when the contingent is mistaken as essential. In figuring the relation between psychoanalysis and homosexuality as metaphoric, is Edelman performing a misrecognition in the very gesture of unmasking one? Explicitly alluding at this point in his argument to Lacan's conception of desire as metonymically structured (and, indeed, Lacan's reversal of the conventional relation between metaphor and metonymy), Edelman misrecognizes the cultural force of psychoanalysis, for *it is psychoanalysis that discloses the cultural misrecognition whereby sexual identities and orientations are solidified and hierarchized*. Freud's insistence that sexuality undermines identity rather than consolidating it entails a metonymic reading of sexuality at the very moment such metonymies were being culturally misrecognized as metaphoric. Freud's position in his *Three Essays on the Theory of Sexuality* was, as we know, "most decidedly opposed to any attempt at separating off homosexuals from the rest of mankind as a group of a special character" (SE 7:145 n.). Thus far from reading sexual signs metaphorically, Freud emphasized such signs' metonymic significance, since he was convinced "that all human beings are capable of making a homosexual object-choice and have in fact made one in their unconscious" (SE 7:145 n.).

In pointing to Edelman's misrecognition of psychoanalysis at the very moment he identifies a cultural misrecognition of sexuality, I am not suggesting that psychoanalysis ever could be completely free from social and cultural biases. But I am suggesting that the tropological and ethnographic imperatives Edelman describes should be viewed as less consistent and totalizing than he would have us believe. Edelman's account does have the benefit of delineating a far more elaborate, more explicit way of conceiving resistance to these cultural imperatives than Foucault's notoriously undertheorized notion of resistance. But where Edelman locates resistance in the deconstructive force of writing or language itself, I would locate that resistance more specifically—perhaps more historically—in psychoanalysis. My objection to situating the possibility of disrupting cultural norms at the level of deconstructive "graphesis," in Edelman's case, or "resignification," in Butler's case, is that despite their best efforts they fail to conceive sexuality in anything but binary, overwhelmingly Manichaean terms. Permit me to explain why their conceiving sexuality in this way paradoxically entails evacuating desire from the theoretical picture.

Both Butler and Edelman write about lesbian and gay egos; they

treat subjectivity and sexuality as if these dimensions of psychic life were a function of one's self-image rather than, as psychoanalysis insists, a function of the unconscious. Yet neither Butler nor Edelman is up front about this; they imply that Lacan theorizes subjectivity and sexuality as effects of the imaginary order, the realm of ego formation. Hence, for example, in "The Lesbian Phallus" Butler suggests:

[E]very effort to inhabit fully an identification with the *imago* . . . fails because the sexuality temporarily harnessed and bounded by that ego . . . cannot be fully or decisively constrained by it. What is left outside the mirror frame, as it were, is precisely the unconscious that comes to call into question the representational status of what is shown in the mirror. In this sense, the ego is produced through *exclusion*, as any boundary is, and what is excluded is nevertheless negatively and vitally constitutive of what 'appears' bounded within the mirror. (262 n. 23; original emphases)

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While it is true that the ego is constituted through exclusion, by means of a perceptual gestalt, it is not the case that this drawing of boundaries produces sexuality or the unconscious. Human sexuality cannot be construed as in any way a result of the mirror stage. However, by relying on Jane Gallop's interpretation of Lacan, Edelman likewise reads sexual identity formation in terms of the mirror stage:

[T]he symbolic (hetero)sexual order established by the reading of sexual differentiation through the polarizing narrative of the castration complex imposes a (not necessarily necessary) fiction of sexual identity. That fiction reenacts the contradictory temporality of the Lacanian mirror stage, a temporality in which totalized identity is posited by a decree that phobically disavows the definitional incoherence of the bits and pieces imagined as having preceded the constitution of the subject, precisely because the subject anxiously anticipates the possibility of succumbing to such an incoherence once again. The sexual identity so structured is endlessly paranoid in its need to assert the inevitability and security of its narcissistic totalization, and thus the subject actively refuses—indeed, aggressively attempts to efface—whatever would ironize its claim to an identity *intrinsic to and coextensive with the fact of its existence*. (225–26; original emphasis)

It is precisely because the ego produced through this mechanism of identification “is endlessly paranoid” and aggressive that these persistent mischaracterizations of sexuality in imaginary terms are so self-defeating. For by focusing solely on the ego, Butler’s and Edelman’s accounts not only misrepresent the subjective level at which sexuality is formed and operates, they also seem unable to escape the impasse of paranoid, highly defensive binarity typical of the imaginary structure within whose terms they theorize sexuality. And despite all their loudly proclaimed awareness of constructedness and contingency, lesbian and gay egos—by virtue of being egos—are no less paranoid or aggressive than heterosexual people’s egos.

Against Rhetoricality

From a Lacanian viewpoint, all binary relations are imaginary in the sense that they are structured by relations of identification and opposition, one-to-one relations. And all imaginary relations are essentially binaristic. From this it follows that to theorize sexuality in imaginary terms—in terms, that is, of the ego or the self—is to conceptualize sexuality binarily, even if, like Butler and Edelman, one intends otherwise. No amount of subtle theorizing will get you outside a binary system if your model of subjectivity remains focused on the self. All you get from an imaginary relation is an ego and lots of trouble. By “trouble” I mean imaginary aggressivity—imaginary not in the sense of unreal, but in the sense of the extremely violent policing of inside/outside borders by which the ego maintains itself. This is not the kind of subversive trouble Butler intends in *Gender Trouble*. Yet as I suggested in chapter 2, in my discussion of *Gender Trouble*, theorizing gender and sexuality in imaginary terms leaves aspects of subjectivity other than the ego calmly untroubled.

The production of what Butler, following Derrida, calls a “constitutive outside” offers a useful way to think about ego formation, including the formation of collective egos. But in psychoanalytic terms, the *subject* is not formed through the production of a constitutive outside; neither is this exterior equivalent to the category of the unconscious, as Butler seems to think (22). Furthermore, this “constitutive outside” is quite distinct from what Lacan means by the real: “The non-ego is not to be confused with what surrounds it, the vastness of the real” (*Four* 245).

To conceptualize subjectivity in terms of exclusion and the regulation of inside / outside or human / abject borders is simply to think subjectivity imaginarily, to remain caught in binary categories. Thus although Butler at one point notes the Lacanian distinction between subject and ego (261 n. 22), subjectivity—in *Bodies That Matter*, as in *Homographesis*—constantly falls back into the ego.

Neither subjectivity nor sexuality is an effect of imaginary relations. Although some of Lacan's vocabulary when describing the specular construction of the ego—the "lure of the mirror" and suchlike—sounds as if it might have something to do with sexuality, we should be clear that for Lacan sexuality and desire are not produced through binary structures. Since lesbian and gay theorists often remain ambivalent about psychoanalytic methodologies because the binary pairings male / female, masculine / feminine, activity / passivity make psychoanalysis look suspiciously like conceptual support for compulsory heterosexuality, I would like to emphasize that Lacan theorizes sexuality in terms not of gender but of *jouissance*. As I elaborate more fully in the next chapter, this underappreciated dimension of Lacanian theory makes psychoanalysis the ally of theorists—such as Butler, Edelman, and Eve Sedgwick—struggling to think sexuality outside the terms of gender.²⁴

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For the sake of distinctions that usually evaporate even when people bother to make them, let me summarize Lacan by characterizing the ego as an effect of the imaginary order, the subject as an effect of the symbolic order, and sexuality as an effect of the real order. This leaves us with at least two questions. First, of what is the desiring subject an effect? Second, how are we to understand relations among imaginary, symbolic, and real orders—that is, among the ego, the unconscious, and sexuality? This brings me to the crucial concept of object *a*. Without

24. In *Epistemology of the Closet* (Berkeley and Los Angeles: University of California Press, 1990), Sedgwick makes axiomatic for antihomophobic theory "the imperative of constructing an account of sexuality irreducible to gender" (34); and, in an interview, Sedgwick specifies the following preference: "I like the notion of there being institutional places to think about the likelihood that for some people the most important thing about sexuality is not the gender of sexual object choice" (Sarah Chinn, Mario DiGangi, and Patrick Horrigan, "A Talk with Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick," *Pre / Text* 13, nos. 3–4 [1992]: 86). Butler seems to be approaching a similar commitment to thinking sexuality outside the terms of gender when, in "The Lesbian Phallus," she remarks, "it is unclear to me that lesbians can be said to be 'of' the same sex or that homosexuality in general ought to be construed as love of the same" (*Bodies That Matter*, 65–66). And in the final chapter of *Homographesis*, Edelman similarly criticizes the way "sexual orientation in Western culture is persistently posited through its often contradictory assimilation to the discursive categories associated with differences historically and culturally elaborated to distinguish between the sexes" (197).

a concept of the object, it is practically impossible to maintain a distinction between subject and ego, as *Bodies That Matter* repeatedly shows.

"It is necessary to find the subject as a lost object," Lacan gnomically remarks, adding that "this lost object is the support of the subject and in many cases is a more abject thing than you may care to consider" ("Of Structure" 189). For all their psychoanalytically derived preoccupation with the construction of homosexuality as a zone of abjection, Butler and Edelman never consider the meaning of the abject object. As "the support of the subject," this object counterintuitively (ungrammatically?) appears to precede the subject, to found the subject. Indeed, his notion of object *a* represents the principal foundation that Lacan posits for subjectivity. Yet the apparent foundationalism of object *a* betokens a radically contingent foundation, since as Ellie Ragland points out, "[w]e humans are grounded in objects that are not themselves grounded."²⁵

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The contingent foundation provided by object *a* is that of desire, an unstable foundation indeed. Lacan refers to the object *a* as "cause of desire." By virtue of its being the cause rather than the aim of desire, object *a* conceptually precedes gender or any particular kind of sexual activity. The place and corporeal form of the object, as it is conceived by Lacan, cannot be deduced from any gender configuration or sexual practice. This status of the object helps explain why it is so easily overlooked in theoretical accounts of desire, but also why the concept of object *a* holds such potential for queer critiques of sexuality. If desire is originally independent of gender, how can Lacanian theory legitimately be accused of promoting a heterosexist model of desire? The heterosexist assumption that desire heads toward the opposite sex is challenged by Lacan's contention that desire heads toward nothing in particular except satisfaction. The object-cause of desire takes so many gender-neutral forms—the gaze, the voice, the phoneme, the lips, "the rim of the anus," and "the slit formed by the eyelids" (*E* 314–15)—that it seems to offer the conceptual basis for a radically nonheterosexist account of sexuality and desire. While it is fairly clear how body parts such as the lips, the nether lips, and "the rim of the anus," may function as object-causes of desire thanks to their direct involvement in sexual activity, it is much less obvious how the gaze, the voice, and the phoneme function as causes of desire.

25. Ellie Ragland, "Rhetoric and Unconscious Desire: The Battle for the Postmodern Episteme," *Studies in Psychoanalytic Theory* 1 (1992): 20.

There is a subtle yet crucial distinction to be made here between thinking of objects *a* as causing desire by virtue of their association with parts of the body, on one hand, and grasping that they cause desire by virtue of their standing in for loss, on the other. For a psychoanalytically informed, gay-positive account of sexuality, it would be plausible to develop Lacan's allusion to "the rim of the anus" in his description of objects *a*. By treating the anus as a legitimate occasion of desire—on a par with more clearly sanctioned sexual body parts—Lacanian theory contributes toward a nonpathologizing understanding of gay sexual practices centered on anal and spintrian eroticism, such as buttfucking, rimming, and fisting. Furthermore, Lacan's characterization of the gaze and voice as objects *a* evokes gay practices of cruising and—in the wake of AIDS and the social imperative to devise safer sexual practices—video sex, phone sex, and virtual sex.²⁶

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These activities dramatize the psychoanalytic insight that many sexual pleasures do not necessarily involve the genitals. By distinguishing sexual desire and *jouissance* from the irresistible pull of genitalia, Lacan denaturalizes and potentially deheterosexualizes desire. But more than this, Lacan's account of multiple object-causes of desire offers a far less literalist theory of sexuality; in so doing, his account opens a space for us to imagine different configurations of bodies and pleasures. This psychoanalytic understanding of sexuality suggests that the most intense pleasures need not involve genital contact at all: there is no privileged sexual activity or erotic narrative to which we should all aspire, no viable sexual norm for everybody, because desire's origins are multiple

26. In his ambitious reading of Otto Preminger's 1944 Hollywood movie *Laura*, Edelman argues that "the gaze comes to carry the very force of gay sexuality itself" (*Homographesis*, 200). Edelman's argument in his book's final chapter may be summarized thus: "This association of the male homosexual with the aggressive deployment of vision, on the one hand (i.e., in his "habit" of gazing at . . . male partners'), and with his passive susceptibility to visualization or perceptual recognition on the other (i.e., as the object of the cultural enterprise that seeks to render the gay body legible) makes the cinema a particularly important institution within which to consider the function and effect of gay inscription or homographesis" (200). The problem with his account of the function of this gay gaze in cinema—as with my assimilation of the desirous cruising gaze to the Lacanian concept of the gaze as object *a*—lies in the failure to distinguish between vision and gaze. Without this distinction, we lose the conceptual force of Lacan's account of the gaze as cause of desire. My point is not that this much-misunderstood Lacanian concept cannot be used to theorize scopophilic dimensions of sexuality, but that the relation between vision and gaze, between cruising and desire, is much more richly complex than gay studies accounts usually allow. Lacan's account of the gaze as object *a* is given in his *Four Fundamental Concepts* (67–119). A useful gloss on the distinctions involved in Lacan's account and their pertinence for theorizing perverse desire may be found in Julia Saville, "The Lady of Shalott: A Lacanian Romance," *Word and Image* 8 (1992): 71–87.

and its ambition no more specific than satisfaction. In Lacan's account, this lack of specificity represents not so much a cover for universal sexual norms as the multiplication of possibilities for desire's outcomes.

Gaze, voice, and phoneme connect our bodies to society and culture in a way that suggests the conceptual potential of object *a* for theorizing sexuality as culturally inflected, mediated, even "technologized," without reductively describing sexuality as culturally constructed. Indeed, the concept of object *a* can help us appreciate the way advertising incites desire, as Lacan suggests:

The features that appear in our time so strikingly in the form of what are more or less correctly called the *mass media* . . . [are] illuminated by the reference to those two objects . . . namely, the voice—partly planeterized, even stratospherized, by our machinery—and the gaze, whose ever-encroaching character is no less suggestive, for, by so many spectacles, so many phantasies, it is not so much our vision that is solicited, as our gaze that is aroused. (*Four* 274; original italics)

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This passage suggests the sensitivity of Lacan's account of desire to technological shifts in the organization of social space; in other words, this passage implies that a psychoanalytic understanding of desire need not remain indifferent to historical change. Furthermore, Lacan expands the potential of his account of desire by characterizing object *a* dynamically: "in some cases it is something done" ("Of Structure" 189). If the object that causes desire can take the form of a verb as well as a noun, then we begin to appreciate its multivalent explanatory possibilities.

Lacan's provisional list of the forms object *a* may take centers on the common feature of what he describes somewhat enigmatically as "the mark of a cut." This "cut" refers to bodily borders, wherever inside meets outside. If we can understand how object *a* results from a cut that produces simultaneously subject and object, then it becomes clearer how object *a* can be "something done." This object appears as the effect of some action on my body, rather than preexisting in object form. If, as Butler suggests, matter is always materialized, then we might say that objects *a* are always objected or objectivized. Lacan explains: "The *a*, the object, falls. That fall is primal. The diversity of forms taken by that object of the fall ought to be related to the manner in which the desire of the Other is apprehended by the subject" ("Names" 85). The object's fall is "primal," because in falling the object founds the subject

and its desire. But what causes the object to fall? In providing an answer to this question, we shall discover how object *a* links imaginary, symbolic, and real registers. We shall also discover—in Lacan's conception of the body in imaginary, symbolic, and real terms—an alternative to the unidimensional "suave body" of rhetoricalist theory.

Broadly speaking, when language hits the body its impact produces not merely the subject of the signifier but also the subject of desire. The symbolic order has a ripple-like effect on human subjects. Think of the symbolic order as a net settling over the corporeal form, penetrating the body, as Bender and Wellbery say, and slicing the body into erotogenic zones by drawing bodily *jouissance* into pools at its corporeal borders. This process does not happen in a uniform way because there is no single symbolic order that we all inhabit. We move through different, interwoven discourse networks that affect people's bodies unevenly; nevertheless, it should be borne in mind that this process of creating desire begins very early in life, well before anatomical maturation, and usually within familial discourse networks.

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Language is the agent of the cut that produces subject and object through the same action. The result of language's impact on the body, object *a* can be thought of as the leftover of *jouissance*, what Lacan calls the *plus-de-jour*. Without language, desire would not exist. But this does not make desire linguistic. Although object *a* is not prediscursive in the sense that it does not precede language, it also is not a discursive effect in quite the way that rhetoricalism understands the subject and his or her sexuality as discursive effects. Object *a* links the body to language and therefore is crucial for conceptualizing rhetoric, which has a demonstrable effect on bodies. Lacan describes corporeality, subjectivity, and sexuality not simply as discursive or rhetorical effects; rather he provides a way to theorize language's impact on the body in three dimensions—imaginary, symbolic, and real.

Consider the terms in which Lacan formulated the relation between body, language, and desire by defining desire as "neither the appetite for satisfaction, nor the demand for love, but the difference that results from the subtraction of the first from the second, the phenomenon of their splitting (*Spaltung*)" (E 287). Distinguishing desire from biological or physical needs, Lacan conceived desire as the excess resulting from the articulation of need in symbolic form. Thus where bodies may be said to have needs such as biological sustenance and physical protection,

subjects have desires—principally, overcoming the loss constitutive of subjectivity as such—hence the requirement to “find the subject as a lost object.” It is because desire remains distinct from need that sexuality is cultural rather than biological. Yet the widespread insistence on various constituencies’ subjective “needs” effectively eclipses desire. Hence the incoherence betrayed in Edelman’s account of sexuality by his reference to “the pressure of more immediate psychic needs” (229). No psyche “needs” anything. The confusion indicated by this oxymoronic formulation of “psychic needs” can hardly be excused as merely terminological or rhetorical because, according to Edelman’s own account, terminology and rhetoric should be understood as constitutive. This rhetoric of “needs”—which is prevalent in, though not specific to, queer cultural critique—effectively misrecognizes desire in just the way that heterosexist cultural assumptions denigrate and trivialize homosexual desire.

To appreciate the paradox whereby queer cultural critique sometimes unwittingly participates in the conceptual logic of mainstream heterosexist consumer culture, we may extend the argument of this chapter’s opening section and suggest that where, from Barthes’s semiological perspective, myth transforms history into nature, advertising transforms desire into need—not literally, but rhetorically. The rhetorical effect of this transformation depends on understanding that while desire is impossible to satisfy, need is not. Thus to speak in terms of consumer “needs”—for example, the “communication needs” telephone companies promise to satisfy—is to convert the unsatisfiable into something that ostensibly *can* be satisfied (that is, need) and so promote capitalist consumption while simultaneously perpetuating desire. The demystification of advertising—which so often takes the form of exposing the fallacy that such-and-such completely trivial product could have any significant effect, could change one’s life—thus misses how advertising capitalizes on our willingness to confuse need and desire. Since the relatively simple satisfaction of need produces significant effects (a drink of water can save, and therefore immeasurably change, one’s life), advertising’s notion that desires are needs effectively persuades us that desires can be satisfied, thereby encouraging consumption.

The paradox of the distinction between need and desire is that what can be satisfied (need) sounds so much more legitimate than desire,

whose satisfaction remains forever out of reach in a Lacanian framework. Given this distinction, our attention to desire can seem like a luxury, a triviality we should think about only once the more urgent political work of attending to “needs” is accomplished. This hierarchy of political priorities is always implicit in materialist critiques of psychoanalysis.²⁷ Yet needs concern the biological organism and therefore have little to do with sexuality, which concerns the subject of desire. The issue, then, is how to theorize sexuality in terms of the body without resorting to either a rhetoric of needs—which would return theory to biological foundationalism and hence heterosexism—or a rhetoric of “the body” as pregiven and immutable.

The Body: Imaginary, Symbolic, Real

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Butler begins her account of morphogenesis by mimicking a question with which she was reproached in the wake of her theory of gender performativity: “‘What about the materiality of the body, *Judy*?’” (ix). *Bodies That Matter* suggests how “the materiality of the body” can be theorized according to the model of performativity proposed in *Gender Trouble*. My problem with Butler’s model differs from those critiques of performativity that charge Butler with failing to take account of “the body.” Instead, I am skeptical about the way performativity theorizes the body unidimensionally. This problem becomes clearer when we consider the distinction between the body (which needs) and the subject (which desires). Butler allows no distinction between the body and subjectivity; subjectivity thus collapses back into the ego (American style) and desire is effectively reduced to need (capitalist style).

Arguing for “[t]he indissolubility of the psychic and the corporeal,” Butler develops an account of the production of “a ‘sexed’ subject in terms that establish the indistinguishability of psychic and bodily formation” (66; 22). This account makes all subjectivity imaginary and mistakenly locates sexuality at the level of the ego. Exploiting Freud’s axiom, in *The Ego and the Id*, that “the ego is first and foremost a bodily ego” (*SE* 19:26), Butler’s analysis provides a nuanced description of nonnormative egos without, however, contributing much to a theory of queer

27. For an example of this kind of ordering of political priorities, see Donald Morton, “Birth of the Cyberqueer,” *PMLA* 110 (1995): 369–81.

desire. Hence her characterization of “the lesbian phallus” as “transferable” and “plastic property” (62) eloquently describes the play of identifications through which lesbian egos exchange dildos; but this elaboration of a lesbian imaginary fails to register the way egos *occlude*—rather than manifest—desire. Butler’s conclusion to her celebrated meditation on “The Lesbian Phallus” makes explicit this emphasis on egos, without considering its psychoanalytic or political implications: “to speak of the lesbian phallus as a possible site of desire . . . is simply to promote an alternative *imaginary* to a hegemonic imaginary” (91; original emphasis). Arguing for the consubstantiality of body and ego—the way bodies do not *precede* egos as models but are themselves embodied, materialized through what Freud calls “the projection of a surface” (SE 19:26)—Butler misses the crucial psychoanalytic insight that *desire is predicated on the incommensurability of body and subject*.

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We are now in a position to extend our account of language’s effect on the body. Although both Butler and Edelman are correct in insisting that we have no unmediated access to our bodies, the forms this mediation takes are more complex than rhetoricalist models allow. The category of “the body” so often invoked in recent theory requires specifying in terms of real, symbolic, and imaginary, as much as in terms of gender, race, and class. If in the realm of the imaginary the body produces—and is indeed produced through—the ego, how should we understand the symbolic order in this production of a visualizable bodily self?

Like Butler, Edelman views the symbolic as essentially an *extension* of the imaginary. Referring to the “policing” effects of what Butler calls “regulatory norms,” Edelman argues that “this policing bespeaks the extent to which the symbolic order is mobilized to defend an imaginary self-image against those forces that are seen as threatening to unmask it as always *only* imaginary” (229; original emphasis). Treating the symbolic as a support of the imaginary effectively imaginarizes the symbolic and reduces to the level of the ego the subjectivity of “the gay male body” that Edelman constantly invokes. And, of course, the irony of Edelman’s reducing subjectivity to corporeality lies in his insistence that homographesis as “a normalizing practice of cultural discrimination” involves “the process whereby the homosexual subject is represented as being, even more than as inhabiting, a body that always demands to be read, a body on which his ‘sexuality’ is always already inscribed” (10). To insist on reading the “homosexual subject” in terms of “the gay male

body,” rather than in terms of that subject’s constitutive *disembodiment*, is thus to perpetuate unwittingly the “normalizing practice of cultural discrimination” at which Edelman levels his critique.

If “the gay male body” is to be credited with a desire beyond that of maintaining his ego—that is, beyond narcissism—this desire will be the result of his disembodiment through language, his subjectivization.²⁸ The symbolic order’s action on dumb corporeal density produces a desubstantialized, symbolic body—the subject (*S*)—and, as I suggested above, an equally desubstantialized remainder of bodily *jouissance*—the object (*a*). This process of disembodiment that produces the subject and its causes of desire effectively splits (i) body and subject; (ii) subject and object, thereby constituting desire and the impossibility of its satisfaction; (iii) subject against itself as a consequence of the multiple object-causes of desire that support or contingently ground the subject.²⁹

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This disembodied, split subject is central to the psychoanalytic theory of sexuality; and it is by conceiving of desire in terms of multiple, partial, not necessarily gendered, not necessarily genital objects that one most fully extricates a model of desire from heterosexist assumptions. By contrast, the unidimensional suave body of the rhetoricalist account—however gussied up in outlandishly queer or sophisticated finery—is simply a product of culturally constrained symbolic and imaginary systems. This “subject’s” desire is simply the product of meaning, of a signifying chain; whereas the psychoanalytic subject’s desire is a product of that chain’s disruption. Regarding this rhetoricalist conception of the subject, Lacan observed that “this subject, who thinks he can accede to himself by designating himself in the statement, is no more than such an [abject] object” (*E* 315).

28. The cultural association of homosexuality with narcissism—which stems from the assumption that both homosexuality and narcissism involve love of the same—requires interrogation rather than the endorsement this part of my argument seems to confer. Edelman provides an acute critique of the use of *narcissism* as a term of censure in AIDS activist rhetoric, arguing thus: “It is all the more painful, therefore, when the rhetoric of ‘activists,’ in its resistance to the dominant discourse, redeploys the ideology of that discourse in order, narcissistically, to reinforce an ‘activist’ identity by stigmatizing as narcissistic the community, already so-stigmatized, from which they emerged” (*Homographesis*, 108). In “Homo-Narcissism; or Heterosexuality,” in *Engendering Men: The Question of Male Feminist Criticism*, ed. Joseph A. Boone and Michael Cadden (New York: Routledge, 1990), 190–206, Michael Warner also provides a strong critique of this association between homosexuality and narcissism. I develop this critique in “Homosexuality and the Problem of Otherness,” in *Homosexuality and Psychoanalysis*, ed. Tim Dean and Christopher Lane (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, forthcoming).

29. In *Read My Desire*, chap. 6, Joan Copjec argues for the political purchase of understanding the subject psychoanalytically as disembodied, nonconcrete, universal.

202 This idea that in language the subject's subjectivity becomes nothing more than "such an object" suggests the difference between a psychoanalytic account (which grounds the subject in the object) and a rhetoricalist account (which more straightforwardly grounds the subject in language).³⁰ Lacan's idea suggests also the complex dynamism of a structure in which the language that impacts and dices corporeal density, reducing the subject to an abject object, comes as much from inside the body as outside it. It is for this reason that the phoneme is included in Lacan's catalog of objects *a*. As the smallest linguistic unit capable of signifying difference between otherwise identical words, the phoneme is distinct from Lacan's notion of the signifier, since to make the signifier an object *a* would be to reduce psychoanalysis to rhetoricalism by treating desire as purely linguistic. Our alienation in language is so intense because it is so intimate—that is, because speech operates at the body's borders. Speech comes out of our very mouths, connecting our insides to our outsides. Hence Lacan's reference to "[r]espiratory erogeneity" (*E* 315), the potential for breath itself—not to mention particular words carried on the breath—to produce desire. And thus despite the elaborate protocols surrounding what can be said and to whom, freedom of speech is defended in this culture that seeks to eliminate all other sounds and substances emitted by the body's orifices or at its borders.

Bodies That Mutter

Treating everything except speech that comes out of the body as execrable, North American culture would rather not heed the vital signs emanating from bodies, for to recognize bodies that mutter would require attending to desire, which capitalism prefers to misrecognize as need. Bodies that mutter, that speak almost inaudibly, unintelligibly, are heeded in our culture by psychoanalysis, which first took hysterical symptoms seriously as a form of communication. By producing signs that are not immediately legible even as something requiring reading, bodies that mutter obliquely indicate desire in the form of a failure in the Other's discourse. (Here we might recall Lacan's remarking that "[t]he desire of the Other is apprehended by the subject in that which

30. Butler makes this point very clearly in a discussion recorded at a 1991 symposium, "The Identity in Question": "My position is that subjects are constituted in language, but that language is also the site of their destabilization" (*October* 61 [1992]: 113).

does not work, in the lacks of the discourse of the Other.”) Bodies that mutter testify to something lacking. Unlike consumer culture, psychoanalysis provides a space in which desire is taken seriously rather than exploited. Whereas rhetoricalism pays attention merely to egos—bodies that matter through imaginary morphogenesis—psychoanalysis pays attention to bodies that mutter, recognizing in the ego a dangerously aggressive façade (“the projection of a surface”) that obscures the subject of desire and his or her suffering. Thus we might say that while the ego matters, the body mutters.

Is “bodies that mutter” merely a figure of speech, a play on words? The difference between muttering and speaking concerns the distinction involved in a notion of desire as something *in* language but not itself linguistic. While speech comprises signs and signifiers, muttering comprises the symptom, which represents a literally unspeakable desire. It is a rhetoricalist error to assimilate hysterical symptoms to a model of language or discourse that contains no place for object-causes of desire; if symptoms were simply signs or signifiers, they would be spoken or written. It is because the speaking subject is a disembodied subject that the body mutters. Thus Edelman’s unquestioned assumption—that sexuality is written, inscribed, or otherwise textualized on the body—is mistaken in its assigning meaning and legibility, rather than ineliminable opacity, to corporeal marks. Bodies that mutter are bodies whose desire, enmeshed in the symbolic order, is struggling to be heard. The symptom signifies that that desire has not been heard, has not found its signifier. This lack of a signifier is a serious matter, for bodies that mutter are in pain; their muttering is an index of that pain. Yet their muttering also perpetuates that pain. This paradox is what Lacan means by *jouissance*, which Jacques-Alain Miller glosses as “that secret satisfaction which . . . is at the heart of the symptom and attaches the subject to his sickness.”³¹ By *muttering* I mean a form of signification that condenses and carries with it *jouissance* in a way that ordinary language cannot, since *jouissance* and language conventionally are conceived as antithetical.

Bodies that mutter reveal a relation among language, the body, *jouissance*, and object *a* that illuminates rhetoric—and thence mass culture—as a discourse of persuasion. Desire in language, propelled by

31. Jean-Paul Morel, “Interview with Jacques-Alain Miller,” trans. Dennis Porter, *Newsletter of the Freudian Field* 1, no. 1 (1987): 8.

objects *a*, perturbs language into rhetoric.³² We might modify the rhetoricalist notion that all language is performative, productive of effects, by saying that language becomes rhetorical only when it produces affects—that is, when it is imbued with desire. This distinction between language and rhetoric derives from that elaborated earlier between the rhetoricalist grounding of subjectivity in language and the psychoanalytic grounding of subjectivity in objects *a*. Lacan emphasized this distinction by differentiating signification from discourse: signification comprises a chain of signifiers, but discourse is made up of both signifiers and objects *a*.³³ As Lacan's discourse structures show, there are different ways of working within language, different ways of speaking, of relating to the Other, of desiring. As I elaborate in the next chapter, the plurality of objects *a* suggests great potential for this psychoanalytic theory of desire to conceive of sexuality outside the terms of normative heterosexuality. If the plurality of objects *a* finds distorted expression in the range of rhetorical figures that spoil the fantasy of representational transparency, then appreciating this link between rhetoric and desire should spoil rhetoricalism's subtler fantasy of "the absolute randomness of language, prior to any figuration or meaning."³⁴

The rhetoricalist model treats some version of this "absolute randomness of language" as the highly contingent foundation of discursive effects (rhetoric) and subjective affects (guilt, in de Man's example). By contrast, the psychoanalytic model treats the loss that forms objects *a* and hence the subject as foundational. This loss is initiated by language; and language in the form of rhetoric or discourse—that is, language infused with desire—tries to overcome this loss. In the face of this foundational loss, language, "resignification," and deconstruction remain ultimately inadequate. Thus although psychoanalysis works with nothing but language, psychoanalytic therapeutics are not directed toward overcoming loss. Instead, psychoanalysis is directed toward admitting desire, finding ways to inhabit desire.

32. See Ellie Ragland, "Rhetoric and Unconscious Desire," 16.

33. Lacan introduces his discourse structures (that of the master, the university, the hysteric, and the analyst) in seminar 17, *L'envers de la psychanalyse*, and develops them in seminar 20, *Encore*. For a demonstration of these discursive structures' potential for retheorizing aesthetic and gender relations, see Parveen Adams, *The Emptiness of the Image: Psychoanalysis and Sexual Differences* (London: Routledge, 1996), chap. 6.

34. Paul de Man, *Allegories of Reading: Figural Language in Rousseau, Nietzsche, Rilke, and Proust* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1979), 299.

One best inhabits desire, irrespective of sexual orientation, by acknowledging that the Other is also lacking. That is, the Other ($\emptyset$), as well as the subject ($\$$), is “barred.” To recognize what Joan Copjec calls “the *unvermögender* Other,” the Other who doesn’t have what it takes, is to recognize that loss is constitutive of subjectivity rather than the consequence of an oppressive regulatory regime that has arranged the world to one’s disadvantage.³⁵ Recognizing this distinction should not delegitimize the impact of social inequities. Instead, articulating psychoanalysis with politics depends upon differentiating between losses and deficits that represent unequal distribution of social resources, including visibility and dignity, on the one hand, and losses and deficits that are constitutive, that indicate an ineliminable zone of subjective abjection (object *a*), on the other. Despite its ostensibly antifoundationalist commitment to “contingent foundations,” rhetoricalism often smacks of conspiracy theory in its unwillingness to countenance the contingency of the real, that which disrupts meaning and, as a by-product of that disruption, leaves objects *a* in its wake. As the desiring subject’s contingent foundation, object *a* is, as Lacan suggests, “a more abject thing than you may care to consider.” Subjective desire is impossible without abjection. The mistake of the rhetoricalist account is to substantialize that abjection and thus to claim that it can be resignified.

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Psychotologic: Arguing with the Real

Butler’s commitment to theorizing subjectivity in terms of imaginary formations explains her view of identities and of foundations as being based on exclusions. Since every foundation and identity depends on its “constitutive outside,” all foundations are necessarily contingent and therefore subject to critique and—at least in theory—resignification. Grasping the Lacanian principle that symbolic and real orders are mutually exclusive yet also mutually dependent, Butler views the real as open to interrogation. Hence the important chapter in *Bodies That Matter* titled “Arguing with the Real.” In fact, this chapter stages an argument with Slavoj Žižek and with what Butler takes to be his account of the real. I want to engage the Butler-Žižek debate here because it frames in more overtly political terms the question of what limits the rhetoricalization

35. Copjec, *Read My Desire*, chap. 6.

of sexuality. My critique of rhetoricalism is, in the end, a political critique, because I see a certain version of psychoanalysis as offering a more radical and workable sexual politics than anything Butler's model promises.

To state my disagreement with Butler in its strongest terms, let me just say that in her rhetoricalizing of psychosis, in "Arguing with the Real," Butler's argument and the politics it implies are psychotic. I hope I will not be misunderstood as suggesting that Judith Butler herself is psychotic; I'm concerned instead with the logic of her argument and its implications for sexual politics. Butler's project to "resignify" the symbolic order by means of psychosis is not political but psychotic. Her turn to psychosis for a politics of sexuality indicates the impasse of Butler's antinormativism and marks the dead-end limits of her thoroughgoing suspicion of all norms.³⁶

Butler claims that "[t]he rallying force of politics is its implicit promise of the possibility of a livable and speakable psychosis. Politics holds out the promise of the manageability of unspeakable loss" (209). I have suggested why the "unspeakable loss" immaterialized in object *a* cannot be overcome, and that without this constitutive loss, desire simply would not exist. The "promise of the manageability of unspeakable loss" perpetuates the common fantasy of a world without desire, perhaps even a world without psychoanalysis. To suggest that politics enables "a livable and speakable psychosis," or to advocate "a politically enabling deployment of psychotic speech" (280), nullifies both psychosis and politics by refusing to distinguish between them.

If the category of psychosis represents nothing more than an ideological construction that excludes certain social groups—principally women and queers—by making them the abject real that shores up compulsory heterosexuality, one then must ask exactly what ails clinically diagnosed psychotic patients beyond the interpellation of a normatively deployed diagnosis. A discursive idealism blinds this rhetoricalist position to the seriousness of its argument's implications: by declining

36. I refer here to Amanda Anderson's Habermasian critique of Butler, in "Debatable Performances: Restaging Contentious Feminisms," *Social Text* 54, vol. 16, no. 1 (1998): 1–24. Anderson argues that Butler fails to distinguish between evaluative norms and normalizing norms, thereby foreclosing political possibilities for evaluative norms in feminist and queer praxis. Butler's turn to psychosis as a political model illustrates Anderson's argument and throws into dramatic relief just how politically efficacious is Butler's unexamined jettisoning of evaluative norms.

to acknowledge any legitimate psychosis beyond its disciplinary mobilization (no original apart from its normative citation), Butler's argument euphemizes psychotic suffering as the consequence merely of hegemonic misnaming. If psychosis represents nothing more than a diagnostic category produced and enforced by heterosexism's regulatory regime, mental illness would be curable through *political* resignifications, according to Butler's model. This logic returns us to the 1960s antipsychiatry of David Cooper and R. D. Laing, which implied that even the most serious forms of psychic suffering are amenable to political redemption, since society and its regulatory norms alone are responsible for driving people mad. What leads Butler to this point of maintaining that there is a political purchase to psychotic speech?

Psychotic utterances, crazy though they may sound, are formulated according to a distinct logic, what we may call psychotologic, which is traceable through the use of psychorhetoric. As I suggested above, Lacan shifted the psychoanalytic understanding and treatment of psychosis by conceptualizing this most serious form of psychic suffering in rhetorical terms—that is, in terms of linguistic disorder. Conceiving of psychosis as a specific structural relation between symbolic and real orders, Lacan questioned the psychoanalytic orthodoxy that maintained psychosis was untreatable via the talking cure. In challenging this orthodoxy, Lacan also discredited the conventional fear that engaging the psychotic's symbolic economy through the discursive link of a psychoanalytic encounter necessarily would make the analyst psychotic too. In other words, he spoke to the fear that entering the psychotic's world via the talking cure would send the doctor mad.

There are various ways of engaging psychotologic—some analytic, some crazy, and some neither analytic nor crazy but simply failing to engage. Psychotologic often produces arguments of startling rigor, as Freud discovered with President Schreber, whose impressive erudition confirms, among other things, that Lacan's definition of psychosis as a foreclosure of part of the symbolic order should not imply an equation between psychosis and silence or gobbledygook. Far from being beyond or outside discourse, psychotologic regularly elaborates an intricate and brilliant—if bizarre—discourse of its own. As psychoanalyst Micheline Enriquez comments, psychotic discourse “very often presents this double aspect of being at once a mad delusional discourse outside reason,

and at the same time a passionate and often pertinent denunciation of disorders and evils 'glaring within reality.'"³⁷ I want here to disentangle the steps that lead Butler to promote a form of discursive psychosis as a viable political option.

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The first step to note in her argument with the real is Butler's synecdochic sleight of hand that makes Slavoj Žižek stand for Jacques Lacan and psychoanalysis in general. Žižek is one of the most important contemporary psychoanalytic theorists; his work has repoliticized psychoanalysis and shown Lacan's enormous potential for cultural studies. But Žižek's work increases, not diminishes, our responsibility to read Lacan. Working with and against a number of psychoanalytically oriented theorists—Žižek, Laclau and Mouffe, Michael Walsh—Butler's argument relies on secondary sources rather than on Lacan's own texts. Symptomatic of this problem is the fact that, in a long, dense chapter ostensibly devoted to a Lacanian concept, Butler quotes Lacan barely more than once. She constructs an elaborate argument based on only a shred of direct evidence. Her reliance on secondary sources gives the lie to Butler's claim that her argument with the real represents "an effort to underscore the limitations of psychoanalysis when its founding prohibitions and their heterosexualizing injunctions are taken to be invariant" (189). While the Lacanian real undoubtedly raises the question of limits and limitations, Butler's argument underscores nothing so much as the limitations of a certain fantasy about Žižek as theorist of the political.

Should we interpret Butler's refusal to engage Lacan directly as simply a failure of rigor in a critic consistently noted for rigorousness? Since Butler's chapter is full of parapraxes involving persistent misquotation and mischaracterization of Žižek, her reliance on secondary sources perhaps should be read as a sign of something more than intellectual laziness.³⁸ If, as Butler suggests for Žižek, the Lacanian real is embodied

37. Micheline Enriquez, "Paranoiac Fantasies: Sexual Difference, Homosexuality, Law of the Father," trans. Yifat Hachamovitch and Béatrice Loeffel, in *Psychosis and Sexual Identity: Toward a Post-analytic View of the Schreber Case*, ed. David B. Allison, Prado de Oliveira, Mark S. Roberts, and Allen S. Weiss (Albany: SUNY Press, 1988), 119.

38. Trivial in themselves, the cumulative effect of these parapraxes is serious, suggesting a systemic problem rather than merely superficial or local accidents. For more on Butler's parapraxes, see n. 15 above. In *The Sublime Object*, Žižek describes the symptom as "a stain which cannot be included in the circuit of discourse" (75); in *Bodies That Matter* this description is glossed and misquoted as "the feminine as a 'stain,' 'outside the circuit of discourse' (75)" (Butler, 196). Žižek characterizes Foucault (admittedly somewhat oddly) as one "fascinated by marginal lifestyles con-

by queerness and the feminine, then this characterization might prompt the question of what functions as the real in Butler's psychic economy. I have little interest in defending Žižek. However, in my reading of "Arguing with the Real" I would like to avoid as much as possible psychologizing Butler in the way that her reading of Žižek psychologizes him. I am interested more in the logic of Butler's argument—a logic that, contra rhetoricalism, I take to be irreducible to the rhetoric in which it is formulated. To reduce logic to rhetoric, or to suggest that no logic exists apart from that of rhetoric, is an imaginary fallacy that bespeaks a refusal to recognize the nonrhetorical logic of the real. Hence my disinclination, in this chapter, to discuss the relation between sexuality and rhetoric in terms of either "a rhetoric of sexuality" or "a sexuality of rhetoric," since both these approaches collapse sexuality into rhetoric in a way that forecloses desire.

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Given this qualification, a rhetorical analysis of Butler's argument might begin by investigating her strategic use of erotema, the form of rhetorical questioning that implies an answer and so produces an assertion by indirect means. Butler's arguments proceed by posing series of questions whose answers subsequently are assumed as if they were the product of logical argumentation rather than the product of insistent erotema. For example:

structing their particular mode of subjectivity" (2), which Butler quotes as ". . . constructing their own mode of subjectivity" (206; emphasis added). In the passage from *Sublime Object* (99) that Butler provides in indented quotation (208), two extra commas are introduced into the quotation. Let me provide one final quotation of Butler quoting Žižek's *Sublime Object* and indicate her lapses in brackets:

In Žižek's words, "what is overlooked, at least in the standard version of anti-descriptivism, is that this guaranteeing the identity of an object in all counterfactual situations—through a change of all its descriptive features [Butler omitted a second dash here] is *the retroactive effect of naming itself*: it is the name itself, the signifier, which supports the identity of the object" ([Butler omitted "94—"] 95) . . . Žižek writes, "That 'surplus' in the object which stays the same in all possible worlds is 'something in it more than itself', that is to say the Lacanian *petit objet o* [Žižek had the correct phrase, "*objet petit a*"]: we search in vain for it in positive reality because it has no positive consistency—because it is just an objectification of a void, [Butler omitted "of"] a discontinuity opened in reality by the emergence of the signifier" (95) (*Bodies That Matter*, 216–17).

Needless to say, Butler makes no attempt to assimilate the literally unspeakable *objet petit a* to her argument. In a footnote Butler cites Žižek's book *For They Know Not What They Do*, providing a bibliographical reference omitting the book's subtitle (*Enjoyment as a Political Factor*) and alluding to Žižek's book *Looking Awry: An Introduction to Jacques Lacan through Popular Culture* as published by MIT Press in Boston (rather than Cambridge) (*Bodies That Matter*, 279 n. 14). Together with the more serious misunderstandings of the *spirit* of the Lacanian argument, these examples—each apparently trivial—indicate a constitutive inability to get right anything connected with Žižek's argument or the *letter* of his text.

How might those ostensibly constitutive exclusions be rendered less permanent, more dynamic? How might the excluded return, not as psychosis or the figure of the psychotic within politics, but as that which has been rendered mute, foreclosed from the domain of political signification? How and where is social content attributed to the site of the “real,” and then positioned as the unspeakable? Is there not a difference between a theory that asserts that, in principle, every discourse operates through exclusion and a theory that attributes to that “outside” specific social and sexual positions? To the extent that a specific use of psychoanalysis works to foreclose certain social and sexual positions from the domain of intelligibility—and for all time—psychoanalysis appears to work in the service of the normativizing law that it interrogates. How might such socially saturated domains of exclusion be recast from their status as “constitutive” to beings who might be said to matter? (189)

The theory that attributes to the real specific social and sexual positions is Butler’s own, since Lacan characterizes the real as asubstantial, unsexed and ungendered. Constructing a Slovenian straw man, Butler proceeds to misrecognize this rhetorical construction and claim that “[t]he production of the *unsymbolizable*, the unspeakable, the illegible is also always a strategy of social abjection” (190). From this mistaken assumption, produced through erotema, Butler proceeds to deconstruct this “strategy of social abjection” in the name of “beings who might be said to matter.”

Butler’s characterization of the real as involving “a strategy of social abjection” makes the real far more intransigent and uncompromising than Lacan conceives it. By describing the real in structural rather than substantive terms, Lacan theorizes the real as a variable limit to the speakable and the thinkable. This distinction is politically significant because it implies that although a homophobic culture may figure gay sex, for example, as unspeakable, that figuration is culturally and historically produced rather than necessary or inevitable. The difference between rhetoricalism and psychoanalysis is that although both emphasize the constitutive, determining, and transformative power of language, psychoanalysis recognizes also the constitutive inability of language to say everything. Hence politicizing the real entails distinguishing limits that are amenable to change (limitable limits) from real limits (illimitable limits), limits that won’t budge. To substantialize limits—for example,

in the form of acceptable sexual practices—makes those limits ideological, the product of regulatory norms. But to generalize from this and assume that all limits are ideological, rather than real and therefore unavoidable, leads to the psychotic conviction that words never fail and that certain kinds of satisfaction can be achieved without limit.

Hallucinating a straw man in which it urges conviction through the rhetorical trope of erotema, Butler's argument also rehearses a series of cultural clichés—a collection of moribund metaphors or straw figures—concerning psychoanalysis. These clichés about psychoanalysis take the following forms: that psychoanalysis is a theory of the self (confusion of subject and ego); that psychoanalysis is universalizing and ahistorical (confusion about the relation between history and the real); that the psychoanalytic category of the real designates reality or real things (confusion of substance and structure); that Lacan misogynistically declared women don't exist (confusion of *La femme* and women); that Freud discovered child abuse, then invented the seduction theory as a cover-up (confusion of fantasy and reality). Although Butler resists trotting out Jeffrey Masson's line on seduction, this last cultural cliché derives from the criticism, which she repeats, that psychoanalysis is "ahistorical and universalistic" (190). The common academic charge that psychoanalysis is ahistorical is connected to Masson's more specific charges against Freud by the assumption that if psychoanalysis were sufficiently attentive to historical realities, especially realities involving power disequilibriums, then it would not have to euphemize abuses of power (incest) in terms of universal fantasy (seduction).

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Butler rehearses this caricature of psychoanalysis as universalizing and ahistorical by misquoting and then interpreting the following sentence from Žižek: "All the different attempts [efforts (Butler, 201)] to attach this phenomenon to a concrete image ('Holocaust,' 'Gulag' . . .), to reduce it to a product of a concrete social order (Fascism, Stalinism . . .)—what are they if not so many attempts to elude the fact that we are dealing here with the 'real' of our civilization which returns as the same traumatic kernel in all social systems?"³⁹ Butler glosses Žižek's sentence thus:

The effect of this citation is to claim that each of these social formations: the family, concentration camps, the Gulag, instantiate

39. Slavoj Žižek, *The Sublime Object of Ideology* (New York: Verso, 1989), 50.

the same trauma, and that what is historically textured about each of these sites of trauma is itself indifferent to and ontologically distinct from the lost and hidden referent that is their traumatic status. They are by virtue of this “same traumatic kernel” equivalent to one another as traumas, and what is historical and what is traumatic are made absolutely distinct; indeed, the historical becomes what is most indifferent to the question of trauma. (202)

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I think Žižek is arguing not that traumas are historically or ontologically equivalent, but that the Lacanian concept of trauma enables a different kind of historical understanding. Trauma offers a different perspective on historicity by showing—as Fredric Jameson glosses this Lacanian position—“that history is *not* a text, not a narrative, master or otherwise, but that, as an absent cause, it is inaccessible to us except in textual form, and that our approach to it and to the Real itself necessarily passes through its prior textualization.”⁴⁰ Far from making “what is historical and what is traumatic . . . absolutely distinct,” Žižek suggests that history and trauma can be conceptualized only in relation to each other.

Butler’s invoking “the lost and hidden referent” in the passage above points to another common point of confusion—confusing fantasy and reality, or, to put it slightly differently, confusing psychic reality with referentiality. Butler’s argument with the real depends upon her substantializing the real as reference—that is, her attributing a content to that zone of psychic negativity that Lacan calls the real. Butler does this by persistently referring to “Žižek’s use of the Lacanian ‘real’ to establish the permanent recalcitrance of the referent to symbolization” (208).⁴¹ Her confusing the real with referentiality connects to Butler’s confusing subject and ego, for she initially characterizes the Lacanian position thus: “Following Lacan, Žižek argues that the ‘subject’ is produced in language through an act of foreclosure (*Verwerfung*)” (189–90). Conceptually, this is complete nonsense. Unsupported by any citation or even allusion to a particular psychoanalytic text, Butler’s claim misrecognizes as a theory of subject formation Lacan’s explanation of psychosis as following from foreclosure of the Names-of-the-Father, a process I de-

40. Fredric Jameson, *The Political Unconscious: Narrative as a Socially Symbolic Act* (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1981), 35; original emphasis.

41. This mischaracterization of the real as referentiality is repeated throughout Butler’s chapter (207, 208, 209, 215, and 217).

scribed in chapter 3. In effect, Butler is saying that subject formation is a psychotic process. Whether or not she actually believes that, it is hardly fair to characterize Lacan or Žižek as having made such a claim. Lacan argues instead that the subject, as subject of the unconscious, is produced through repression (*Verdrängung*).

Taken together, these common points of confusion—between real and referent, between subject and ego—enable Butler to conclude that performativity can overcome the real: “Insofar as performatives are their own *referent*, they appear both to signify and to refer and hence to overcome the divide between referent and signification that is produced and sustained at the level of foreclosure” (209; original emphasis). Even more strangely, Butler then proposes performativity as that which might overcome referentiality, as if the fact that words refer to things in the world were in itself a kind of conspiracy: “If referentiality is itself the effect of a policing of the linguistic constraints on proper usage, then the possibility of referentiality is contested by the catachrestic use of speech that insists on using proper names improperly” (217–18).⁴² Confusing the real with referentiality, and foreclosure with repression, Butler furthermore conflates *La femme* with women, arguing that women are effectively policed into the real by Lacan and thus excluded from political intelligibility: “if women are positioned as that which cannot exist, as that which is barred from existence by the law of the father, then there is a conflation of women with that foreclosed existence, that lost referent, that is surely as pernicious as any form of ontological essentialism” (218–19). A pernicious conflation indeed, one that derives from Butler’s psychotologic itself, since it is not “the law of the father” that bars existence, just as foreclosure does not produce a “lost referent.”⁴³

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42. As an antifoundational foundation, catachresis may be seen as the paradoxically stabilized as trope of queerness for rhetoricalist accounts, in that Edelman also treats catachresis as centrally significant for his theory of nonnormative sexuality. By interpreting catachresis as the sign of a fault line in the sexual ideology that esteems heterosexuality as natural and original while repressing homosexuality as artificial and derivative, Edelman argues that

catachresis, though traditionally construed as aberrant or abusive, as the very trope of “mis-naming,” is actually the fundamental principle of language and thus of naming itself. I want to propose that the negotiation between what gets constructed as aberrant and what gets constructed as “natural” in this reading of catachresis and the positing of “face,” is implicated in, and bears crucially upon, the logic through which homosexuality takes cognitive shape in the modern West. (*Homographesis*, 232)

43. Although it is not possible to rehearse here Lacan’s argument concerning *The Woman*, we might recall his remark that “Woman does not exist. There are women, but Woman is a dream of men.” See Lacan, “Geneva Lecture on the Symptom,” trans. Russell Grigg, *Analysis* 1 (1989): 17.

This quite astonishing sequence of conflations, confusions, mischaracterizations, and misquotations leads Butler to characterize Žižek's *The Sublime Object of Ideology* as "a text that defends the trauma of the real, defends the threat of psychosis that the real delivers . . . over and against a different kind of threat . . . that [Žižek's] text proliferates . . . by investing it in a variety of social positions" identified with women, feminism, homosexuality, sadomasochism, and poststructuralism (206). Allegedly aligned with the real by Žižek or Lacan, these "social positions" are constructed psychoanalytically as psychotic, according to Butler. Hence political contestation of women's and queers' social abjection should begin with "a politically enabling deployment of psychotic speech" (280).

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In 1975, Lacan publicly corrected a misconception generated by the title of his 1932 doctoral thesis, "De la psychose paranoïaque dans ses rapports avec la personnalité," maintaining that there is no *relation* between paranoid psychosis and the personality (or ego) because they are effectively the same thing.⁴⁴ Since Butler's logic stems from a theory of subjectivity grounded in the ego, perhaps we could extend Lacan's point by saying that there is no "politically enabling deployment of psychotic speech," because in the rhetoricalist model all politics—by virtue of its imaginization—is virtually psychotic. My argument against rhetoricalism dispenses not with all politics, but with the paranoid style of queer politics. One alternative to the paranoid style is a politics in which desire really matters, and in the next chapter I lay out a different political approach based on queer desire.

44. Jacques Lacan, "Le sinthôme," *Ornicar?* 7 (1976): 7.